

Hierodeacon Panteleimon (Adzhindzhal)

PROJECT

«To Christians of the Third Millennium»

Reflections of an Abkhaz Exile

Christ bin.

Contents:

Contents

Part I. An Essay in Applied Metaphysics of the Subject

An Essay in Applied Metaphysics of the Subject	5
Prolegomena	36

Part II. To Christians of the Third Millennium

The Origin. Once Primordial	39
On the Nature of Faith	50
Toward a Metaphysics of the Person	64
The Language of God	77
The Functionality of the Church	84
Toward an Ontology of the Logos	98
Faith as Competence	117
The Church as the Infrastructure of the Formation of Personal Eschatology	133

Appendices

The Metaphysics of the CTT Project (“To Christians of the Third Millennium”)	140
Terminological Commentary on the Project “To Christians of the Third Millennium”	157
Key Terms of the Project “To Christians of the Third Millennium”	165

Afterword	166
-----------------	-----

Translated into English with the help of ChatGPT (GPT-5, OpenAI).

· XTT I — DOI (all versions): 10.5281/zenodo.18940871

Part I.

An Essay in Applied Metaphysics of the Subject

An Essay in the Applied Metaphysics of the Subject

Introduction

This work offers an essay in the applied metaphysics of the subject. This definition requires clarification, since each of its constituent terms can easily be misunderstood.

1. What This Book Is About

This book is not a theological treatise in the traditional sense, although its primary concern is the conditions of possibility of Christian faith as a mode of being. Nor does it claim the status of a philosophical system, even though it employs philosophical language and method. Its genre may be defined as an ontological propaedeutic: it does not provide ready-made answers, but seeks to disclose a new perspective that would make it possible to renew Christianity's former projective force.

The fundamental intuition of this work is simple and severe: Christianity has, to a large extent, lost its ontological initiative. Increasingly, it describes reality in a language borrowed from external systems—politics, psychology, morality, ideology, or culture—and ever more rarely proceeds from its own vision of the world. As a result, faith ceases to be the ground of being and becomes one sphere of life among others: an emotional state, a cultural identity, or a moral sensibility.

The question posed by this work is ontological, not merely theological: does there exist today a form of subject capable of proceeding from truth as the ground of its own existence? In other words—is faith possible not as belonging, but as an authentic mode of being?

2. What Is Meant by the Subject

Within the framework of this work, the subject is not a psychological function, not an abstract center of consciousness, and not a social role. The subject is defined here as a form of being that arises where a human being makes the decision to proceed from the recognition of reality and to remain in accordance with it even under internal and external resistance.

Subjecthood is not given to the human being automatically. The claim of this work is to show that Christianity itself constitutes the ultimate form of ontological reorientation that makes subjecthood possible.

3. What Is Meant by Applied Metaphysics

Applied metaphysics in this book is not a speculative discipline, but a practical instrument for working with the subject. It is an inquiry into—and a verification of—the metaphysical presuppositions from which a human being in fact perceives reality and constructs the trajectory of their life.

As long as these presuppositions remain unexamined, inherited, or imposed, the human being lives in a derivative mode, reproducing descriptions of the world that are not their own. Applied metaphysics sets itself the task of bringing these foundations to light, subjecting them to radical examination and re-evaluation. In the language of classical theology, this process is closest to repentance—not as a moral

experience of guilt, but as a radical transformation of the very foundations of perception and existence.

4. On the Limits of Philosophical Discourse

It is important to define the limits of this work from the outset. No philosophical text is capable of producing subjectivity, nor can it replace the act of faith. No system of concepts can algorithmize the decision a human being makes beyond the bounds of logic as a closed system.

The task of this book is different: to bring false and derivative foundations to complete transparency, to render them unbearable for the subject itself, and thereby to clear the space for a decision that can no longer be deferred. The book does not offer a “method” for attaining subjectivity—it merely leads to the point at which evasion of the question becomes impossible.

5. On the Language of This Work

The language of this book is philosophical prose. It cannot be reduced either to academic apparatus or to publicistic writing, since its subject demands precision without losing contact with existential reality.

If Christianity is to regain its power as that which determines the mode of existence, it must cease to live from borrowed descriptions of the world. It must learn to look at reality with its own eyes, to speak in its own language, and to assume the full weight of its ontological claim. This is precisely the intention of the present work.

Chapter 1. Reality

Reality as the Horizon of Existence

1. The Gift of Reality

The primordial condition of human existence is reality, which is not produced by the human being and is not derived from their consciousness. The human being appears in a world that already exists prior to them, does not depend on them, and is not determined by them. They do not create the fundamental structures of being, but find themselves within what is already given.

In this sense, reality may be understood as a gift of existence. A gift means that the human being receives the world not as their own product, but as a condition that precedes them. However, the gift does not remain a neutral fact. It demands a response. In receiving reality, the human being inevitably finds themselves before the question of how they will relate to it: whether they will accept it as the ground of their existence or attempt to replace it with their own constructions.

It is precisely here that the space of subjecthood opens.

2. Reality as Horizon

Reality is not reducible to a collection of separate objects, events, or impressions. It constitutes a more fundamental dimension of human existence—a horizon within which the human being perceives the world, thinks, and acts.

The horizon does not determine the content of each individual experience, but the conditions of its possibility. It defines the limits of the space within which the human being is capable of orientation, of distinguishing the significant from the insignificant, the possible from the impossible. Therefore, the human being never encounters reality as something absolutely external to themselves. They are always already within it and exist within the horizon it sets.

3. Interiorized Reality

Although the human being does not create reality as such, they constantly form its internal model. In the process of perception, thinking, memory, social interaction, and anticipation of the future, what may be called interiorized reality takes shape.

Interiorized reality is the internal representation of the world through which the human being orients themselves in actuality. It includes the perception of things, conceptions of what is significant, evaluations, expectations, fears, goals, and images of the future. It is through this internal model that the human being makes decisions and constructs the trajectory of their life.

However, interiorized reality is not identical with reality itself. It is always a partial appropriation of it and therefore may either approximate the real or diverge from it.

It may be said that interiorized reality performs a navigational function. The human being does not act directly in reality, but through a structure of orientation that enables them to distinguish the significant from the insignificant, the possible from the impossible, the real from the illusory.

In this sense, every human action is navigation—a relating of oneself to reality through its interiorized form.

4. Divergence and Fiction

Between reality and its interiorized form there always exists the possibility of divergence. This divergence may arise from the limits of perception, the pressure of environment, cultural patterns, psychological defenses, or a conscious withdrawal from what appears undesirable or painful.

When the internal representation of the world ceases to correspond to the world itself, fiction arises. Fiction is not merely an error of knowledge, but a distinct mode of existence in which the human being is oriented not toward reality, but toward its distorted image. Outwardly, life may retain coherence: the human being continues to act, to choose, to make plans, to enter into relationships. However, their actions increasingly fail to correspond to the actual state of affairs.

For this reason, fiction has not only an epistemic, but also an ontological significance. It alters the very mode of human existence.

5. Truth as the Recognition of Reality

The problem of divergence between reality and its interiorized form leads to the question of truth. Within the framework of this work, truth is understood not as the formal correspondence of a statement to a fact, but as a deeper act of recognition of reality.

Truth arises where the human being consents to proceed in their actions from what is real, rather than from what is convenient, habitual, or psychologically advantageous. Therefore, truth is not only a characteristic of thinking, but also a characteristic of existence. It determines the mode of the subject's relation to the world.

In this sense, truth has an ontological character. It does not merely say something about reality, but establishes the form of the human being's presence in reality.

6. Reality and Decision

The recognition of reality does not occur automatically. The human being is capable both of accepting reality and of evading it. In many cases, reality demands the renunciation of comfortable illusions, the revision of established conceptions, the acknowledgment of one's own insufficiency, or the acceptance of decisions bound up with risk and loss.

Therefore, the relation to reality always contains a moment of decision. The human being must not only see something, but also consent to live from what has been seen. It is precisely at this point that the difference between knowledge as information and recognition as the ground of existence becomes evident.

The decision to proceed from the recognition of reality constitutes the first ontologically significant act of subjectivity.

7. The Subject and the Horizon of Reality

The subject does not arise as a mere bearer of consciousness, but as a form of being that accepts reality as the ground of action. It is not the one who simply perceives the world who is the subject, but the one who decides to relate their existence to reality.

This decision opens a specific space of human action. Within it, actions cease to be merely reactions to circumstances and become expressions of a relation to the real.

Within this space, two levels of horizon may be distinguished. If the human being acts within the limits of the immediately given situation, one may speak of an ontic horizon. It includes events, circumstances, social structures, psychological states, and concrete tasks.

However, the human being is capable of going beyond the immediate situation. When they relate particular facts to broader grounds, meanings, and to the structure of being as a whole, their horizon becomes ontological. Then action is determined not only by current circumstances, but also by an understanding of what is real in a deeper sense.

It is precisely here that the possibility of ontological action opens.

8. Reality as the Condition of Freedom

At first glance, it may seem that the recognition of reality limits freedom, since it requires one to reckon with what does not depend on the subject. In fact, the opposite is true. Freedom is possible only where there is reality in relation to which the human being can make decisions.

If reality dissolves into an endless play of interpretations, the very possibility of genuine choice disappears. What remains is only movement within constructions that have no necessary relation to the actual. Freedom degenerates into a shifting between options within fiction.

Therefore, the recognition of reality does not destroy freedom, but makes it possible. Only where there is something independent of the subject can the subject take a position, make a decision, and bear responsibility for it.

9. Reality and Participation

The subject does not create reality and is not its source. But they are capable of accepting it and acting in accordance with it. In this sense, the subject does not produce being, but participates in its disclosure.

This participation constitutes the essence of subjectivity. The human being becomes a subject not when they replace reality with themselves, but when they take upon themselves the labor of correspondence to the real. The more their existence is determined by this correspondence, the more it exits the mode of fiction and enters the space of truth.

Chapter 2. The Subject

The Subject as a Form of Being

1. The Problem of Defining the Subject

The subject cannot be defined through functions, capacities, or processes. In this case, it inevitably becomes derivative—an element of psychological, social, or cultural structures—and thereby loses its ontological status.

For this reason, the subject must be considered not as a function, but as a form of being. It is determined not by what occurs in consciousness, but by the manner in which the human being exists in relation to reality.

The subject is a form of being capable of founding its position in relation to reality.

Foundation means the taking upon oneself of the ground of one's own existence.

2. The Act of Foundation

(the exit from derivative existence)

In order to genuinely acquire a subject-position, the human being must, at a certain moment, step out of the inertia of being and interrupt the mode of existence in which their life is determined by external conditions, social structures, and unreflected impulses. This transition is neither a psychological decision nor merely an act of self-reflection. It is an ontological event in which the human being, for the first time, ceases to derive their existence from external grounds and assumes the task of grounding their own being.

Within the framework of this study, this process is designated as the act of foundation.

The act of foundation means that the subject begins to derive their existence from their own ontological horizon. It involves taking upon oneself the burden of the ground—the responsibility for that from which and for the sake of which one's existence is carried out. Prior to the act of foundation, the human being exists in a derivative mode. By derivativity, in this context, is meant a condition in which the subject's grounds do not possess their own ontological status, but are borrowed from external structures. In this case, the subject exists not from its own ground, but as a function of external determinations, which inevitably leads to a reduction of interiorized reality. As a result, their life is determined by what is given from the outside—culture, environment, circumstances, psychological mechanisms. In this mode, they are not the source of their own position, but merely reproduce already existing structures.

The act of foundation breaks this dependence. The subject ceases to be a function of external forces and becomes the instance from which its ontological position is determined.

It is precisely in this act that the human being steps beyond the bounds of ordinary living nature. Their existence ceases to be fully embedded in the chain of natural causes and reactions and, for the first time, acquires the character of self-grounded being. In this sense, one may speak of the acquisition of the status of "human being" in the strictly ontological meaning of this word.

However, the act of foundation does not complete the formation of the subject, but only opens its possibility. It establishes the point from which further

development becomes possible—the choice of a subject-position, self-determination, the decolonization of the personality, and the formation of ontological autonomy.

At the same time, it must be emphasized that the act of foundation itself does not yet secure the fullness of subjectivity. It merely breaks derivative existence, but does not guarantee the stability of the new position. The subject must form ontological autonomy—the capacity to sustain its own ground and not return to external sources of determination. This autonomy cannot be partial or formal in character. It requires radicalization—the capacity to think and project one's existence as self-grounded.

If this process is not carried through to its limit—that is, if it does not reach the level of full ontological autonomy—the subject inevitably reproduces derivativity at a new level, incorporating it into the forms of its own autonomy. In this case, all subsequent forms of self-determination, including an appeal to ultimate grounds of being, retain a simulacral character.

Thus, the act of foundation should be understood as the beginning of a process leading to the formation of ontological autonomy. The quality of the subject's ontology is determined by the dimensionality of this autonomy.

3. Foundation (Position)

Within the framework of this conception, it is necessary to distinguish two levels of foundation. In this section, foundation is understood as the act of actualizing the subject-position, distinct from the primary act of foundation as the exit from derivative existence. It occurs when the human being makes the decision to proceed not from emotions, social expectations, and habitual patterns of behavior, but from what they recognize as real and true.

Thus, foundation constitutes an act of taking responsibility for one's relation to reality. It is precisely this act that actualizes the subject-position, makes it operative, and transfers it from a potential state into an actual one.

4. Ontological Position

Subjecthood is not a permanent property of the human being. It constitutes an ontological position. An ontological position is the manner in which the human being organizes their relation to reality. Within the ontology of the subject, two basic modes of existence may be distinguished: the subject-position and the inertial position.

5. The Subject-Position

In the subject-position, the human being accepts reality as the ground of their actions. They orient themselves toward what they take to be true, even if this is bound up with certain difficulties or risks. The subject-position presupposes the capacity to recognize reality, to make decisions, and to bear responsibility. Such a position requires a certain internal structure of the personality. It is impossible without the capacity to endure the tension that arises in the making of decisions.

6. The Inertial Position

Alongside the subject-position, there exists another mode of human existence. It may be called the inertial position. In this mode, the human being acts primarily

within the framework of habits, social roles, and the expectations of the surrounding environment. The inertial position does not necessarily imply passivity. The human being may be active, energetic, and even successful. However, their actions are not the result of the independent grounding of a position. They merely reproduce already existing structures.

7. The Freedom of the Subject

In what does the freedom of the subject consist? The freedom of the subject is not reducible to the possibility of choosing between different options of behavior. The mere possibility of choice is not yet a sign of freedom, since it may be realized within a pre-given horizon that the subject does not control.

The freedom of the subject consists in the capacity to change the horizons of being within which this choice acquires meaning at all. The subject is free insofar as they are capable of stepping beyond the given conditions of existence and transitioning to other grounds from which their relation to reality is determined. They are free to the extent that they are capable of determining the framework of their own personal project.

The mechanism of this transition—the redefinition of the framework—is the verification of metaphysics. By metaphysics, in this context, is meant the totality of presuppositions through which the subject perceives and interprets reality. These presuppositions may be unreflected, inherited, or imposed by external structures; in this case, they limit the ontological horizon of the subject.

The verification of metaphysics means the capacity of the subject to subject these grounds to examination, to identify those that are derivative in character and therefore structurally lead to a reduction of reality, and to renounce them. As a result, a transformation of metaphysics occurs, which leads to a transformation of the ontological horizon.

In the theological dimension, this process may be designated as repentance. Repentance, in this case, should be understood not as a moral experience or a feeling of guilt, but as a radical transformation of the grounds from which the subject perceives reality. This transformation affects the very mode of relation to being and opens the possibility of a transition to another horizon.

Thus, the freedom of the subject constitutes a process in which, through the verification of metaphysics, a shift of the horizons of being is effected. At the same time, freedom presupposes not only the capacity to transition between horizons, but also the capacity to sustain the new horizon as one's own ground.

Freedom is determined not only by the presence of choice, but also by the dimensionality of the ontological horizon within which this choice is carried out. This dimensionality is determined by the volume of reality that the subject is capable of interiorizing and sustaining without reduction.

The greater the volume of reality the subject is capable of sustaining, the higher their freedom. Conversely, the reduction of reality—the exclusion of its complex or contradictory aspects—leads to a decrease in the dimensionality of freedom.

One of the parameters of the expansion of freedom is ontological etherification. By etherification, in this work, is meant the transition of the subject to a more capacious horizon of being. This transition does not signify a withdrawal from reality

or its abstract “spiritualization.” On the contrary, it signifies an increased capacity of the subject to perceive and sustain reality in its greater fullness and complexity.

In this sense, etherification may be interpreted through an analogy with the trophic chain. In biology, the transition to the next level of the trophic chain is accompanied by an increasing complexity of the organism’s structure, as well as by a change in the nature of the resources it consumes and processes—both quantitatively and qualitatively.

Analogously, at the ontological level, the transition to a higher horizon signifies a change in the level of assimilation of reality. The subject becomes capable of interiorizing more complex forms of being and sustaining a broader spectrum of ontological contents.

At the same time, this analogy is purely structural in character and does not imply a reduction of ontological processes to biological ones.

Thus, the freedom of the subject is measured not only by the number of available options, but also by the volume of reality the subject is capable of interiorizing, and by the scale of the horizon within which they are capable of acting. Freedom is the capacity to transition between horizons of being and to sustain them as one’s own ground, effected through the verification of metaphysics and expressed in the expansion of the ontological capacity of the subject.

8. Ontological Tension

Ontological tension arises when the human being finds themselves before the necessity of making a decision without being able to rely fully either on social norms or on psychological impulses. Former grounds prove insufficient; new ones have not yet been formed. The subject finds themselves in a state of rupture between inertia and the necessity of self-grounding.

This state is not accidental or situational. It belongs to the very structure of subjecthood and functions as a necessary condition of its emergence. Ontological tension does not generate freedom, but constitutes the condition of its actualization: freedom is disclosed not in a choice between ready-made alternatives, but in a situation in which the subject is compelled to become the source of their own ground.

Axiom:

The subject exists only where ontological tension is sustained. Withdrawal from tension is the loss of subjectivity.

Withdrawal may take various forms: adaptation to existing norms, rationalization, the shifting of responsibility, the imitation of choice. All these forms share one structure—the refusal of self-grounding.

Thus, ontological tension constitutes a limit situation in which not the quality of the subject, but the very fact of its existence, is determined. In this situation, the subject either sustains the tension and thereby exists, or withdraws from it and ceases to be a subject.

Author’s remark.

The term “ontological tension” was formulated by the author in 1993 during the war of liberation of the Abkhaz people against Georgian intervention forces. The author

used this term to describe the condition of the Abkhaz ethnos undergoing an existential threat at that time.

9. The Attempt and Failure of Autonomy

The subject that arises in ontological tension cannot limit itself to the mere fact of sustaining it. It is obliged to carry its ontological claim to the fullness of autonomous realization.

The fullness of autonomy means that the subject undertakes the attempt to sustain the universal character of its claim exclusively by its own means, without relying on external grounds. This attempt cannot be replaced by refusal, by a reduction of scale, or by a prior acknowledgment of impossibility. It must be carried out as a real effort of autonomous sustaining.

The attempt to bring ontological autonomy to fullness inevitably leads the subject to a limit. At this limit, the impossibility of sustaining the universal claim by one's own forces is disclosed.

This limit is not accidental or conditioned by external circumstances. It belongs to the very structure of subjectivity. Therefore, the attempt at the fullness of ontological autonomy inevitably, everywhere and always, ends in failure.

The failure of autonomy does not mean the abandonment of the claim as such. It means the destruction of its scale as autonomously sustained. The subject discovers that it is not capable of being the ground of itself within the universal horizon.

The failure concerns the scale of the claim and does not abolish the requirement concerning its quality. It is precisely in this distinction that the possibility of preserving subjecthood arises.

Axiom:

subjecthood is preserved only where the quality of the claim is sustained in the failure of its scale.

The preservation of the quality of the claim means the preservation of correspondence to reality in the condition of failure. The subject recognizes failure as failure, without distorting it or replacing it with interpretations. To name defeat as defeat is the only form of preserving the quality of the claim.

The attempt to soften, conceal, or reinterpret failure signifies the loss of the quality of the claim. The communicative distortion of reality at the moment of failure is a form of withdrawal from ontological tension and leads to the loss of subjectivity.

Thus, the failure of autonomy does not appear as the end of subjectivity, but as its decisive test. At this point, the subject either preserves the quality of the claim and thereby remains a subject, or loses it and exits the subject-position.

10. The Quality of Ontology

The quality of ontology is determined by the capacity of the subject to preserve correspondence to reality in a limit situation. The limit in which this quality is disclosed is the failure of autonomy.

In this state, the subject loses the capacity to sustain the scale of its ontological claim and confronts the impossibility of being the ground of itself. The quality of ontology is determined by the subject's relation to this failure.

A subject in whom the quality of ontology is preserved recognizes failure as failure and does not distort it either in thinking or in communication. They do not

reduce the scale of their claim and do not replace reality with interpretations designed to conceal its non-correspondence. Their position is coherent and transparent: it contains no internal contradictions and does not conceal from the subject itself its own grounds. In the limit case, the subject overcomes the rupture between internal and external communication and is capable of “thinking aloud.”

A subject who has lost the quality of ontology does not sustain this correspondence and seeks to eliminate the rupture between claim and reality by distorting it. They soften failure, rationalize it, translate it into other registers, or mask it. The distortion of reality at the moment of failure signifies the loss of the quality of ontology and, thereby, the loss of subjectivity.

The capacity to sustain the quality of ontology is manifested in the horizon from which the subject acts. A subject limited to the ontic horizon (situation, social norm, psychological impulse) sustains quality only within that horizon. A subject acting from the ontological horizon (taking into account reality as a whole and its ultimate grounds) is capable of sustaining quality on a broader scale. The development of the subject is determined by its capacity to sustain this horizon over time and to expand it without loss of quality.

Axiom:

The quality of ontology is determined not by the success of action, but by the capacity to sustain the truth of one’s relation to reality under conditions of its ultimate resistance. The preservation of the quality of ontology means the preservation of the universal character of the claim while recognizing the impossibility of its autonomous sustaining.

Thus, the quality of ontology marks the boundary between the subject and its loss. In a limit situation, the subject either preserves correspondence to reality and thereby remains a subject, or distorts it and loses subjectivity. Differences of horizon and degrees of development do not alter this criterion, but only determine the scale of its realization.

11. Ontological Readdressing

The attempt to bring ontological autonomy to completion inevitably leads the subject to failure. The subject discovers the impossibility of being the ground of itself. This failure is not accidental but structural: autonomy cannot withstand ultimate load.

At this point, a bifurcation emerges.

The subject may attempt to preserve stability by distorting reality — to soften the failure, reconstruct it in alternative registers, reduce the scale of its claim, or redistribute responsibility. This path leads to the loss of the quality of ontology and, consequently, to the loss of subjectivity.

The alternative is ontological readdressing.

Ontological readdressing is the subject’s renunciation of the claim to be the source of its own being, while preserving the universal character of this claim. The subject does not abandon ground as such but abandons its autonomous retention. The ground is not eliminated but readdressed.

The key condition of readdressing is the preservation of the quality of ontology. The subject acknowledges the failure of autonomy as failure, does not distort it, and does not reduce the scale of its claim. Its position remains coherent and transparent

even under conditions of ultimate mismatch between claim and the possibility of its realization.

Readdressing is not an act of delegation. The subject does not transfer responsibility to an external system and does not free itself from the necessity of grounding. On the contrary, it accepts the impossibility of self-grounding as a permanent condition of its existence. Ontological tension is not resolved but becomes a stable mode.

In this sense, ontological readdressing stands in opposition to the totalitarian model of submission. Totalitarianism removes tension, substitutes the ground, and redistributes responsibility, turning the subject into a carrier of external prescriptions. Ontological readdressing, by contrast, preserves tension, does not eliminate responsibility, and demands ultimate honesty in relation to reality.

The renunciation of ontological autonomy does not mean the renunciation of personhood. What is eliminated is not the "I" but its claim to be the source of itself. The subject does not dissolve but, for the first time, finds itself in a position where substitution of the ground becomes impossible.

Various constructions may serve as addresses of readdressing — ideological, political, cultural, or religious. All of them are capable of demanding from the subject a movement beyond itself and even sacrifice. However, the mere possibility of sacrifice does not make an address ontologically valid.

The criterion is the preservation of the quality of ontology in the situation of failed autonomy. If an address requires distortion of reality, softening of failure, or redistribution of responsibility, it cannot withstand ultimate load and cannot function as ground.

Ideological constructions, even in their radical forms, do not meet this criterion. They inevitably reduce reality, remove tension, or substitute the ground, thereby destroying subjectivity.

Thus, the multiplicity of possible addresses does not imply their equivalence.

If the requirements of the quality of ontology — coherence, transparency, and correspondence to reality under conditions of failed autonomy — are consistently maintained, the range of possible addresses is radically narrowed. In the limit, it reduces to one.

This single address is determined not by the arbitrary choice of the subject but by its capacity to withstand ultimate load without distorting reality and without removing responsibility.

The choice of address cannot be derived from logic as a closed system, since logic itself brings the subject to the limit of autonomy and reveals its insufficiency. In this sense, the choice has the character of faith.

Faith, however, is not an arbitrary preference or an irrational act. It is the decision to preserve the quality of ontology in a situation where logic can no longer provide grounding.

The ultimate form of ontological readdressing is the Cross.

The Cross designates a situation in which the subject preserves correspondence to reality under the complete loss of empirical guarantees. This is not a renunciation of freedom but its ultimate form. Freedom here appears as the obligation to maintain full correspondence to truth when no support in oneself remains possible.

Thus, ontological readdressing defines the only way to preserve subjecthood after the failure of autonomy. The subject either readdresses the ground while preserving the quality of ontology, or distorts reality and loses subjectivity.

12. Consequences

Three consequences follow from the proposed ontology of the subject.

1. Ontological Capacity

A subject that has passed through the cycle

“ontological tension → failure of autonomy → readdressing”

acquires the capacity to sustain broader horizons of reality without distortion.

This expansion is not development in a psychological or social sense. It is a structural consequence of readdressing: a ground that does not coincide with the subject does not require reduction of reality.

The more stable the readdressing, the greater the volume of reality the subject can interiorize without loss of the quality of ontology.

2. The Rarity of Subjecthood

Subjecthood is not a stable state or a natural mode of existence. It arises only at the point of passing through the cycle

“tension → failure → readdressing.”

Most human activity unfolds outside this cycle: either at the level of inertia or in the form of simulated subjectivity. In such cases, the external form of action is preserved, but the act of grounding is absent.

Since entry into ontological tension and the preservation of quality at the point of failure are rare events, subjecthood has the character of an exception rather than a norm.

3. The Significance of the Subject

The subject is the only bearer of correspondence to reality. Only in the subject-position is it possible to sustain truth, assume responsibility, and enact freedom.

Where subjecthood is lost, the very possibility of correspondence to reality is lost. This leads to the replacement of truth by interpretations, responsibility by distribution of roles, and freedom by adaptation to structures.

Therefore, the crisis of subjecthood inevitably takes the form of a crisis of culture and civilization.

The restoration of subjecthood requires neither psychological development nor institutional reform, but the creation of conditions under which the passage through the cycle

“ontological tension → failure → readdressing”

becomes possible.

Chapter 3. Action

Ontological Action

Axiom of the Chapter

Ontological action is the continuous rupture of the self-reproduction of distortion. In this rupture, Logos-reality is actualized. The subject exists only in this action. The cessation of action is the loss of subjectivity.

1. The Problem of Action

The subject is not given as a presence. It exists only in action.

Neither beliefs, nor intentions, nor inner states have ontological significance in themselves. Their reality is determined solely by whether they are realized in action. It is in action that it becomes visible whether a human being proceeds from the Logos or remains within the reproduction of distortion.

Therefore, the analysis of action is not psychology but a diagnostics of being.

Not every activity is action. The majority of processes are functioning.

2. Ontic Action (Functioning)

Ontic action is action that takes place within an already given reality.

A person acts without questioning the grounds of their position. Their activity may be intense, rational, and socially significant, yet it remains within existing structures. Ontic action does not require an act of foundation.

It relies on:

internal states

external norms

Within ontic action, two forms can be distinguished: psychological and social.

3. Psychological Action

Determined by internal states.

This is a reaction to emotions, desires, fears, and preferences. It is a natural part of life but does not require a relation to Truth. A person acts under the influence of impulse without asking whether it corresponds to the Logos.

This is a reaction of the psyche, not an act of the subject.

4. Social Action

Determined by external structures.

This is action in accordance with norms, expectations, and roles. It ensures social stability and coordination but does not require independent grounding of position.

A person performs a function without relating it to the Logos. This is the work of a system, not the freedom of the person.

5. The Limits of Ontic Action

Ontic action is necessary but ontologically limited.

It does not lead beyond the given reality. It reproduces structures but does not change their ground. In the strict sense, it is not action but functioning.

Ontic action does not interrupt entropy but reproduces it. Therefore, its horizon inevitably narrows. This narrowing leads to existential crisis.

5.1. Entropy of Action

The basic state of human activity is entropic.

Any system tends toward self-preservation and the reproduction of what already exists. Psychological impulses and social structures sustain this process. Entropy is the normal state of the world without action.

Therefore, without rupture, any activity becomes a form of maintaining distortion. Complacency, adaptation, and stability do not produce development but intensify the growth of entropy.

Ontic action is a form of entropy — the self-reproduction of distortion. Therefore, the subject is a rare mode of existence.

6. Ontological Action (Rupture)

Alongside functioning, there exists action.

Ontological action is the rupture of the self-reproduction of distortion. In this rupture, Logos-reality is actualized.

Logos-reality is a reality not produced by the subject and not dependent on it. Ontological action arises from the recognition of the Logos and is directed toward its retention.

The source of ontological action is neither in the past nor in the present, but in the eschaton. It is oriented toward a reality that exceeds what is given. Action is participation in a future that is not yet realized.

It stands in opposition to internal impulses, external pressure, and the inertia of existing structures. A person acts not out of desire and not out of norm, but from the recognized Logos, which does not allow inertia.

Not every activity is action.

The criterion of action is as follows:

if no rupture occurs — it is functioning

if the Logos is not actualized — it is functioning

if stoppage occurs — action ceases

The cessation of action is the loss of subjectivity.

7. The Structure of Ontological Action

Ontological action is not a single act. It is a process.

It unfolds through the following stages:

ontological stoppage

a crack in reality

tension

risk of collapse

readdressing toward the Logos

rupture

At each stage, a return to automatism is possible. Therefore, action requires constant renewal. Action is the sustaining of the process of rupture process. The inner form of this holding is contemplation. Contemplation is the capacity not to lose the Logos after rupture. Without contemplation, rupture turns into breakdown.

8. The Cost of Action

Ontological action is bound to loss.

A person loses psychological stability, social protection, the illusion of control, and their former identity.

They are deprived of all previous grounds. The price of action is the destruction of false ground. Without this loss, access to the Logos is impossible.

9. Continuity (Law of the Subject)

Ontological action cannot be completed.

After each rupture, there arises a tendency to return to automatism. Entropy seeks to restore previous structures. Therefore, action must be continuously reproduced.

Rupture must be continuous. Stoppage means the loss of action. The loss of action means the loss of subjectivity. The subject exists only insofar as it acts.

Contemplation and prayer are actions that sustain rupture.

10. Social Implication

The type of action determines the state of society.

Psychological action leads to instability

Social action leads to stability without development

Ontological action opens the possibility of transforming reality

A society is alive only insofar as subjects act within it.

However, social structures do not guarantee the emergence of ontological action. In many cases, they suppress it — through norms, institutions, and culture.

As a result, forms of distorted subjecthood arise. Their analysis requires separate consideration.

Final Formula

Ontological action is the continuous resistance to entropy, the rupture of the self-reproduction of distortion in which Logos-reality is actualized.

The subject is the one who does not cease this action and does not allow a return to automatism.

Chapter 4. Multiplicity

1. Multiplicity

Multiplicity does not possess its own substantial ontology and does not exist as an independent mode of being. It arises only as an effect of the co-existence or communication of two or more subjects or objects.

Multiplicity is not a substance but a relation — a space in-between.

In this capacity, it contains no content of its own, produces no meaning, and allows only for a degree of transparency between what is related. Its ultimate possibility is transparency, but not the production of meaning.

However, multiplicity may also be non-transparent. In the limit, absolute opacity destroys multiplicity as relation, reducing it to mere adjacency — in space, time, or imagination.

Thus, multiplicity is relationality deprived of its own ground.

2. Entropy and the Limit of Multiplicity

Relationality as such is not a neutral medium.

Every transmission — of energy, information, or meaning — occurs under conditions of loss and dissipation. This corresponds to a general principle: any system tends toward the growth of entropy.

Therefore, multiplicity in itself does not stabilize relation, does not retain meaning, and tends toward distortion and disintegration.

Full communication — as the disclosure of meaning — is not a natural state of multiplicity. It requires the overcoming of entropy.

This means that multiplicity does not produce the human but only allows it as an excess.

3. Relational Ontology and Its Limit

Relationality is not homogeneous. Not every relation is capable of sustaining meaning.

The decisive distinction runs along the line of ground.

3.1 Closed Relationality

Closed relationality is a relation that has no ground outside itself.

In this regime, elements relate to one another, but the relation is not rooted in anything beyond these elements. Therefore, the relation exists but does not sustain meaning.

The connection here is:

derivative

unstable

prone to distortion and disintegration

In the limit, it degenerates into pure connectedness without content or collapses into adjacency.

3.2 Grounded Relationality

Another form of relationality is possible — one in which relation receives its ground from outside itself.

In this case, the connection is not reducible to the interaction of elements. It is rooted in a source and is therefore capable of sustaining meaning.
The relation becomes a bearer of content.

3.3 Colonization as Derivative Relationality

Not every external ground is ontological.

A ground may be:

imposed

substitutive of the subject's own point

replacing the subject

In such a case, colonization arises.

Colonization is derivative relationality in which one subject or structure appropriates for itself the role of ground for another.

Here, the relation is preserved, but the ground is structurally false, since it does not open the subject but replaces it.

4. Ontological Ground

Ontological ground is fundamentally different.

It is not imposed but disclosed,

it does not suppress but makes possible,

it does not replace the subject but constitutes it.

In this case, the subject does not disappear but comes into being.

5. Interhuman Relationality

Interhuman relations are not neutral.

If a relation is closed within its participants, it inevitably tends toward colonization. Each subject attempts to become the source, and a struggle for ground arises.

If, however, the relation is not closed and has a common ground outside the subjects, it ceases to be colonization and becomes participation.

6. Limit Formulas

Multiplicity does not produce meaning.

Relation without ground does not sustain meaning.

Entropy is the natural mode of multiplicity.

Colonization arises as an attempt to compensate for the absence of ground.

Freedom is possible only in a relation grounded outside its participants.

7. Conclusion

Multiplicity as such is not capable of producing the human. It allows relation but does not sustain meaning.

Relationality without ground leads either to disintegration or to colonization.

Yet only within multiplicity can the human appear.

Relationality with ground opens the possibility of the subject.

8. Transition

If meaning exists but does not arise within multiplicity, then it is necessary to recognize the existence of a ground that does not belong to multiplicity.

And this raises the question: what is the source of relationality capable of sustaining meaning?

Chapter 5. The Problem of Meaning

1.

Meaning is disclosed as an exclusively human phenomenon. It is not given as a property of things, but arises within the space of human experience.

The human being does not react to reality directly. They relate, interpret, distinguish, and choose. Their action is determined not only by what happens, but by what it means.

In this sense, meaning is not an addition to reality. It is the condition of orientation within it.

More precisely, meaning is the structure of the subject's orientation in relation to the accessible and the real.

Without meaning, it is impossible to identify a situation, impossible to distinguish the significant from the insignificant, impossible to make a decision, and impossible to sustain action. Therefore, at the most elementary level, meaning appears as the condition of human survival — not in a narrowly biological sense, but in a structural one: without it, the human being is incapable of acting as a human being.

2.

At this level, meaning is always bound to a concrete situation.

It answers the question of what is happening and what is to be done.

The meaning of pain is to avoid damage. The meaning of labor is to secure existence. The meaning of a rule is to stabilize interaction. The meaning of a decision is to alter a situation in a definite direction.

In all these cases, meaning has a finite and functional character. It makes it possible to orient oneself, to choose, and to act within the limits of a given reality. Ontic meaning is navigation within the accessible.

It provides coherence of action and predictability of outcome, but does not call into question the very nature of the reality within which the action takes place.

However, the human being does not exist within the limits of a single situation.

They retain the past, orient themselves toward the future, and act in the present. They perceive individual events not in isolation, but as elements of a broader trajectory. They relate their actions not only to current conditions, but also to what has already occurred and to what may yet occur.

This means that human existence unfolds not at a point, but within a horizon.

3. A horizon is the ultimate framework within which individual events, actions, and decisions receive their meaning.

A situation does not determine its own meaning by itself. It becomes meaningful only in relation to a broader context. The same act may have an opposite meaning depending on the horizon within which it is included.

Therefore, the meaning of an action is determined not only by its function, but also by the horizon within which it is interpreted.

4. A horizon is impossible without time.

The human being retains the past, anticipates the future, and relates every action to both. Time in human experience is the structure within which these different dimensions are held together.

But the holding of time requires something more. In order to bind together past, present, and future, the subject must preserve identity with itself. It must remain one and the same across changing states.

From this arises identity as the condition of horizon. And therefore meaning becomes the condition for the preservation and development of identity through time.

5. It is precisely here that a fundamental rupture arises.

As long as meaning is bound to an individual situation, it remains ontic. It makes action possible, but does not require grounding of itself. But as soon as the human being relates their actions to the wholeness of their life, another question arises: not what to do, but what sustains this wholeness itself; not the meaning of action, but the meaning of the horizon within which action becomes possible.

This transition can be stated rigorously.

Ontic meaning answers the question: what is to be done within the accessible? But the human being inevitably comes to another question: what is real? For the accessible may be partial, distorted, or illusory. Thus, a rupture arises between the accessible, within which navigation is carried out, and the real, in relation to which this navigation must be verified.

This rupture is not a defect. It is a structural condition of human existence. The gap between the accessible and the real is the condition of freedom and the possibility of the subject.

6. False Meaning and Simulation

It is precisely at this point that a critical danger arises.

Since the gap cannot be finally eliminated, the subject is confronted with the temptation to close it artificially. The simulation of meaning is the substitution of ontological navigation by ontic navigation. In other words, a part of the accessible is declared to be the whole of the real.

This is the structure of idolatry: the partial is endowed with the status of the absolute.

7. The Mechanism of Simulation

The simulation of meaning is reproduced through three operations:

Substitution of horizon. A particular goal is declared to be ultimate meaning.

Closure of the gap. The question of the real is replaced by the assertion: "the real is what works."

Fixation of the accessible as ultimate. The accessible is taken for the whole. Navigation becomes closed within the accessible and loses its relation to the real.

8. Diagnostics of Simulation

Simulation is disclosed by its consequences.

Entropic erosion of identity. Meaning no longer sustains the subject through time.

Narrowing of freedom. The subject becomes dependent on the construction.

Absence of verification. Any test is blocked. False meaning is navigation that forbids the verification of the map by reality.

9. The Gap and Action

Simulation is possible only because the subject does not fully coincide with its own navigation. It is capable not only of acting, but also of seeing how it acts. A gap arises between action and its interpretation. It is precisely in this gap that verification becomes possible.

However, verification is effected only in action. Without action, the gap collapses, and navigation turns into fiction.

10. Verification and Applied Metaphysics

Verification means the comparison of navigation with reality through action. It discloses whether meaning corresponds to the real or merely reproduces the accessible.

The verification of metaphysics leads to its rationalization, and the rationalization of metaphysics leads to the modernization of ontology. Metaphysics determines the limit of ontology, and its verification determines the possibility of its expansion.

The rationalization of derivative grounds of metaphysics — the elimination of dependent grounds that do not withstand verification — expands the interiorized ontological capacity of the subject. The fewer unverified grounds remain, the broader the horizon of reality that the subject is capable of sustaining. This is precisely what applied metaphysics is.

Applied metaphysics is the governed process of verification and rationalization of metaphysics, as a result of which ontological capacity expands and the freedom of the subject increases. Freedom is understood here as the capacity to sustain and realize navigation within a broader horizon of the real without the disintegration of identity.

11. The Criterion of the Real

Verification requires a criterion that does not belong to multiplicity.

This criterion cannot be produced within the system, since the system itself is subject to entropy and distortion. Therefore, the ground capable of sustaining meaning must be outside multiplicity.

Every human language describes operations with meaning as personal interaction. The operator of meaning inevitably appears as a person. Even the disclosure of the space of meaning is possible only for a person. Therefore, meaning cannot be reduced to impersonal structures or processes. If a criterion of meaning exists, it cannot be purely formal or impersonal.

This means that the ground capable of sustaining meaning must have a personal character.

12. Conclusion

Therefore, the problem of meaning, in its limit form, is the problem of the ground of navigation.

The task of the subject is this: through verification by action, not to allow simulation to close the gap between the accessible and the real.

And therefore: the subject exists only so long as it keeps this gap open.

Chapter 6. Ontological Communication

1. Communication as Encounter

In the previous chapters, the basic components of communication were examined: the subject, ontological action, multiplicity, and meaning. To repeat them here would be redundant. It is necessary to focus on the specifically communicative character of the act — not as action in general, but precisely as encounter.

The central problem of communication is to see the Other and to recognize the fullness of the being of the Other.

A person may participate quite functionally in communication while perceiving the Other solely as a projection of the self, as an element of one's own navigation, or as a threat to the "I." Even a totalitarian form of communication changes nothing: the leader or "duce" in such a case remains merely a function — a projection of a pathological collective or individual ego.

Communication here remains ontic — navigation within the accessible, where the Other never exceeds the limits of my world-picture.

A healthy subject, having recognized the universality of the claim "I am," is obliged to take the next step. The subject must see and recognize the universality of the claim "You are" — and further, "He is," "They are."

As long as the subject does not pose the question in this way, as long as the subject does not suspend all derivative grounds and continues to function as part of the flow of multiplicity, communication remains within the ontic mode.

But if the subject truly recognizes the fullness of the being of the Other, the horizon of the subject expands. Meta-navigation begins, and we enter the domain of ontological communication.

2. The Risk of Recognition

Only in this case can one speak of real communication — when the subject recognizes the fullness of the being of the Other.

What happens at this moment?

The subject subjects not individual propositions, but the entire structure of the metaphysics and ontology of the subject to verification. The subject places the own world-picture at risk, allowing the Other into the ontological space of the subject. If the subject is ready for this risk, the subject performs a genuine ontological act. The Other ceases to be an external object or projection and becomes a point of encounter with the One Ground.

The recognition of the Other requires a shared Logos. Without it, encounter remains either colonization or a simulation of participation.

3. Two Limit Cases

History preserves two visually similar yet ontologically radically different acts of communication: the death of Socrates and the Cross of Jesus Christ.

Socrates: The Limit of Autonomy

Socrates reached the boundary of ontological autonomy. He dismantled the derivative grounds of Athenian polis life, subjected prevailing values to verification, and stood before judgment.

His words, “I know that I know nothing,” are not a modest epistemological remark. They are an existential-ontological statement: the recognition of the limit of human reason and the autonomous “I.”

Socrates died for this.

His death, as an act, created a new reality for European thought — a space of reflection upon reflection. He opened for Europe the possibility of continuous metaphysical questioning.

However, he spoke in his own name. He revealed the limit of the autonomous “I,” but could not cross it.

Socrates is a question left open.

Christ: A New Ground

Jesus came from another reality.

He did not merely reach the boundary of ontological autonomy — He gave a different ground of ontology.

He not only opened the possibility of metaphysical analysis, but offered a radically different ontology: the possibility of living not from one’s own autonomy, but from Truth, which itself becomes the source of being.

Human nature as a whole was moving along a trajectory of separation from reality. Christ took upon Himself this trajectory of the entire human nature — of all who were before Him and all who would come after.

He recognized the human being as the human being is, traversed the path of the human being to its end, and on the Cross reversed the entire trajectory — toward life, toward true reality.

The Cross is the ultimate act of ontological communication.

The Son of God fully recognizes the being of fallen humanity, receives it into Himself, and takes upon Himself all distortions and derivative trajectories.

He does not impose a ground but discloses it through absolute correspondence to reality, even at the moment of the complete collapse of autonomy.

The Resurrection confirms: this is not defeat, but victory.

Humanity is given a new trajectory — access to the living, personal Source of being.

4. Conclusion

Socrates showed that the autonomous “I” at its limit, dies — opening the space of the question.

Christ showed that the “I” can live if it is grounded in Him — in the One who is “I Am.”

Socrates is the limit of human autonomy and the beginning of reflection.

Christ is the Answer and the new ground of ontology.

By recognizing Christ as Savior and as the Source of being, the human being receives the possibility of full subjecthood— no longer grounded in the unstable foundation of autonomy, but in the firm ground of His divinity.

This is the ultimate form of ontological readdressing: not the rejection of the claim “I am,” but its fulfillment through participation in the One who truly Is.

In the previous chapters, the discourse led toward the Logos while preserving the formal possibility of bypassing it.

The chapter on communication removes this possibility.

In the event of the Cross, the Logos ceases to be a hypothesis and appears as the only ground capable of sustaining the ontological claim at the point of the complete collapse of autonomy.

Chapter 7. The Church as the Space of the Retention of Ontological Communication

1. In the previous chapter, the limit point of ontological analysis was reached. The subject is brought to the boundary of its own autonomy and discovers the impossibility of being the ground of itself.

At this point, the necessity of ontological readdressing is disclosed.

In the event of the Cross, the only ground capable of sustaining this ultimate load without distorting reality becomes manifest.

However, the question is not exhausted by this discovery.

If a new ground is given, a further question arises: how can it be retained in history? How is the existence of a subject possible — a subject acting from this ground — under the conditions of multiplicity, entropy, and the constant pressure of derivative structures?

2. The answer to this question leads to the problem of the Church.

In this context, the Church cannot be understood as a social institution, a cultural tradition, or a system of norms. All such definitions remain within the ontic and do not reach its ontological meaning.

If the Church is considered merely as a structure, it will inevitably be reduced to one of the elements of multiplicity and subjected to the same laws of entropy as any other form of social organization.

Within the proposed ontology, the Church must be understood otherwise.

The Church is the space of the retention of ontological communication disclosed in the event of the Cross.

This means that within the Church there is preserved the possibility of relation grounded not in closed relationality and not in colonization, but in the Logos as an external and ultimate ground.

For this reason, the Church does not produce subjecthood but makes it possible.

It does not replace the act of foundation and does not eliminate ontological tension, but creates the conditions in which this act can be carried out and sustained.

3. The subject does not arise from the Church automatically. On the contrary, the very possibility of genuine participation in the Church presupposes subjectivity.

However, without a space in which Logos-reality is preserved, the subject finds itself face to face with multiplicity and inevitably returns to derivative grounds.

Thus, the Church appears as a specific form of the historical presence of a ground that does not belong to multiplicity.

This presence does not eliminate freedom, but makes it possible. It does not remove ontological tension, but prevents its degeneration into chaos or fiction. It does not guarantee the preservation of subjectivity, but creates the conditions under which the subject may not disappear.

In this sense, the Church can be defined as the infrastructure of ontological readdressing.

Infrastructure here is understood not in a technical, but in an ontological sense: as a form in which access to a ground that exceeds the subject and is not reducible to multiplicity is preserved.

Through participation in this form, the subject receives the possibility not only to pass through the collapse of autonomy, but also not to lose the quality of ontology at this point.

However, this participation is not external or formal. It cannot be reduced to belonging, identity, or the fulfillment of norms. Any attempt to reduce the Church to these forms inevitably transfers it into the ontic mode and destroys its ontological significance.

Authentic participation in the Church is possible only as a continuation of ontological action.

This means that the subject must preserve correspondence to reality, must not distort the collapse of autonomy, and must not substitute the ground. Otherwise, even within the Church, the subject remains in a derivative mode.

4. Thus, the Church does not abolish the task of the subject, but radicalizes it.

It does not provide a ready solution, but makes the evasion of the decision impossible.

It does not replace the act of faith, but makes it ontologically meaningful.

In this sense, faith appears as the form of the retention of ontological readdressing — not as an emotional state and not as a cultural identity, but as the decision to preserve correspondence to reality at the point where autonomy is impossible.

5. Therefore, the final conclusion of this work may be formulated as follows.

The subject arises in the act of the recognition of reality and is sustained in ontological action.

The subject reaches its limit in the attempt at autonomy and is preserved only through ontological readdressing.

The only ground capable of sustaining this readdressing without distorting reality is the Logos disclosed in the event of the Cross.

The Church is the historical space in which this possibility does not disappear.

6. And therefore:

the subject exists insofar as it preserves correspondence to reality; freedom exists insofar as it is grounded in that which exceeds the subject; and the Church exists insofar as the possibility of this grounding is preserved within it.

Conclusion

Criteria and Verification

The ontology proposed in this project cannot be accepted or rejected at the level of abstract agreement. It presupposes the possibility of verification — yet this verification is reducible neither to empirical validation nor to logical consistency in the classical sense. What is at stake is verification of an ontological order.

The problem is that the subject, as the bearer of experience, is at the same time a potential source of distortion. Therefore, any appeal to “immediate experience” requires further differentiation. Without such differentiation, there arises the risk of substituting reality with one’s own projections, and readdressing with its simulation.

In this context, the notion of criteria is introduced — not as external norms, but as conditions that make it possible to distinguish genuine ontological action from its derivative forms.

1. The Criterion of Truth

Truth in this project is understood neither as the correspondence of a statement to a fact nor as an effect of discursive coherence. It should be defined as the capacity to sustain correspondence to reality under ultimate conditions.

This means that the verification of truth does not occur in situations of cognitive comfort, but at points where habitual grounds cease to function: in experiences of limit, crisis, loss, or death.

If, under such conditions, the subject preserves the coherence of thinking and action without resorting to fictitious grounds, one may speak of the presence of an ontological support.

Thus, truth manifests itself as resistance to disintegration rather than as the persuasiveness of an argument.

2. The Criterion of the Subject

The subject is not accepted as a given. It arises and is sustained in the act of the recognition of reality.

The criterion of subjecthood is the capacity to assume a position that is not reducible to external determinations — cultural, psychological, or social. However, this is not sufficient.

Autonomy, achieved in the process of decolonization, is only an intermediate state.

The genuine subject is disclosed at the moment when it is capable of relinquishing autonomy without the loss of identity.

If the renunciation of autonomy leads to regression, dissolution, or the substitution of the ground, the subject has not yet been constituted.

If, however, it is preserved — and even intensified — in this renunciation, one may speak of the transition to a stable form of subjectivity.

3. The Criterion of the Church

In this project, the Church is not regarded as a guarantor of truth by virtue of its institutional form. Therefore, a criterion is required to distinguish its actualization from its simulation.

Such a criterion is the presence or absence of real ontological readdressing.

The Church exists insofar as the possibility is preserved within it for the subject to be related to the Logos without the substitution of the ground.

If ecclesial practice reproduces forms that do not lead to a transformation of the subject's ontological orientation, it functions as a simulacrum, regardless of its canonical correctness.

If, however, it contributes to the preservation of correspondence to reality and to the formation of a stable horizon of being, it is actualized as an event.

4. The Criterion of Readdressing

Readdressing is the central act around which the entire structure of the project is organized. However, it does not in itself guarantee authenticity, since it may be reproduced in a distorted form.

The criterion of genuine readdressing is the impossibility of its closure upon the subject.

If, as a result of readdressing, the subject preserves itself as the ultimate ground, what has occurred is merely a modification of autonomy.

Genuine readdressing leads to a change in the mode of existence: the subject ceases to be the source of its own ground and begins to act from that which exceeds it.

At the same time, it does not lose subjectivity, but receives it in a stricter and more demanding form.

5. Verification

Verification in this context is understood as the process of testing the correspondence between the declared ontological state and the real structure of the subject's existence.

It is carried out in two interconnected dimensions.

First, textual verification — the correlation of personal experience with a body of texts in which concentrated ontological experience is fixed: Sacred Scripture, the patristic tradition, as well as philosophical works that have reached the limit of analytical depth.

Second, existential verification — the testing of the subject's stability in change, its capacity to preserve identity and coherence under conditions where external supports are absent.

The convergence of these two lines does not guarantee truth in an ultimate sense, but allows the exclusion of the most crude forms of self-deception.

6. The Quality of Ontology

On the basis of the introduced criteria, one may speak of the quality of ontology — as a characteristic of the subject's capacity to exist in correspondence to reality.

The quality of ontology is determined by:

- the capacity to sustain correspondence to reality without substituting the ground;
- the capacity to preserve the coherence of thought and action under ultimate conditions;

— the capacity to pass from autonomy to readdressing without the loss of subjectivity.

Thus, ontology is evaluated not by the completeness of its description and not by systemic closure, but by whether it withstands the test of reality.

Final Statement

In this sense, the proposed project should be understood not as a completed theory, but as an attempt to articulate the conditions under which the distinction between the genuine and the fictitious remains possible.

Prolegomena

This corpus of texts has a strange, almost uninvited history. The author experiences himself more as a witness and recorder of its emergence than as its creator.

The texts did not arise according to a plan, but as successive attempts to articulate the same persistent intuition that would not leave him at rest.

If you have read up to this point, then you have already passed through *An Experiment in Applied Metaphysics of the Subject* — the most mature and systematic text in the first part of the project. What now lies before you is the very “original” material from which the Experiment later grew.

It was written earlier, in a different rhythm and with a different degree of refinement, yet it is here that the main themes and the intonation of the entire corpus first appeared.

However, one circumstance must be fixed from the outset.

The texts that follow do not introduce a new theory and do not propose an alternative system of views. They register an attempt to sustain a distinction that becomes possible only with a certain shift in the understanding of oneself and of reality.

If this shift has not occurred, the text will be read as just another concept. If it has occurred, it ceases to be a concept and becomes a continuation of an already initiated movement.

At the center of the project lies neither the question of the content of faith nor the question of the form of religious life. What is at stake is a more radical level — the status of the subject.

The problem is not how to be. The problem is to be — and to be in reality.

This entails posing the question in its ultimate form: does the person exist as a center of identity, responsibility, and truth — or is it a derivative of factors external to it?

From this perspective, it becomes clear that the Church may be actualized, or it may exist as a simulacrum. Form does not guarantee event. The presence of structure does not entail the presence of readdressing.

Therefore, the task is not to describe an institution, but to distinguish: whether real communication with the Logos is taking place within it, or whether its imitation is being reproduced.

One of the key processes in which this distinction becomes possible is the decolonization of the person.

This is understood not as a socio-political process, but as the ontological liberation of the subject from false centers of self-determination.

Ontological decolonization restores the capacity to be a point of decision.

But even this is not the completion of the process.

For the autonomy attained at this stage proves to be only an intermediate condition.

The renunciation of autonomy is possible only after its acquisition.

And this renunciation is not a regression.

It is a transition to another mode of being, in which the subject ceases to be the source of its own ground and becomes a participant in that which exceeds it — and thereby attains the fullness of subjecthood in the face of Truth.

Method and Limits

The project does not construct a closed system and does not claim finality. Its task is to delineate a problem-field and to propose a language in which one can speak of the person as an ontological event.

The author deliberately sustains a tension between the philosophical and theological registers. This makes it possible to conduct an honest dialogue with contemporary thought without severing the connection with the Christian tradition.

The texts should be read precisely as an invitation to discussion, not as a finished doctrine.

Context

The author is from the North Caucasus. This largely determines the optic: here, the disintegration of the person and of society is not experienced as an academic theme, but as a personal and collective reality.

For this reason, in the project the disintegration of the subject is not taken as the normative state of the human being.

This distinction is not polemical, but methodological.

It indicates a difference in initial assumptions, not an opposition of cultures.

This is, in essence, all that needed to be said in advance.

What follows are the texts themselves.

If they provoke disagreement, clarification, or at least a serious question — then the project has fulfilled its task.

Part II.

To Christians of the Third Millennium

The Origin. Once Primordial

This cycle of articles, united into a single whole, grew out of one initial article, which itself was born thanks to the arrival of Father Konstantin Dojić at the Cetinje Monastery. Its further development was largely the initiative of Dr. Tomàs Meinhardt Teixidor, whose appearance in Cetinje also seemed a coincidence. I express my gratitude to both of them, but I must emphasize that they bear no responsibility for any inaccuracies or misunderstandings that may be present in this treatise.

I must admit that this treatise did not emerge from a genuine dialogue. I am trying to present to the “general public” certain intuitions that have not passed through the filter of theological communication, as would normally be the case. I am simply publishing a “conversation with myself.” In that sense, it is the ravings of a madman. Therefore, I will not burden the reader with the customary prefaces about my unworthiness, lack of intellect, and so forth. I am merely, as one says, “taking out the trash from my house.” I see nothing particularly special in this text. So, with your permission I shall proceed straight to the matter at hand.

Why discuss anything at all, or worse — write? The Kingdom of Heaven is already at our disposal. Whether we reach it or not depends solely on each person’s individual effort. Those gates have long been open. Whoever wishes may ascend the ladder. I have long since found that ladder, and, whether poorly or well, I am climbing it. What more could I possibly need?

It is my profession. I have a diploma attesting to my qualification. I have a status. My social responsibility consists in turning this staircase into an escalator and increasing “the throughput capacity of this staircase” to the maximum possible level. At least, that is how I understand my vocation. That is why I write this text.

And let us agree from the outset: I do not aspire to the role of yet another Martin Luther — God forbid! I do not claim the ultimate truth. I speak only from personal experience. All my reflections are rooted in my own experience. I fully understand that another experience is possible. I do not speak on behalf of everyone, nor do I write for everyone. There are general questions, and there are my own personal attempts to find answers to them. If someone else has, by other means, found other answers to the same general questions, that in no way — not even for me — diminishes the legitimacy of those “other” answers. God is fullness. God saves all — not just one or another variety of human beings.

Nevertheless, it seems to me that the current tradition places a number of “new” social classes somewhat outside the Church — “new” in the sense that they have arisen over the last few centuries. Yet the Church must learn to incorporate

them too, to speak in their language. Perhaps this is precisely where my personal ambition lies: not to replace the “rural” Church with an “urban” one, but to complement the “rural” Church with its development, with its continuation within yet another, new social environment.

...

The Church, as an activity, is obviously a particular kind of human activity. If that is so, can we apply to the Church the same criteria of effectiveness that we apply to any human profession? In principle, we can. This means that life within the Church — the processes that take place in it — can be analyzed in the same way as any other form of human activity.

This is a bold assertion. In any case, it is a highly promising one — at least in an operational sense. Such an approach — let us be honest, a rather “consumer-oriented” approach — makes it possible, I believe, to discover new opportunities for the development of ecclesial life, for the growth of Christian spiritual experience.

Can we speak about the meaning of the Church? Can we search for meaning within the Church’s processes? These processes are called sacraments. And within these sacraments, the main acting Person in the Church is God the Logos. Logic, as is well known, is a derivative of the word Logos. Let us not go too far into philology, but it is worth noting that this means that for Christians the function of the Logos is, by definition, a sacred function. And logic itself is precisely the function of the Logos.

What do we seek in the Church? Surely we seek the fullness of our humanity. We wish to become true, complete human beings. Is that not so? If it is, then is not logic, is not language itself a sign of our humanity? Is not the understanding and acceptance of what is happening an expression of humanity?

What makes a human being truly human? What distinguishes us from animals? Can we live without meaning? What troubles human beings more than the absence of understanding — more than the loss of the logic of what is happening?

I suppose we may expect that, in the experience of the Church’s sacraments, we reach the highest development of our human nature. Could that mean that we are developing our logocentric nature? Considering that the main acting Person in these sacraments is none other than the Logos Himself, such a conclusion seems to me inevitable.

What indications do we find in standard Church practice that confirm (or perhaps disprove) these assumptions?

I suggest that we reflect on the meaning of the words that describe our practices. For example, the principal event of Church life — what we call Communion.

I am not sure how it is named in all the Slavic languages, but that is how it is called in both Russian and Serbian.

In the language of the original it is called κοινωνία. Θεία κοινωνία. Divine Communion.

The Slavic equivalent implies the participation of one thing in another — Communion. Something partakes of something else. A Greek would say: the participation of one nature in another. This, in fact, is the third meaning of the Greek word. But the Greek original has two other meanings as well: the first is “society,” and the second is “communication.” In other words, when a Greek goes to church to celebrate the Eucharist, even if he is not consciously aware of it, the Greek language itself tells him that he is going to assemble the perfect, ideal society in which perfect communication will—or should—take place. Let us not forget that Eucharistia means “thanksgiving,” and Litourgia means “sacred public action,” or more simply, “function,” even if a sacred one. What does all this mean for us? It means that during the celebration of the Church’s central sacrament we gather together to form a perfect, divine society in which perfect, divine communication takes place among the members of the assembly. The whole process has the character of thanksgiving and is functional. As with any function, it may or may not take place, depending on various factors.

If we have already gone this far into philology, then we should turn our attention to another term translated from Greek that we often use — namely, “sacrament.”

The English word comes from the Latin sacramentum, which was used in the Vulgate to translate the Greek μυστήριον (mystērion). In classical Latin, sacramentum meant an oath or pledge of allegiance — originally a military term referring to a soldier’s sworn loyalty to the Roman state. When early Christian writers adopted it as the Latin equivalent of μυστήριον, the word underwent a profound transformation: what had once meant a legal or military pledge came to signify a sacred act through which divine grace is conferred. Thus, in Western Christianity, μυστήριον became sacramentum, and from there sacrament in English — while in the Eastern Church the original Greek sense, mystērion, was preserved and continues to be rendered as mystery.

Having traced the Latin transformation of the term, let us now return to its Greek source. The Greek word μυστήριον (mystērion), which lies at its root, derives from the verb μύω (“to close the eyes or mouth”) and in ancient tradition denoted a sacred ritual accessible only to the initiated, through which they experienced a personal encounter with divine reality—for example, the Eleusinian Mysteries. In the Christian context of the New Testament (Eph. 3:3–5; Col. 1:26), mystērion is a divine

secret once hidden and now revealed to believers in Christ, yet remaining closed to those who have not accepted faith. Here the emphasis is not on intellectual “incomprehensibility” but on the living experience of communion with God, available only through faith. The Slavic word *tainstvo* (from Old Church Slavonic *taina*, related to *taiti*—“to conceal”) amplifies the nuance of the unknowable, creating in the believer the sense that “this is a mystery that cannot be understood.”

Such a shift partially replaces the original idea of divine communication—of personal participation in revelation—with a ritual contemplation of an inaccessible enigma. In the Greek original *μυστήριον* never carried the sense of an “impenetrable secret” and still signifies not so much what is incomprehensible as what is revealed to the faithful yet hidden from unbelief. Most importantly, the Church’s Liturgy is not only, or even primarily, a remembrance of the Last Supper that once took place in the Upper Room of Zion; it is, much more profoundly, a participation in the Banquet of the Kingdom, which is yet to come.

Let us return to our original thought about our logocentric nature and about how the Church’s sacraments are, in principle, meant to develop this very nature. We have discovered that our chief liturgical act consists in the realization of absolute communication — divine communication. The people of this world gather into a divine community in order to enact divine communication. This gathering and this communication are functional in character and, on the psychological level, express gratitude.

It seems to me that a great number of important nuances arise immediately, each of which reveals something significant — but it is important not to lose ourselves in this abundance of information and not to forget the central idea.

That central idea is by no means new. God the Logos became flesh. Humanity was created in the image and likeness of God the Logos. Accordingly, it is precisely the logocentric nature of the human being that opens to us the possibility of communion with God. This communion with God takes place par excellence in the Church. And we have just discovered that such an interpretation of the Church — as a process — is entirely possible and, moreover, very promising for explaining our active participation in the life of the Church.

A perfect, ideal society. A perfect, ideal communication. What does this mean? In this text, they appear together as two different meanings of the same Greek word. But is their coincidence accidental? Let us think. Is a society possible without communication, or communication without society? No. These are two different aspects of one and the same reality. This interdependence becomes even more evident when we raise the question of the qualitative characteristics of both phenomena. For it is precisely by considering society as a communicative process

and communication as a social process that we can most effectively evaluate the quality of each.

How, then, can a society be perfect? How can communication be perfect? What do all fairy tales speak of? What do all dreams express?

Let us return to “normal human” language.

When a person comes to meet the Almighty God — if this is not a game but a conscious act of a truly believing soul — that believer simultaneously experiences two radically opposite states.

On the one hand, the believer confronts his own complete existential nothingness. The greatness of the Creator only accentuates one’s immeasurable insignificance — the utter contingency and non-necessity of one’s personal being. I suspect it is precisely this experience that Jesus praised in the most enigmatic of His beatitudes: “Blessed are the poor in spirit.” That is why the experience of real, not staged, prayer inevitably gives rise to humility and contrition. Not only the majesty of the Creator, but even the sheer vastness and immensity of creation itself cannot but break the heart.

On the other hand, the very fact of communion with the Creator — the possibility of communion with God — cannot but fill one with unshakable strength. Therefore, once again, the experience of genuine, not simulated, prayer inevitably gives rise to a sense of unimaginable power. If God Himself hears me, if God Himself is with me — who can be against me? What can the miserable forces of society or even of this created universe do against such a union: God and I?

And yet even these experiences do not answer the question of what exactly the ideal community and the ideal communication unfolding within such a community are.

I finished school back in the Soviet Union. It was believed that the Soviet school offered a solid education. In the Soviet textbooks on mathematics, physics, and chemistry, at the very end of the book there were answers to the problems assigned as homework throughout the course. Most likely, something similar exists here as well. Why do I mention this? Our religion is the religion of Revelation. We already have the answers. These answers have come “from the other side.” They are the most essential answers. Our task, paradoxical as it may sound, is to formulate the questions. Our spiritual search consists precisely in finding the right questions for which we already possess the answers. We must learn to understand these answers — for an answer without a question loses its meaning.

How, then, do the Church's sacraments — or, in the language of this treatise, the Church's processes — help us in this matter of ready-made answers and still-unformulated questions?

Let us look around! I mean this quite literally — let us look at anything at all. We see. But why, and how do we see? What do we actually do in order to see?

We see because somewhere far away the Sun is burning. It floods all the space around it with light. We see by the light of that star. If we find ourselves in a place where the light of the Sun does not reach, we invent all sorts of analogues of the Sun. All that is “required” of us is to have eyes. The rest is done by the Sun.

The same applies to spiritual life. We are sanctified not by what we do or do not do; we are sanctified by the Sun of Righteousness. Our task is to remain within the reach of the Sun of Righteousness — that is, within the Church. What is required of us is simply to “have eyes.”

We gather in the temple. We begin the Eucharist. We ourselves are holy, and so are all who have come with us. But not because of anything we do or fail to do. We are holy because we are illuminated and sanctified by the Sun of Righteousness — Christ. Our task is to stand within the reach of His rays and to “have eyes,” that is, faith.

We already have the answers. We are already beyond this unfinished world. We are already “there,” on the other side — where all is well, where all is true. From there we behold ourselves as already perfected. And all those around us are already perfect. For everything is flooded with Light, everything is bathed in the Sun.

This is not from us; it is not we who accomplish it. It is the Sun. Our task is to stand beneath the Sun. Our task is to allow the Sun to shine upon us and warm us. To do this, we need “eyes.” We must see it.

We must simply allow it. We must simply let it happen. We must trust — Him.

If we truly believe, then we do not need to strain ourselves. We experience, allow, or model the presence of God. And in that case, we allow all His promises to be fulfilled. And... voilà!

And then, somewhere in the deepest depth — or perhaps on the highest height — we see ourselves and all who are with us, all who have gathered around the Chalice, in the Light.

So it must be, if we truly take seriously the texts we call sacred. And then we experience the reality of the ideal society and the ideal communication.

This is the most impossible, the most magnificent achievement of human thought — to allow that everything, absolutely everything, can be OK.

The very experience of seeing the world not “from here” but “from there,” from the other side, from the far end — this experience turns psychology upside down. It turns out that the main thing is to know how to give thanks; then suddenly all possibilities open before us.

Any human life is a history of defeats, a chronicle of tragedies. To learn to see in this catastrophe a power, a success — that is what blessing means.

Blessing is, in fact, a rare example of a good translation. What does “blessing” mean? What does it mean to say, “I bless you”? A blessing is a good word. When I say, “I bless you,” I give you a good word — I open for you a good perspective.

In my native Abkhaz language, “to bless” literally means “to place someone in a state of celebration.” It is the same meaning, only far more dynamic — very Caucasian, one might say.

There is “I know,” and there is “I want.” But “I believe” means both “I want and I know.” Or “I know and I want” — whichever order one prefers.

OK. Now we know, by experience, what an ideal community is. If people gather together around the Living God — if they allow God to illuminate them with His Spirit — they become holy. Not by themselves, but through sanctification by the Holy Spirit. That much is clear.

Here, however, we must make a small but important clarification. Communion with the Living God cannot be limited by either time or place. If the Church’s Eucharist is defined as the time and place of encounter with the Omnipresent, then the believer, who regularly stands before such an encounter, must prepare for it during all the rest of his time. If that meeting lasts for one hour each week, then the entire week — indeed, the entire life that remains — must be filled with that meeting.

Let us go further

But this encounter has a strictly fixed ritual. People read precisely prescribed texts in a strictly prescribed order. How, then, can reading and singing according to the Typikon possibly give rise to perfect communication — even in the presence of the Living God?

Let us consider communication as a process — as a social process. What do we observe? As the result of any social process, we witness the devaluation of

communication, the devaluation of language. This has always been, is, and will continue to be so — everywhere and always. I will not refer to the laws of thermodynamics or to the concept of entropy, nor will I attempt to explain this phenomenon. Let us simply state the fact: any social process leads to devaluation. Any social process, by definition, consists of social interaction. And any social interaction is communication. Every interaction leads to an increase in entropy. Once again, we draw an equation between society and communication, only to discover that the devaluation of communication leads to the degradation of society. That is why our Lord warns us against fascination with society itself.

The format of this reflection does not require scientific citations — but a few cannot be avoided.

My next thought I have borrowed from a lecture by Dugin devoted to Heidegger. Heidegger speaks of the “forgetfulness of Being” (*Seinsvergessenheit*), which Dugin interprets as “the philosophical Fall.” Dugin notes that in the Germanic languages the terms *thing* (English) and *Ding* (German) derive from the Proto-Germanic *þingą* — the name of a tribal assembly, the thing, where in a sacred setting decisions and the names of things were established. In Russian, the word *veche* (the traditional East Slavic popular assembly) is functionally analogous to the thing as an assembly, though the word *veshch'* (“thing”) has a different origin (from Old Church Slavonic *věštĭ*, “property”). This analogy, though not entirely exact etymologically, is accurate in meaning: communication at such assemblies originally had a sacred character, linking language with being. The metaphorical use of words, according to Dugin, distanced language from this sacred connection — and that was the beginning of the “philosophical Fall.” Communication was sacred until the metaphorical use of words arose.

Another idea I have borrowed from an as yet unpublished work by the Igumen of Daibabe Monastery, Archimandrite Daniil (Ishmatov), devoted to liturgical consciousness. Father Daniil studies the liturgical self-awareness of the faithful and the influence of this consciousness on their social life. He argues that the degree of nearness to God — to the reality established by the priest during the Eucharist — sets the highest level of ascent possible for the community that is being spiritually guided. That is, depending on the depth of interiorization of the sacred texts achieved by the priest through personal ascetic struggle, there is formed the highest point of approach to reality attainable — or unattainable — for the society within which that priest serves. In other words, the spiritual state of the entire society is directly determined... in the altar. There is a kind of mysticism in this — one might even say a quantum mysticism. But I personally agree with this observation. A society can rise only to the height to which its “local, domestic mystic” has already risen. Whether it will rise or not — that is the question; but higher — it cannot.

We have a commandment: “Thou shalt not bear false witness.” Does this commandment not speak to us of the sacred character of communication — indeed, of the sacred character of any communication? All the more so if we are speaking of “divine communication.”

Thus we arrive at the conclusion: everything depends on who lives the Liturgy. If the believer has truly become a priest — if he has lived through the texts and the processes personally, as a conscious individual — then these texts come alive. And what happens then? The words become filled with meaning. The meanings acquire social significance. Society itself comes to life. Society begins to shape its own future. The necessary critical mass of persons is not large. The Lord said: “Where two or three are gathered together in My name.” And He, the Lord, also describes the very methodology of the process: “I am the Way, and the Truth, and the Life.”

The Way, the Truth, and the Life. “The Way” means that spiritual search is dynamic, not static. “The Truth” means that the Christian stands on the side of truth under any circumstances, even when this contradicts not only individual but collective egoism — national, religious, ideological, or any other. “The Life” means that as a result of a proper spiritual search, the believer’s strength should only increase.

So which texts and processes must the cleric interiorize in order to become a true priest? We already know what we are talking about.

Here I must return to our foundational tradition — almost forgotten by us — the Jewish one, as expressed in the texts of our Old Testament.

We all know the beginning of the Book of Genesis: “God created the heaven and the earth,” and “God saw that it was very good” (Gen. 1:31). “Very good” corresponds not to a perfect score of five, but to something like a “four plus.” Why did God create the world as “very good” and not as “perfect”? This metaphor reflects the rabbinic tradition of *tikkun olam* (תיקון עולם, “the repair of the world”), which teaches that God intentionally created the world imperfect, leaving to humankind the task of participating in its perfection.

In the Kabbalistic interpretation, the world contains scattered divine sparks that human beings are called to gather through righteous deeds, prayer, and the keeping of commandments. In the Christian context this idea takes on a universal scope: we Christians, as the new Israel (Gal. 6:16), bear responsibility for the restoration of the entire universe — and to me this thought is absolutely true.

The term Christian (*christianos*) is the Greek calque of the Hebrew *mashiah* (“anointed one”), which emphasizes our connection with Christ as the Anointed One.

To be a Christian means to bear a messianic identity, realized through active responsibility for the whole world — above all through the Church's sacraments.

In κοινωνία — the divine communication of the Eucharist — we, as the new Israel, are called to restore the bond of creation with the Logos, participating in His salvific work (Col. 1:20). The scope of this mission is universal, for the Church, as the perfect society, is directed toward all creation, transforming the world through prayer, testimony, and humanity in the fullest sense of the word.

There is yet another aspect of the Jewish tradition that, I believe, we must revive. We know how teaching was conducted in ancient times: disciples would gather around a teacher, and the teacher would instruct them. The question is: among the Jews, who was considered the best, the most beloved disciple of his teacher? The answer: the one who asked the most questions.

What does this have to do with us? We must still clarify how the cleric ought to study the sacred texts and rituals in order to become a true priest.

Our sacred texts and rituals have a very long history — generally, a tradition of two thousand years. It is evident that anyone who studies these texts encounters a multitude of contradictions — both apparent and real. How should the faithful respond? Should one declare that there are no contradictions at all, that the surface interpretation is the only correct and infallible one? Or should one begin to grapple with the contradictions, hoping to unearth the truth?

To me, the answer seems obvious. If the Lord Himself identified Himself with Truth, then we, too, must fearlessly seek the truth in every case. Only in this way can we find ourselves on the Way to the Truth that gives Life. Conversely, the nominal believer who refuses to acknowledge contradictions in the sacred texts and clings to the first interpretation that comes along, in fact bears witness to his own lack of faith — his distrust of the Source of our tradition.

Of course, one more clarification is needed. Is it necessary for a believer to become a priest in order to experience the fullness of salvation? Of course not. Thus, when I speak above about the unique role of the “priest,” I mean, in fact, the believer himself. Certainly, a “simple layperson” may attain far greater spiritual heights than the salaried and formally qualified clergy. We have all probably encountered this more than once. This is precisely what the New Testament affirms. The Apostle writes that from now on we all have the right to enter the Holy of Holies, and that we all have one great High Priest.

What does “the right to enter the sanctuary” mean in the language of the Old Testament? Another Apostle speaks directly of all believers as “a chosen race, a royal priesthood, a holy nation.” And it is in this sense that I mean “priest.”

Of course, the Church is not limited by either space or time. The function, the struggle, the liturgy of a Christian lasts throughout his entire life. The Lord explicitly destroys the dichotomy of “profane” and “sacred.” What does the “abolition of the Law” mean, after all? The tragedy of today is that the experience of what should be the simplest truths has become the privilege of isolated individuals. This gives rise to the temptation to speak in the language of an “elite club,” even though all the texts of the New Testament cry out against such exclusivity.

And finally, one more Abkhaz proverb. It says: “Satan is the father of fear.” I think that for modern Christians this thought should be closer and clearer than ever.

And, above all
Christ is risen!

On the Nature of Faith

Allow me to continue our discussion about the questions posed to the Church by the “new social classes.” We have agreed to regard the Church as a particular kind of “normal” human activity. The distinctive feature of specifically human activity, as I hope, lies in the fact that it is grounded in thought. That is, in the ideal case, a person first forms his or her worldview and only then, based on a certain picture of the world, proceeds to interact with the phenomena and energies of the surrounding environment.

Of course, one might say that this is an optimistic statement, not always supported by empirical evidence. But since we are speaking of faith, I allow myself to appeal primarily to this higher norm.

If we are speaking of human activity as such, it must be pointed out that one of the defining characteristics of the human being is subjectivity. Man is always subjective. Man reacts not to the world itself beyond his body, but to his own representation of that world.

This is a very simple and, in fact, an entirely commonplace observation — and yet it requires a certain attentiveness. In the sense that everyone knows this, but not everyone realizes the scale of this principle — or even law.

As a believer, I would add that both the experience and the dogmatics of the Church affirm that man has been given complete and absolute freedom in what concerns his inner world. Man is, quite literally, a god within his own microcosm. A human being freely — absolutely freely — chooses the premises upon which he then builds his worldview.

Let us not go too far into a quantitative analysis of that adverb “then.” It is quite possible that, in most cases, the formation of a worldview and the choice of its underlying premises occur simultaneously. Yet if a person seeks to do this consciously and well, he will inevitably be forced to start over — to reconsider everything from the beginning, reflecting seriously on the premises, or, more simply, on the metaphysics of his choice.

Here we should pause and once again reflect on what has been said — at least to make sure that we truly understand one another.

On the one hand, today we all know how many factors — even before or just after a person’s birth — decisively influence the formation and development of personality. There are so many of these factors that the vast majority prefer to conclude that human destiny is predetermined. On the other hand, we constantly

encounter examples of heroes who have managed to turn the “normal” course of events in another, more human direction. We are even educated on such examples.

But what about us? We ordinary, normal people — without superhuman abilities. And after all, who is “normal”? What is the point of waving before our eyes examples of people with supernatural capacities? What guilt do we bear in comparison?

I am a monk. I am addressing believers who live or labor, as it is said, “within the enclosure of the Church.” In the language of the Church, these heroes are called saints. Therefore, in the language of the Church, the answer to the question Who is normal — we or the heroes? may turn out to be quite unexpected, at least from the point of view of those “outside the Church.” For in the language, in the culture of the Church, it is precisely the saints who are considered normal people, while we — the so-called ordinary people — fall into the category of “simple sinners,” that is, judging by the Church’s own language, into the category of the abnormal.

Thus, the simplest and most superficial analysis of the language of the Orthodox Church already reveals its once dominant messianic identity — once dominant, but now largely forgotten.

So, we have already turned the “ordinary” picture of the world upside down. What we thought were “normal” people turn out to be the abnormal ones, and the supermen — the saints — are in fact the norm.

But statistically nothing has changed. The majority, which thought it represented the norm and suddenly found itself displaced, remains the majority. We, the ordinary and standard people — the majority — still look upon the “heroic” minority with respect, but also with the same incomprehension. Especially upon the One — the Crucified — from whom it all began.

How did they manage it? Why? And why can’t we? How can we look into their minds? How did they see this world?

From the very beginning, we agreed that the distinguishing feature of human activity is subjectivity. Therefore, I have tried to analyze every human action beginning with the analysis of subjecthooditself.

What distinguishes human subjecthoodfrom that of other mammals — even from primates? The difference lies in the fact that animals react to the world instinctively. Their instincts are inscribed in their nature and may change, but never by their own conscious choice. That is, when an animal acts instinctively, it acts objectively: it receives an external stimulus and responds to it according to a pre-set program. Even domesticated or trained animals operate within this same rule.

One might even observe that the latest creature of human hands — artificial intelligence — still acts within this same principle.

And what about us?

Earlier we discovered that a truly normal human choice is not the choice of the statistical majority, but the choice of the heroes — the choice of the minority.

It is therefore logical to assume that our next object of inquiry must be precisely this: the choice of the heroes, the choice of the minority. In order to understand specifically human activity — that is, how people act, not merely higher primates — we must grasp the logic of the heroic minority rather than that of the statistical majority.

What does our ordinary human experience tell us? What have we seen countless times? People can make completely different decisions under identical circumstances. People can believe — or not believe — in absolutely anything. Of course, there are certain patterns in human choice: the success of advertising and all kinds of manipulation are vivid proof of this. Yet, returning to actual people rather than statistics, we always find, however small, a minority that somehow manages to follow its own — though often quite standard — “right” logic.

What follows from this?

Both the one who succumbs to manipulation and the one who resists it make their choices based on some kind of inner voice. To be fully honest and consistent, we must admit that people somehow determine in advance their own criteria of “objectivity and value,” and at the moment of decision they merely follow those pre-established principles. Of course, environment and tradition matter — but not decisively. There will always be a minority that manages to follow its own course.

One of the paradoxes of modern times is that “following one’s own course” sometimes actually means realizing, in practice, the very course that the majority has proclaimed to be “official.” Statistically, this usually means a more or less successful imitation — and only the heroic minority truly follows it in reality.

And so we come to the most difficult conclusion that must be drawn:

Human beings — all human beings — every single time, in fact, make a completely free choice. Even the choice to yield to manipulation arises from a prior act of free will — the decision, at some earlier point, to renounce one’s own judgment regarding a given matter.

We form our own style and our own taste in complete freedom. We freely accept or reject our past and our future. We freely choose whom to love and whom

to hate. We are absolutely free in our decisions — even when we refuse to admit it, even to ourselves. That, too, is our free choice. The only question is whether we dare to take the step that turns freedom into an act. And that is what not everyone succeeds in doing — again, the result of free choice.

The clearest confirmation of this is found in the choice made by the heroes — for they exist. I would even say that they alone truly exist.

Incidentally, for us — for those who live within the Church — it is precisely our daily neglect of our own freedom, in other words, our neglect of the divine presence, that is the real reason for our continual “sinfulness,” which we sincerely and consciously confess again and again at every confession. We have not murdered anyone, nor robbed anyone. We simply have not received the Spirit. So why should we keep repenting? And yet we do — endlessly. Which means that we recognize that there is a reason. Is it not this lack of reverence for ourselves and for the universe in which you and I live that lies right there, on the surface, as the cause?

Ultimately, even this simple observation tells every believer that the human being has been given absolute freedom.

I am not entirely certain that my respected reader fully agrees with this radical assertion of mine. Therefore, my dear reader, allow me to develop the same logic, beginning from a different starting point.

Very well — we have rediscovered what we knew from the beginning: it is the saints, not we sinners, who are the true models to emulate. But that only raises more questions. The saints, perhaps, by their spiritual struggle attained perfect freedom of choice. But we remember — they are supermen, endowed with some special capacities. How, then, can we compare ourselves with them?

Is such an objection possible? Let us admit that it is.

Then let us look more attentively at our common human nature. We all know that we were created in the image and likeness of God. What does this mean? It means that we are, in some way, kin to God. I will now attempt to describe this reality in a way that is, from any theological or dogmatic standpoint, quite improper — but, I hope, as humanly understandable as possible.

“We are God’s relatives by blood, by flesh.”

Taken literally, this formula is, of course, heresy. The Incarnation changed much—if not everything. One could say that the Incarnation restored us to “the norm.” Yet the fact remains that our animal nature is not the basis of our kinship with God. Thus, the statement “We are God’s relatives by blood, by flesh” can easily lend itself to heretical interpretation. Still, from a human, experiential point of view, one could

hardly say it better. Therefore, I leave the phrase as it is, in order to continue my reasoning.

We are related to God in two ways. First, by the way we are constituted—one might say that kinship with God is built into our very “design.” This static aspect of our kinship is called image. But there is also a dynamic aspect: the way we function, the way this image is realized. This dynamic aspect is called likeness.

What belongs to this “image,” and what to this “likeness”? Let us look around us. Whatever distinguishes us—and distinguishes us for the better—from animals, for example from primates, is the image of God within us. Today, we can refine this model: to our superiority over primates we can add superiority over artificial intelligence. That which we can do but no artificial intelligence can—that is often the manifestation of the image and likeness of God.

I admit that the model I propose is more negative than the reader might expect, describing what the image is not, rather than what it is. Yet I think such a negative definition may be more intuitively comprehensible to the reader than a textbook-style, formal definition.

So far, everything seems simple and clear: that by which we differ, that by which we transcend our environment, is precisely the image and likeness of God in us. In other words, we have found that very Gospel field in which the precious pearl is hidden.

If we know in what our personal image and likeness consist, then our spiritual life must focus on the renewal of the image and the restoration of the likeness. My dear reader, I trust you understand that many synonyms could be used here—but that is not what matters. What matters is that now we know exactly—one might even say technologically—what and how we must do when we participate in all ecclesial processes and events.

If we know. Therefore, we must delve as deeply as possible into the meanings of image and likeness in order to build our presence—our participation in the entire ecclesial dynamic—as operationally and effectively as possible.

We know that God is perfection, that God is at the very least infinite. Therefore, we must be prepared for the fact that on our journey toward God there can and must be various stages — from the very first, “human” ones to the most exalted, “divine” ones, which are, in all likelihood, simply unattainable for “statistically standard” human beings. It is clear that I am trying to discern the very first steps, fully understanding that the beginning of the path is not yet the path itself. On the way toward God, the most important thing begins when God Himself takes the seeker of God under His own guidance. Such a miracle, of course, is the goal. But we

are speaking of a process or an event that we cannot in any way control. Therefore, let us begin at the beginning — from the very beginning.

In what, then, do we surpass our neighbors on this planet? What constitutes our royal dignity? Why do we keep them in zoos, terrariums, and aquariums — and not the other way around? (Though, it must be said, it was we humans who also invented concentration camps.)

Once again, let us begin from the very beginning. For example, we are capable of communication. Animals, too, seem to be able to understand and transmit certain signals. But there is a fundamental difference between human communication and the grunting or growling of animals. The signals animals transmit are always reactions to the present moment or to the immediate past. Man, on the other hand, through communication, can model the future. He can even model what does not exist.

Thus, even the capacity for falsehood is an expression of the royal position of man in the universe. I trust there is no need to elaborate at length on the connection between speech and thought. We think. It is precisely our capacity for thought that forms the foundation for all the other qualities that tradition attributes to the image of God in man — such qualities as freedom of will, self-determination, humanity, logic, creativity, and, consequently, the royal position we occupy in relation to all other creation.

Here it is important to add a few more qualities: godlikeness and the immortality of the soul. First, of course, this list could be extended indefinitely. Second, it should be understood that the boundaries between these qualities are fluid; one often flows into another. Nevertheless, we have roughly outlined the potential whose realization, in the likeness of God, should lead us to the fullness of communion with Him.

Once again, let me emphasize: I am addressing the ordinary majority as a representative of that same ordinary majority. Like all “ordinary” people, I stand on the very first rung of the well-known Ladder — the Ladder of Divine Ascent of St. John Climacus — and I look upward from below. I do not see the “upper” rungs, and therefore I will speak only of what I can see — of the “lower” steps.

So, in order to understand in what our likeness to God is expressed, let us try to model the development of the qualities we have just listed. In this, by the way, the Gospel can help us. John 14:6: “Jesus said to him, I am the way, and the truth, and the life; no one comes to the Father except through Me.” Moreover, a little later in the same Gospel we find the development of the same idea. John 18:37: “Jesus answered, You say that I am a king. For this reason I was born, and for this reason I

came into the world — to bear witness to the truth. Everyone who is of the truth hears My voice.”

Thus we see that Jesus links the spiritual life of His followers directly with truth. Our Lord describes the spiritual life of His disciples in three words: the way, the truth, and the life.

We stand at the foot of the Ladder. Therefore, what do we see when we look at this formula — the way, the truth, and the life?

The Way means movement. From Christ’s perspective, spiritual life presupposes growth, evolution, change. Spiritual life cannot be static — something you understood once and then chew over for the rest of your life. Faith must grow throughout life. It is surely no accident that our Lord pointed us to the dynamic character of spiritual life.

The Truth. “I am the Truth.” “For this reason I came into the world — to bear witness to the truth. Everyone who is of the truth hears My voice.” Does this require decoding? Is it not obvious that for Jesus, the spiritual life of His followers must consist precisely in bearing witness to the truth? And what does bearing witness to the truth mean if not, first of all, seeking the truth? A Christian is a Christian to the extent that he stands on the side of truth. Truth is often uncomfortable — especially for those in power, especially for the majority. So what is to be done? To begin with, look at the Cross — at the Truth crucified upon it. And then, always and everywhere, follow the truth, however inconvenient it may be.

In fact, the Lord very clearly warns His followers against falling into zealotry. “Do not give what is holy to dogs, nor cast your pearls before swine, lest they trample them under their feet and turn and tear you to pieces.” These are the words of the Lord Himself — the Gospel of Matthew 7:6. And again: “Behold, I send you out as sheep among wolves; therefore be wise as serpents and innocent as doves.” (Matthew 10:16).

We see His reaction to His accusers at the trial — silence. He simply ignored them. Is His behavior an example for us? Does that even need to be asked?

So, we have begun our spiritual life. We have set out on the path of seeking truth — and where are we supposed to arrive? What does the Lord Himself tell us about this?

Life. “I am the Life.”

Strange. We might have expected to hear about the Cross, about suffering, about patience — at the very least. And yet we are told: Life. What does that mean? It means that, according to the words of Christ, spiritual life must lead to the

intensification, the increase of life itself. What kind of alien-sounding nonsense is that! Well, roughly speaking, it means that as a believer advances and grows along “the path toward truth,” the strength that sustains that very movement should increase more and more. How else can one interpret “the Way, the Truth, and the Life”? There is no other way. Our Lord clearly testifies that as one “grows in faith,” one’s strength for faith — one’s life — must become greater and greater.

And if we do not see this happening in our lives? Then we are not on the path the Lord has prescribed for us. My condolences! The law of the excluded middle is universal in this universe.

Returning to the image and likeness: we have sketched, however roughly, the image of God in man. Then we have likewise outlined, in very broad strokes, how this image should be realized in likeness.

And where, in all this, are the superhuman abilities? Where is heroism supposed to come from? And, most importantly — where is freedom of choice?

It seems to me that everything begins with a choice — the choice in favor of truth. When a person makes an inner, conscious decision to be always and everywhere on the side of truth, something happens.

Indeed, it seems that the most important events take place within. Declarations are far less significant. In any case, they have real power only when they rest on deep, strong inner decisions. When a person discovers himself within his inner world — within his own microcosm — he can no longer remain merely a part of the social whole, merely a projection of external experience. When, in the process of seeking truth, a person finds himself — his boundless inner world — there will inevitably arise the question of how real that inner world is, and how it is connected with the outer one. An honest, consistent search for meaning, a search for logic, will inevitably lead to the First Meaning — to the Logos of all logoi.

Human language — any human language — describes the relationship between man and truth in a remarkably revealing way. In every language, these relationships are expressed in personal terms. One can draw near to truth. One can turn away from truth. Truth can be offended. Truth can be honored. Truth can give thanks. Truth can punish. We observe this in every language. Every person, even the most unbelieving, speaks of his relationship with truth as if it were an interpersonal relationship. Is this not evidence that it is precisely one’s relationship with Truth that makes a human being a person in the true sense?

Why, in the language of the Church, is baptism — that is, baptism in the name of Truth — called birth? It is precisely by “putting on” Truth that we are born as true persons, that is, as images of the divine Person.

Why, in the language of the Church, is sin called death? Because when communication with Truth is lost, the person within man dies. Man loses the image.

Now it becomes clear why the Church speaks of “eternal life” and “eternal death.”

At the close of the key epoch in the history of thought, Aristotle formulated the central question of philosophy: “What is being?” A thousand years earlier, at the burning bush, Moses received the answer to that question — one that had not yet even been posed. The canonical version reads that the answer was: “I AM THAT I AM.” In other words, the answer to the question “What is being?” is not what but who.

Let us continue our observations. When a person raises in his life the question of truth, we always observe a radical expansion of the scale of personality. As far as I understand, modern psychology has not yet taken up the study of the messianic type of personality; thus, there is as yet no scientific methodology for measuring the “scale of personality.” We may only add that, as practice shows, persons of this type always know their mission. If I am not mistaken — or at least, if I correctly understand human language — mission always implies vision. Note how even the attempt to approach truth exerts a physiological effect upon a person! Does that really need explanation?

To sum up:

We have ended by considering the psychology — or even the physiology — of the messianic type of personality. Let us recall: what does Christ mean? Yes, Christ is the Greek calque of the Hebrew word that literally means “anointed.” And how does this Hebrew word sound in the original? Correct — Mashiach, that is, Messiah.

So we return to the beginning: what, then, does Christian or Christianity mean? It means following the Messiah — or, in essence, messianic.

If we are truly united with our Messiah, is it surprising that our very physiology changes? For me, the circle is complete. Everything falls into place. I hope it is also clear to you, my dear reader.

If we do not merely declare our allegiance to Christ but strive, in this real life, to follow Him, a number of questions inevitably arise. I have tried to address some of them. We seem to have discovered that the interiorization of the teaching and identity of Christ transforms us—and transforms us radically, I believe even at the physiological level.

Let us continue these observations. We are discussing how Christian faith—faith in Jesus Christ as God and Savior—can help us restructure our lives on different,

new, more “spiritual” foundations. In other words, we are trying to explore the function of faith.

I propose that we pose the question precisely in that way: what is the function of faith? What can faith give us—and what should it give?

From a practical standpoint, Christian faith must help the believer solve at least two problems.

The first problem is adequacy.

From the moment of our birth, God has endowed us with the ability to create our inner world. Unfortunately, we usually make use of this capacity without proper attention or reverence. As a result, instead of developing and deepening an inner world that could help us understand and master the outer one, we usually construct a flat, almost two-dimensional—at any rate, monochrome—model of reality that covers only the zone of direct contact. Then we try to hide within this primitive fiction from the responsibility that genuine contact with the fullness of reality demands.

For three centuries we have been declaring our allegiance to the values of the Enlightenment, and yet we have still not raised the question of the quality—the degree of consciousness—of the human being. Man still lives, in the vast majority of cases, by instincts and unexamined impulses. This is especially strange to observe within the Christian, ecclesial milieu.

In the Church it is customary to speak much about humility. Humility is often, perhaps too often, presented as the highest of virtues. Yet humility is usually understood as some sort of supernatural quality that appears suddenly in a saint as the result of superhuman effort—typically of an ascetic kind. I fear this is once again a problem of language.

The Greek word that denotes the opposite of humility is ὑπερηφάνεια (hyperēphaneia). In Greek it is simple: it means “to appear greater than you are.” Interestingly, Greek also has a positive analogue of “pride”—καμαρώνω, καμάρι—that is, a neutral or even positive sense of dignity. This approach at least helps us to understand the positive function of humility.

It is not about self-deprecation; it is about natural adequacy. Is it really necessary to explain that inadequacy is bad—and, in the end, simply unprofitable?

Thus, the first task that a healthy Christian faith must accomplish is to teach the believer adequacy. In the language of faith, this quality is called humility. A believing person must learn to see the world as it truly is—not to live in a world of illusions, fantasies, and fears. It is humility, therefore, that should urge the believer

onto the path of philosophical search—if it is true humility, and not the mere talk of humility.

And what, then, is the second, no less important task that Christian faith must be able to accomplish?

The second, equally fundamental task that Christian faith must fulfill is the preservation of optimism.

We have agreed that, first of all, we must see the world as it really is. And the world around us is, in truth, always a kind of hell. Every human life is, in one way or another, a tragedy. And yet, within this hell, we must be able to see Heaven—to see Paradise.

Schizophrenia?

We profess that our God is omnipresent and omnipotent. That means He is present in all this horror. It also means that He bears responsibility for all this horror and for all these tragedies. It also means that within all this horror and within all these tragedies there is logic and meaning—human logic and human meaning.

We agreed that we are speaking of “normal” people—that is, of people with a messianic identity. By the way, that means the kind of person who, in any circumstance, is ready to seek a solution to the problem, rather than to despair because of the problem itself. And these are the people who believe that the Kingdom of Heaven awaits them—a Kingdom in which all is perfect. They know that their life is preparation for life in the Kingdom of Heaven. They know, and have confirmed it many times, that their Heavenly Father will always show them the right way. And if that way once again turns out to be the Way of the Cross—they are used to it.

The experience of real Christian life is the experience of seeking meaning and truth, the experience of constant self-education. Standing before Truth—what the Bible calls “walking before God”—brings its own kind of adrenaline. Yet people remain human. Pain remains pain. And sacrifice remains sacrifice. But the experience itself becomes different.

A believing person perceives the scale of problems differently. The constant search for God’s presence teaches him to see that presence where others do not. Of course, God’s silence in such a life is also felt much more acutely. This knowledge—or firm hope—comes only with experience. And this experience has a beginning but no end. There will always be evidence that “you have not yet sought enough.” In the end, what always remains is humility. Humility and gratitude.

It is a simple logical operation. Once again, something unacceptable happens; once again, all hopes collapse. And once again there remains the same question: “Why, Lord?”—or, in another form, “When will this all end, Lord?” In any case, you do not break off communication with God. You lay responsibility upon Him—not upon some fool of the moment—and you wait for His answer.

And there is no answer. The answer will come when the pain has already passed and when the answer itself is no longer needed. But the answer will come.

And that is what we call experience.

With experience, indeed, comes peace. Fewer illusions, fewer emotions.

To live in hell as if in paradise.
To live without God as if with God—these are not my words. They are the words of my abbot, Father Daniel (Ishmatov).

And yes, with experience comes optimism—not the crude, forced optimism of Soviet youth rallies, but the ability to see the bright side. Of course, there are situations in which no bright side can be found. But optimism—faith itself—will remain always.

We agreed, at the very beginning, that faith is a choice. Faith presupposes conscious control over one’s own thinking. If a Christian has learned such control, he will never lose his faith. That means he will always be able to see God. Because faith is a continual effort, a constant inner struggle.

At this point, a number of questions arise. If we take seriously everything written above, then Christians, it seems, must constantly act as a kind of experts—people capable of finding a way out of any situation. Frankly speaking, this partly explains how a peninsula on the western edge of the continent of Asia suddenly decided that it was a continent in itself—and, moreover, managed to impose that audacious assumption as a norm upon the rest of humanity. But what has happened to today’s Christians, who, thank God, now exist on every continent and in every land?

Here allow me to share another of my intuitions.

The experience of seeking Truth allows one to see the world differently. To identify oneself with Truth ennobles; it truly places the believer in a royal position. A practicing Christian better understands the laws of the world—the laws of the universe.

There is a word in English—integrity. I do not know an equivalent for it in the “Orthodox languages.” As a Caucasian, I find it a deeply resonant and

comprehensible concept—though that does not mean I know a proper equivalent in my own Abkhaz tongue. Why do I mention this? Because Christian life unquestionably grants the believer, and teaches the believer, a greater integrity—and therefore greater strength.

A Christian is no Christian unless his life affirms eternal values and eternal norms. From this arises an interesting consequence: experiential knowledge of the norm allows one to see the future. The experience of standing before Truth teaches a binary vision of reality: sin versus virtue, good versus evil, life versus death, truth versus fiction. This is an extraordinarily important skill—one that modern humanity is rapidly losing. If a Christian does not drift along with the current, as everyone else does—and by definition, a Christian is a nonconformist—then he creates his own current. A Christian is consciously and voluntarily mobilized for the pursuit of truth and humanity. Not “for a war for truth and humanity,” but “for the search for truth and humanity”. That is why, for the past two thousand years, movements of this kind have triumphed. Christian movements ceased to triumph when they began to live, as the Apostle says, “according to the elements of this world” (Gal. 5:16–17; Col. 2:20–23). Modern Christians must recover the traditional Christian understanding of knowledge—not as a mere method for solving problems or mastering the world (and often not even the world, but merely one’s immediate surroundings), but as a path toward Truth.

This is a very interesting and very important observation—one that was already made by Socrates and that underlies the dogmatic definitions of the Ecumenical Councils. There exists a direct correlation between a person’s moral state—his integrity—and his cognitive capacity. In fact, this entire treatise is devoted to that very idea.

Why was a believer once required to have an orthodox understanding of a given dogma? Even in our own times—when, unlike in late antiquity, higher education is by no means rare—we do not expect every seminary graduate or theology student to understand the subtleties of dogmatic theology. Yet in the age of the Ecumenical Councils, this was taken for granted. It was assumed that literally every abbot, and all the more every bishop, without the aid of any “Wikipedia,” possessed his own right—that is, orthodox—understanding of each new dogmatic question.

What does this tell us? Were the Fathers of the “Golden Age” more academic? Clearly not. The Christians of that Golden Age knew in practice that right belief (orthodoxy) in dogma presupposes right ethos—that is, a right way of life.

To conclude: we have agreed that faith is, above all, a mode of thinking. Christian faith implies the formation and development of a messianic identity. I

believe we have managed to clarify, at least a little, what the formation and development of that very messianic—that is, truly Christian—identity means. We have also tried to glimpse how a practicing Christian, who strives to form and live out this messianic identity, must think—that is, how he must believe.

If I am not mistaken, the principal traits of the Christian messianic type of personality are adequacy and humility.

Toward a Metaphysics of Personality

It seems to me that in the previous part of the treatise we have approached an understanding of the person as it is postulated by Christianity. The discussion has been about faith. We proceeded from the premise that the activity of a believing person within the bounds of the Church can be studied as “ordinary” activity—as any other form of human activity. As a result, we arrived at several rather unusual observations. And, most importantly, we discovered that the believer—that is, in the Christian perspective, the true human being—inevitably functions differently, precisely because he thinks differently.

Let me remind you that the Greek word *μετάνοια* (*metanoia*) can be more accurately translated, at least literally, as “re-thinking” or “reconsideration.” In other words, re-thinking is the literal meaning of the term that in Christian culture has come to be rendered as repentance. We all know that Christian life—the life of faith—begins with repentance. I propose that we first use these words in their original sense, and then much becomes clearer. This means that the Christian life—the life of faith—begins with re-thinking.

I must repeat this idea once more. I am trying to understand what Christianity looks like if we describe Christian practices using the words themselves in their original, literal meanings. This, in fact, is the method of the present inquiry.

Now let us return to this notion of re-thinking. What does the language—Greek, in this case—tell us? There was a man. Then he came to believe—he became a Christian. From that moment, he lives differently. Where does this difference begin? Correct — it begins with re-thinking. That is, at the moment of conversion, the newly baptized must inevitably re-think his previous experience, the entire inertia of his former life. He must reorder his priorities, for example. In any case, what is required is an intense investment in the process of thought.

A believing Christian cannot simply “believe.” He must—literally must—creatively internalize and appropriate the teaching of the Church. As we know, the Church has been forming and developing this teaching for two thousand years.

The term Orthodoxy itself carries a distinctly dogmatic and historical meaning. An Orthodox Christian is, first of all, a Christian who knows the issues of the Ecumenical Councils and is fully in agreement with their decisions. The less “prepared” Christians, from the standpoint of both the letter and the spirit of those Councils—which, as we recall, remain binding for all Orthodox—fall under the category of the flock, who more or less passively agree with the views of Christians in the strict sense of the word.

There are many so-called “dark” passages in the Gospel that, in reality, express a certain pessimism regarding the prospects of Christianity ever becoming a social ideology. Matthew 13:10–11 belongs precisely to such passages. And since in our present inquiry we are attempting to restore the image of the complete human person as understood by Jesus, His anthropological observations that follow in this passage are of the utmost importance for us. This continuation is so remarkable that I will quote it in full:

Matthew 13:13–17

13. Therefore I speak to them in parables, because seeing they do not see, and hearing they do not hear, nor do they understand;
14. and in them is fulfilled the prophecy of Isaiah, which says: “By hearing you will hear and shall not understand, and seeing you will see and not perceive;
15. for the hearts of this people have grown dull. Their ears are hard of hearing, and their eyes they have closed, lest they should see with their eyes and hear with their ears, lest they should understand with their heart and turn, so that I should heal them.”
16. But blessed are your eyes, for they see, and your ears, for they hear;
17. for assuredly, I say to you, that many prophets and righteous men desired to see what you see, and did not see it, and to hear what you hear, and did not hear it.

What do we observe here? How does the Lord describe those who truly believe—that is, in the terminology of this study, the complete human beings? Our Lord and Savior affirms that the “true believers” are those who see and hear. Those, however, who “do not see and do not hear” belong to a very different category—and the context of this passage leaves no doubt as to who constitutes the majority, indeed the overwhelming majority.

Again, in the spirit of this inquiry, it is logical to ask: What, then, should this majority do? With all due respect to democratic values and norms, all four Gospels leave no doubt whose opinion the Lord regards—and whose He equates with the crowd, with the voice of the stones (Luke 19:40).

So what should “the stones” do? Probably, first of all, they should not be satisfied with the status of mere “listeners,” but should strive to move into the category of the “seeing.” And secondly—and far more importantly—they must not silence the few, rare voices of those who still “see and hear”.

So far, we have been speaking—or attempting to speak—about who is truly a person, a genuine personality. We now approach a rather painful branch of the same question: What kind of gathering can truly be called a “gathering of persons”—that is,

the Church? From what we observe in the Gospel passage above, the Church is that assembly in which the seeing speak—and not the other way around.

Let us return to the main theme. Let us leave sociology and meritocracy for better times!

We see that a complete person—one who preserves and develops the divine image and likeness—must necessarily see and hear. But see and hear what?

Matthew, chapter 13:

14. And in them is fulfilled the prophecy of Isaiah, which says: “By hearing you will hear, and shall not understand; and seeing you will see, and not perceive;

15. For the hearts of this people have grown dull. Their ears are hard of hearing, and their eyes they have closed, lest they should see with their eyes and hear with their ears, lest they should understand with their heart and turn, so that I should heal them.”

What is this about?

In the previous part of our inquiry, we agreed that the complete person is the one who has placed the search for truth at the foundation of his existence. The search for truth is a path—and this path leads to life, to eternal life. The Lord affirms that such people “see and hear.”

Does this mean their eyesight and hearing literally improve? That they constantly behold the light of Tabor? The Gospel texts do not say so. Yet they clearly continue the Old Testament tradition in their understanding of messianic psychology.

Those who possess this messianic psychology necessarily see and/or hear. Therefore, a person who has found his mission must also see the path toward its fulfillment. In another, equally valid version, he may hear it. Let us not forget how the central prayer of Israel begins: “Shema, Israel!”—“Hear, O Israel!” And let us recall what Socrates said about the voice of his daimonion, the inner genius that guided him.

Conclusion:

The person who softens his hardened heart and opens his closed eyes—see the quotation above—will inevitably be healed. And then he will begin to see and/or hear.

The “normal” person is the messianic type of person. On the path of seeking truth, he attains life. To express this formula in a way more familiar to believers: on the path of seeking eternal truth, the believer attains eternal life. Inevitably and necessarily attains it.

The believing person—that is, in the language of this study, the normal, the authentic person—inevitably knows his mission in this life. He has found this mission and follows it. This path is accompanied by visions and/or voices. And it is precisely these visions that convince the believer, with certainty, that he is walking the right path.

I would suggest replacing these somewhat slippery notions of “visions and voices” with inner conviction. After all, we already live in the third millennium. After Marx and Freud, it is no longer possible to speak in the language of medieval or even ancient psychology. We are describing the same reality, but using terminology appropriate to the new age.

Here we touch upon another theme—one around which our inquiry has long been circling, though we have not yet addressed it directly: the theme of the microcosm.

Every human being is the author and the absolute master of his own inner world—his microcosm. The problem is that, in practice, we react not to the external world itself but to what we have imagined—to our inner world. There are, of course, many external factors that influence the formation of this inner world. But the person himself—his consciousness, his self-awareness—acts as a constant filter, allowing or refusing to allow these “external factors” to affect the “inner” realm.

The task of the human being, first and foremost, is to become himself. The task is to be—and to be truly. To become the master, the subject, of one’s own life. To become a human being—a full, authentic human being—not a fiction, not an appendage to something or someone else. Still less can a human being be a simulacrum.

Faith in God begins with faith in oneself. A person must accept that his thoughts, desires, dreams, victories and defeats, his past and his future—all of these are real, and that they matter above all else. Questions such as “to be or not to be,” or “am I a trembling creature or do I have the right,” should not even arise. Where such questions arise, it becomes difficult to speak of Christianity at all.

The word devil means “slanderer.” If a person believes the slander—against the universe, against humanity, against the Creator of the universe and of all human beings—then no spiritual life can be built upon such a foundation. A spiritual life rooted in the Trinitarian nature of the Creator and in faith in the Incarnation cannot arise from such self-denial.

We must choose life and light from the beginning—and always, everywhere, remain on the side of life and light. Otherwise, psychological fluctuations begin, which at best waste our time and strength without meaning.

A person must, without fail, become the full master of his inner world. By his own deliberate choice, he must form his relationship to his past and shape his vision of the future. It is a tragedy if anyone else gains the ability to interfere in what happens within this Holy of Holies.

To learn how to protect and properly cultivate this sacred space, a person must learn to distinguish truth from falsehood, reality from fiction. He must be able to perceive how his worldview influences the quality of the psychic processes that define his personality. That worldview either strengthens him—or destroys him.

How should one choose a worldview? How should one form it? How should one change or adapt it? These are all extremely important and entirely practical questions.

How can I find myself?
How can I discern my path, my mission?
Who am I? Where do I come from? Why am I here?

Such questions—and there are many of them—inevitably arise before any person who truly wishes to mature, to become the genuine master of his life and his destiny.

Let us take another passage from the Gospel in which Jesus describes His understanding of the “true” human being:

John, chapter 8:

- 31. Then Jesus said to those Jews who believed in Him, “If you abide in My word, you are truly My disciples;
- 32. and you shall know the truth, and the truth shall make you free.”
- 33. They answered Him, “We are Abraham’s descendants and have never been in bondage to anyone. How can You say, ‘You will be made free’?”
- 34. Jesus answered them, “Truly, truly, I say to you, whoever commits sin is a slave of sin.
- 35. And a slave does not remain in the house forever, but a son remains forever.
- 36. Therefore, if the Son makes you free, you shall be free indeed.”

A true human being is a free human being.

Throughout His earthly ministry, Jesus consistently links spiritual life with knowledge. What is “freedom from sin,” if not spiritual life itself? Jesus unequivocally connects spiritual life with both knowledge and freedom. What more can be added to this?

The entire history of the Church demonstrates a strict correlation between morality and cognitive ability—precisely what the Savior speaks about in the passages quoted above. There is a whole range of concepts that belong to the moral sphere but, in essence, describe the quality of cognitive and, if you will, intellectual activity. I would even say—of mental performance.

Consider terms such as sincerity and integrity. The English word integrity is, in English usage, practically synonymous with righteousness. The same applies to righteousness itself. These words may appear to refer to moral qualities, but what do they describe, if not the quality of thought?

When the Lord speaks of “straining out a gnat and swallowing a camel” (Matthew 23:24), what does He mean if not the quality of intellectual discernment? In that same chapter, He goes on to speak very clearly about the necessity of distinguishing essence from appearance. What is that, if not an intellectual process?

When, in ecclesiastical circles, one often hears the advice to abandon intellectual inquiry into Scripture and spiritual life altogether, and instead to “open the heart” in some purely emotional way, I see in that nothing but the standard obscurantist manipulation.

Our central Gospel begins with the formula:

“In the beginning was the Logos.”

Not the Spirit, not the Heart!

In the beginning was the Logos.

And only in the end—only after the redemptive mission of the Logos—was the Spirit revealed to humankind. Not the other way around!

So why, in our spiritual life, do we insist on putting the cart before the horse?! The Spirit does not come unless one has first encountered and accepted the Logos.

Jesus said to him, “I am the way, and the truth, and the life. No one comes to the Father except through Me.” (John 14:6)

For me, this is the formula of Christian spiritual life.

And who could deny that it is so?

If this is true—if John 14:6 provides the foundational model and paradigm for Christian spiritual life—then why are we still searching for a black cat in a dark room, especially when the cat was never there in the first place?

No one is saying that emotions must be switched off. But one must turn to emotion at the right time. The emotional sphere is only part of the spiritual quest. It

cannot replace it entirely—just as the intellectual quest cannot wholly replace the affective, intuitive dimension.

Everything must have its measure and its proper time.

Thus we see that the right structuring—or rather, the right ordering—of one's inner world (cf. Matt. 13:14–15 and John 8:31–36) leads to the capacity to see and hear the Truth—with a capital T. These are still the first steps of the Ladder. We are still among the majority. Transcendental contemplation begins higher up—how much higher, I do not know.

Allow me to take a risk. I think we can now approach something that everyone has long known—or thinks they do. As an example, I suggest we reflect on the dogma of the Holy Trinity. Even a simple, intellectual—non-mystical but serious—reflection on it already reveals much, if one truly thinks about it.

Let us take for discussion one of the principal feasts of the Church—Theophany (the Baptism of Christ). Some have managed to reduce it merely to a remembrance of a certain Epiphany. In any case, most clergy seem to believe that the main point is the blessing of the water—indeed, of the whole universe. But what actually happened?

Jesus comes to John to be “baptized.” Of course, before the Cross this cannot yet be called our sacrament of baptism; it was a ritual immersion in water. At the moment when Jesus comes up from the water, the voice of the Father sounds from heaven, and the Holy Spirit descends upon the Son in the form of a dove—as John saw it. For the first time in the history of creation, the Most Holy Trinity revealed Itself to humankind: the Son rises from the water, the Father proclaims Him His Son, and the Holy Spirit descends upon Him.

The meaning of this feast is that the three Divine Persons were manifested to us, and that their mutual relations are radically different from ordinary human ones. Here language begins to falter—but we must still try to speak.

There are Three of Them—and yet He is One. For both the Son and the Spirit are, in essence, in nature, the Father. And yet each Person gives Himself wholly to the Others.

We human beings too share one nature: there are now more than eight billion of us. Yet we live mostly in a mode of rivalry and struggle for resources. Such is our present competitive ontology—a mode of being in which each “I” is enclosed within its own interest and forced to compete in order to survive.

But in the Theophany another mode of being is revealed—a solidary ontology. The three Divine Persons, sharing one and the same nature, consciously and freely

give everything to one another. Their “egoism” is as it were reversed: to give to the Other is not to lose but to gain, for there “to give” means “to receive,” and “yours” there means “mine,” while “mine” means “yours.”

We now live in a competitive ontology, but in the world to come God will “rectify” creation, and it will become solidaric. One can point to another difference of the coming world: in the future world falsehood will be impossible — not merely forbidden, but physically impossible. In contrast to the present logos-fugal ontology, which by its nature tends toward entropy, we are destined for a logos-centric ontology in which it will be impossible to separate action from meaning.

Those who prepare themselves for such a truly human reality are learning already now to live in love; but those who remain in the logic of competition and manipulation risk being unprepared for the new world — the world of eternity.

And how could we have guessed this without Revelation? We could not. For this very purpose faith is given—faith as intuition, as the capacity to perceive what is to come in the light of God. Yet we often suppress this capacity in order to appear “rational” and “mature.”

To find a genuine balance between one’s inner world and external reality, one must rely not only on reason, but also on the intuition of faith and on the data of Revelation—on what God has already shown us about our future. For me, intuition and affective searching are stages of intellectual inquiry; I do not oppose them. In their proper time, each becomes a source of the “needed” knowledge.

Consider the Incarnation. What does it mean for me—today, now, in my small, unsuccessful life, in my personal tragedy?

God has taken my life, my nature, and joined it to His own. And in my life there appeared a meaning that had not existed before—and that, even now, is not always visible. And in the life of every other human being, a new dimension has appeared. What kind of dimension? A divine one.

He who has ears to hear, let him hear! And much, indeed, is said about the eyes as well.

Being. Personhood. These are categories that are most obvious and most evident, yet at the same time least accessible to analysis. This chapter is titled *Toward a Metaphysics of Personality*. In other words, I do not even expect to be able to describe the metaphysics of so ineffable and elusive a phenomenon as personality. On the one hand, we are speaking of facts of our experience, and so we assume that this belongs to the sphere of cataphatic knowledge and attempt some verbalization. But as soon as we begin to verbalize, we realize that we are dealing precisely with the most profound apophatic reality. And so all that remains for us is to hang up a

few signposts—left, right, and then again—and beyond that, one must discern the way oneself.

Let me attempt to summarize what has been said.

Faith begins with re-thinking. Faith requires understanding and assimilation of the Church's experience. The believer is given the capacity to see and hear. The Church is the assembly of persons. The Church is the assembly of the seeing. The true believer is the true person.

All of this pertains to what is still "ordinary," not yet supernatural experience. The person is a phenomenon of messianic character. The person is always the master of his inner world. The "stones" are not persons. Faith in God begins with faith in oneself. The person knows his mission. There exists a direct correlation between moral qualities and cognitive capacities. The person perceives his mission, his place in the world, and his place beside God.

The emotional sphere is but one part of spiritual searching; it cannot replace it entirely—just as spiritual search cannot be replaced entirely by intellectual exploration. Everything must have its measure and its proper time.

The vision of the ontology of the world to come is the foundation of faith. It is the living of a solidaric ontology that gives strength to remain human, even within our still competitive one.

Therefore, the person can bear the Cross. The person always bears the Cross. And the person has the strength to bear it—because he knows how and why to do so.

The Russian conquerors of the Caucasus used to call my ancestors "predators". Allow me to add two small strokes to the psychology of predators. My mother—may she rest in peace—repeated two Abkhaz proverbs to me throughout her life. The first: "A word spoken twice begins to stink." And the second: "If I told you what to do, and you did it, then it was not you who did it—it was I." In Abkhaz, the second proverb requires almost half as many words. As you might guess, in present-day Abkhazia I observe nothing of the kind anymore.

That was about predators. But what about Christians—in the language of this work, what about "normal human beings"?

As we have agreed, the Christian sees. The Christian sees God, sees the universe—the creation of God—and sees his own place and role within it. The Christian knows that he has been sent into this universe to fulfill his mission. He also knows that this universe has been given to him precisely so that he might fulfill that mission.

An important feature of the Christian is that he knows how to see the Other as the Other truly is. The Christian does not invent an image of the Other; he studies the Other with respect, so as to know how best—indeed, how most effectively—to interact with the Other. This knowledge aids the Christian in accomplishing his mission.

More broadly, the Christian regards knowledge, skill, and competence with deep reverence. The Christian stands before his God in the sphere of the Logos. The Christian God has revealed Himself to the Christian as God the Logos. It is precisely in the process of seeking truth that the Christian finds both his God and his mission.

To “fulfill the mission” means that, this time, as it were, it is not yet final. This time we are, so to speak, taking an exam. Depending on the state in which we emerge from this exam, we shall be granted access to the next, eternal phase.

People do not respect themselves; therefore, they do not value the talents that God has given them. And for that reason they often fail to grasp what they have already seen and heard.

Nietzsche long ago described the relative nature of man with uncanny precision:

“What is great in man is that he is a bridge and not a goal: what is lovable in man is that he is a transition and a destruction.”

“Man is something that shall be overcome.”

— Thus Spoke Zarathustra

Isaac Asimov, in his three-part novel *The Gods Themselves*, expressed the same intuition. In the second part, he depicts a race of three-gendered beings whose ecstatic union gives birth to higher beings.

Even unbelievers, then, perceive that the human being in his present state is an unfinished creature.

Of course, I do not mean biological transformation, as Nietzsche probably did. But for some reason, in every language there exists the phrase “a true human being.” That means that everyone, many times, has encountered untrue humans. And this, in turn, means that the goal of Christianity is to give birth to and nurture the true human being—in other words, the human being as such.

What amazes me is the blindness of the ritually pious. Why do we not think about the meaning of the words we utter millions of times? We call baptism birth. We call sin death. We call virtuous life eternal life, and life in sin eternal perdition. What do these words tell us? What do we ourselves bear witness to?

What does “life in Christ” mean? What does “the Sun of Righteousness” mean? Why do we call the monks’ principal task “noetic work” or “the noetic struggle”?

Why does it never occur to us that all these words must first of all be taken literally?

The Christian, in Christ, attains true, complete life. The Christians of the early centuries spoke of Pleroma—fullness—as a given. And we—what have we traded that fullness of life for?

Forgive me for a harsh question — but is our Orthodox Typikon truly designed for life after the Incarnation? Or is this Typikon still merely waiting for redemption? Do we really understand the phrase “Christ is risen!” literally? Or is it, for us, still some distant, not entirely real prospect?

Does the modern Church know that those who gather for prayer are Christs? Already saved, already deified Christs! At least, this is what the dogmatic texts of the Church affirm—those same texts we continue to proclaim as sacred, that is, as normative. These texts declare that believing Christians have already put on Christ, have already received Christ, have already become Christ.

Or perhaps, to begin with, we simply need to learn how to read?

Yes, absolutely. I categorically insist that the Christian of the third millennium must know how to read—there is no other way! A Christian is a person who has consciously and freely made the decision to mobilize himself in the pursuit of truth and freedom. A Christian is a person who freely, deliberately, and consciously has structured his inner world so that it continually expands the dimensions of his freedom—both in relation to the external world and to his own microcosm.

This decolonization of personality presupposes a whole series of acts and achievements. Technically, it consists in the person independently shaping the project of his own future.

The person is equal to himself and in no case a copy of someone else’s project, even if that project is presented as “churchly.” A human being must liberate his inner space from external control. And this “external control” is not always exercised from without—demons have direct access to our inner world. Thus, a person who has forgotten faith can lose his freedom within as well.

The Christian must be the master, the subject of his own inner world, of his worldview. How else could a believer function who builds his life in the image and likeness of Jesus? This inner freedom gives rise to outer freedom as well. A Christian who seeks and finds his mission in this universe is, by necessity, entirely free before every challenge—both from without and from within.

This does not mean he is spared the struggle with demons, external or internal. It means that he is ready for that struggle—armed and trained for it.

“O death, where is thy sting? O hell, where is thy victory?” (1 Corinthians 15:55)

The whole history of humanity is a history of the struggle for freedom. From age to age, the human being fights. The fact that this struggle is eternal and never seems to reach its goal shows that the goal itself has been wrongly defined. That is why it remains either unattainable—or forever receding.

A veteran of the war of liberation against Georgia—against the Georgian invaders—writes these words.

I know very well that the struggle for freedom is one of the highest expressions of the struggle for the divine image and likeness. I know this from personal experience. But if a person or a social group does not know that freedom is found in Christ, they will continue to fight endlessly—and most often, against themselves. This knowledge I gained through bitter experience.

There is no such thing as a counterfeit Holy Spirit. The Holy Spirit also helps unbelievers when they sacrifice themselves for freedom, for their neighbor. But if a combatant—or any fighter—does not grasp the deeper meaning of the struggle for freedom, if he confines himself to achievements in the social, political, or economic sphere, the Holy Spirit withdraws. And such a “liberator” is left alone with his demons. Few are able to win such a confrontation.

It should not need explaining, I hope, that by “Christ” I mean a specific Person, not a set of rituals.

In the language of this work, a believing Christian is a complete, authentic human being—one who has attained, or is attaining, the fullness of humanity. A person capable of genuine sincerity, of genuine and complete human communication. A person who knows how—and is not afraid—to think; who knows how—and is not afraid—to speak fully, to the end.

In my colonial childhood among the Abkhaz there was a proverb: “The language of Aesop is the language of slaves.” That is why, for me, the quality of social communication directly determines the quality of the society itself and of the people who compose it. A toxic environment cannot be the dwelling place of the Holy Spirit. And I am speaking here about the Church, not only about Abkhazia.

To avoid repeating myself endlessly, let me add only one, but very important clarification.

Greek theology distinguishes two different yet complementary paths of knowing God: apophatic and cataphatic. Cataphatic theology includes all statements—everything that can be said about God or about anything related to Him. But there is also an experience of faith that human language is unable to describe. Believing Christians know what I mean. Human beings cannot give a proper description of essence. We can only describe around it—never it itself, which always eludes us. This approach or method of theology is called apophatic theology. It is precisely apophatic theology that applies to the essence of something seemingly so obvious as personhood.

One could go on forever, but I will try to summarize—if such a thing can be summarized at all.

A Christian is a person who has received, understood, and assimilated the dogma of the Trinity and the dogma of the Incarnation. The interiorization of these dogmas—within the framework of the New Testament and, more broadly, the biblical text—the interiorization of the identity of Jesus leads to a qualitative transformation of human existence. The person becomes a true person. The believer freely and consciously identifies himself with Jesus and entrusts himself to the power of the Holy Spirit. In this ascesis the believer attains the fullness of authenticity and existence. Being becomes both creation and struggle.

Let us conclude this chapter with the passage from 1 Corinthians 15, which we have already cited:

“But thanks be to God, who gives us the victory through our Lord Jesus Christ! Therefore, my beloved brethren, be steadfast, immovable, always abounding in the work of the Lord, knowing that your labor is not in vain before the Lord.”

May the Lord God bless us all!

The Language of God

Everything was wonderful. It is convenient—and even pleasant—to theologize while sitting at a computer: bright ideas, beautiful philosophy. And then, sooner or later, practice begins. And what do we see in practice? In practice, God is silent. That is the central problem.

You pray and pray, and there is no answer. Then it gets worse. It begins to seem that the God of love—the Logos—likes our suffering. He loves nothing more than when we endure pain with faith. The more suffering, the stronger the faith. So He, “like a loving mother,” rejoices as He watches us seek Him. We suffocate in blood, in tears, and in all that comes with it—and He rejoices. He crowns us with crowns that will, someday, somehow, be credited to us.

Thank God, I was not born a Christian. I became one consciously, as an adult, and that choice was made on the basis of a whole set of premises. Those premises leave no room for such a worldview. The picture does not add up. It cannot be—because it cannot be. And yet this is exactly how it happens.

We need another picture, another language, to describe all this—so that the files align.

What does it mean—another picture and another language?

First, we can suppose that the God of Love, the Logos, exists “otherwise”—in a mode unlike ours. And perhaps we simply misunderstand what is happening. Moreover, “understanding,” in any case, must imply a process on our side. Only then does understanding make sense.

The only logically possible explanation is to admit that all these tragedies are fiction.

But how can the horrors of human history be fiction? And why does God seem to remain so “calmly” present through it all? Where is the logic?

All right—fiction. What does “fiction” mean? Fine: let us call the same thing an exam, a test.

What kind of exam? In what subject? And what does it mean to pass the exam successfully?

We have already agreed that truly normal people are those who possess a messianic identity. How do people with a messianic identity respond to problems? People infected, so to speak, with a messianic identity respond to problems as to a challenge. The greater the problem, the greater the challenge—the stronger the motivation to overcome it.

A problem as a challenge? Motivation to overcome the challenge? Even here, in this reality, we can see people who experience catastrophe precisely as a challenge—pardon me, as a test, as an exam. So we return to our earlier thought: what matters is not the problem itself; what matters is the context into which the problem is placed—the frame that makes it solvable.

Does such a thing happen in real history? I can confirm that the highlanders of the Caucasus endured the horrors of the nineteenth century with relative calm. And after the nineteenth came the twentieth. What the Caucasian highlanders went through in those two centuries is something that history rarely witnesses. But they did not perish in vain. Those who once danced upon their graves now cough up blood. And the highlanders survived.

Yes, the last two hundred years of our history have not been a story of development but of survival. Only after 1991 did the prospect of true development open. After four millennia of social history, the North Caucasus now stands only at the threshold of growth.

Unfortunately, there has been no scientific study of this phenomenon: how the highlanders of the Caucasus managed to preserve their identity through so many losses. It would be fascinating—at least within the framework of this inquiry.

I can only note that in the Caucasus mountains, observance of the commandments is a social norm, regardless of religion. Of course, private property as an institution could not take root in a region where there had been no peace for the last eight centuries. But the standards of interpersonal relations there correspond quite closely to the norms of the Decalogue.

And perhaps the most important point for our theme is this: in the mountains, depression is impossible. No matter what horror occurs, a highlander will not fall into depression. This is something Christians must learn. More precisely, it is abnormal that someone knows how to do this—and Christians do not.

In any case, it is a sociological fact: at least one culture, one civilization, knows how to function without depression. This means such an ability can be learned. If some can do it, others can learn it too. And it also means that depression is a cultural phenomenon, not a physiological necessity.

The point is not to live a life without tragedies. Tragedies have been, are, and will always be. The point is that tragedy does not necessarily deprive the sufferer of strength. All the more so, a believing Christian should never fall into impotence or into exhausting despair.

Let us look at the same situation from another side—what we might call a second approach.

Suppose we have invented words that somehow explain the most inexplicable thing: that God is silent. Does that change anything? Does that help us in any way?

Yes, it does. What are words? Words are descriptions of reality. If we find a description of reality that allows us to find a way out of a dead end, then in our “new” reality a way out actually appears. Is that good? It is wonderful.

In fact, that is precisely how faith functions. Faith offers such a description of reality that allows us to see reality from another perspective—and this “new” perspective opens another layer of reality, which leads to an expansion in the scope of our freedom. That is the dialectic.

The same logic leads us further: the human being, in his present form, is not the final version. Further “upgrades” are still to come. If there is an exam, what is it for? What happens to those who pass it successfully? At the very least, successful completion of an exam usually entails a change of status—an elevation, or at least an expectation of elevation.

Have we found an explanation? Apparently, yes. Are we satisfied with it? Almost—but not quite. Something about it feels artificial. So let us walk the same path again, but this time along another trajectory.

What is the fundamental contradiction here? Our God is the God of Love and Logos, the God who saves. And yet He is neither seen nor heard—especially when things are at their worst. And somehow our God seems... paradoxical.

On the one hand, God calls for decisiveness and purposefulness. On the other hand, He demands from us a kind of mad humility. And the two are not always easy to reconcile—or so it seems. In any case, we must try to understand.

For Christians, the primary source of faith is, as we know, Holy Scripture. So let us make a brief overview of what Scripture tells us about such virtues as decisiveness and humility, and then try to see how these virtues are interrelated.

Where shall we begin? Let us begin with determination.

Matthew 7:7–8

“Ask, and it will be given to you; seek, and you will find; knock, and it will be opened to you. For everyone who asks receives, and the one who seeks finds, and to the one who knocks it will be opened.”

Revelation 3:5

“The one who conquers will be clothed in white garments, and I will never blot his

name out of the book of life. I will confess his name before my Father and before His angels.”

Revelation 3:12

“The one who conquers I will make a pillar in the temple of My God. Never shall he go out of it, and I will write on him the name of My God, and the name of the city of My God, the new Jerusalem that comes down from My God out of heaven, and My own new name.”

Revelation 3:21

“The one who conquers, I will grant to sit with Me on My throne, as I also conquered and sat down with My Father on His throne.”

Moreover, when the Lord speaks of John the Forerunner, does He not describe the very qualities He Himself considers positive for believers?

Matthew 11:7

“What did you go out into the wilderness to see? A reed shaken by the wind?”

What does “a reed shaken by the wind” mean? Obviously, in this context the image carries a negative connotation. Therefore, believing Christians should not be like such a reed—and John certainly was not.

I cannot resist a touch of irony regarding the “soft garments” mentioned immediately after this reed—especially considering the love of many modern clerics for soft garments. Contemporary liturgies are celebrated precisely in soft and brightly colored vestments—straight from the Gospel! But let us return to determination.

The Parable of the Talents—does it praise the depressed and the submissive? And what about Jesus Himself during His trial—what example did He give us? Yes, He submitted to an unjust court; He allowed Himself to be killed. But He did not break. He openly mocked His “judges.” What else can we call His complete disregard for that farce?

So what do we see? The Lord Himself—and the authors of the New Testament—unambiguously describe determination, and even boldness in faith, as positive qualities.

Now let us do the same brief investigation concerning humility.

Matthew 11:29–30

“Take My yoke upon you, and learn from Me, for I am gentle and humble in heart, and you will find rest for your souls. For My yoke is easy, and My burden is light.”

Matthew 18:3–4

“Truly I tell you, unless you turn and become like children, you will never enter the kingdom of heaven. Whoever humbles himself like this child is the greatest in the kingdom of heaven.”

Matthew 23:11–12

“The greatest among you shall be your servant. Whoever exalts himself will be humbled, and whoever humbles himself will be exalted.”

Luke 14:11

“For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, and he who humbles himself will be exalted.”

Luke 18:14 (the Pharisee and the tax collector)

“For everyone who exalts himself will be humbled, but the one who humbles himself will be exalted.”

Very interesting. First, the Lord proposes that we learn humility because He Himself is humble. Second, He says that humility, in some strange way, leads to the exaltation of the believer. Third, let us look more closely at His most famous statement about humility.

Matthew 5:3

“Blessed are the poor in spirit, for theirs is the kingdom of heaven.”

Luke 6:20

“Blessed are you who are poor, for yours is the kingdom of God.”

At first glance, Jesus seems to be praising people without willpower. I am a Caucasian, and in our mountains “poor in spirit” means weak-willed. For me, spirit means will, determination. Perhaps we have an intercultural misunderstanding here—but I cannot accept such a reading.

Therefore, I propose to recall that we are speaking about a Jewish context, and to recognize in the Greek phrase “poor in spirit” an echo of a Hebrew construct form (smikhut). Then the proper sense would be “crushed in spirit”—literally, “bearers of the spirit of poverty.”

This is consistent with the Masoretic text: “crushed in spirit” (Psalm 34:18), “a broken spirit” (Psalm 51:17), “a crushed, despondent spirit” (Proverbs 17:22; 18:14), “the contrite and lowly in spirit” (Isaiah 57:15). Thus, in this Beatitude the Lord is praising the humble—the contrite, not the spineless.

And what do we see here? Humility turns out to be, so to speak, a ticket into the Kingdom of Heaven. And this is precisely what Jesus says every time He praises humility. Recall His main argument: “For I am gentle and humble in heart.”

In earlier chapters, I proposed the dichotomy of “competitive” and “solidaric” ontology. In our current ontology, the rule is: the more you take, the better. But it seems that in the world to come, the true “victors” are those who can give more.

Humility, then, is a kind of non-presence—at least, in the sense formed by our experience within the framework of our still competitive ontology. That is why, perhaps, the Lord God “seems not to be present” in our still competitive universe.

Why do we learn foreign languages? To communicate with the speakers of that language, to gain access to the treasures of their culture.

So then? To communicate with God, one must learn humility. Our Christian God understands only one language—the language of humility.

Thus, if we stitch together these two seemingly opposite threads—determination and humility—what do we see? We must resolutely and purposefully seek a personal answer from God. We must strive for personal communication with Him. But God “exists” in another reality, another ontology. Therefore, to “reach” Him, we must resolutely and purposefully learn His language. And that language is humility.

Ladies and gentlemen—Christian careerists! I think I have just explained to you (and to myself as well) how one “builds a career” in the Kingdom of Heaven. According to the rules of this game, everything begins already in this life.

And so—has the pain passed? It seems so. Now that there is at least some rational understanding of the process, one at least knows what is happening—at least from my personal point of view.

Can we somehow verify this theory? In principle, Holy Scripture should provide answers to questions of this kind.

What does the story of Jesus’ arrest and the ensuing farce of a trial tell us? Where does this image of a trembling, hesitant Jesus come from? Even when He, on the cross, addressed His Father with words of anguish—where was there a broken spirit, where was there a broken will? There was immense suffering; there was unfeigned humility. But Jesus never, anywhere, renounced anything.

In Plato’s *Apology*, in Socrates’ final speech, the philosopher frankly reports the wavering he experienced when he learned that the court had condemned him to death. Socrates eventually overcomes this hesitation—but Jesus never had such

hesitation at all. There was that terrible, almost unbearable prayer in Gethsemane, yes—but there was no doubt.

In the final moments of His life, Jesus calmly gives instructions concerning the future of His Mother—entirely manfully. He calmly and confidently promises the repentant thief a meeting in Paradise. Where is despair? Where is hesitation?

The Evangelists write of a loud cry before His death. Can a person who is utterly spent cry out loudly? No—an exhausted man cannot cry out loudly.

To me, as a Northern Caucasian, it is obvious: Jesus was about to embark on a journey into hell. That cry was the discharge of power before the fiercest of battles. It is no coincidence that in Greek churches on Holy Saturday the faithful strike the stásidia and even the walls. Christ is breaking the bonds of hell—and the Church knows this. That final cry preceded His descent—when Jesus was preparing to tear apart hell itself. And in this case, yes: to tear it apart literally, too.

In a word, this image of a weakening Jesus is the product of the imagination of a feminized European Christianity—not of the Christianity of the Caucasus. The North Caucasus, thank God, will long remain an embodiment of masculinity. God willing—always, and unto ages of ages.

But of course, the story of the arrest and all that followed is also a description of the deepest humility. Jesus gave us an example of how to accept reality as it is—whether we like it or not, and especially when we do not like it.

It seems that this is how reality will be perceived there, “on the other side”—naturally, organically, without distortion. We were warned in advance, and even shown how it is done. Everything is fair—and, what is important for us human beings, everything is clear and predictable.

May the Lord help us all!

The Functionality of the Church

Now I would like to summarize this entire inquiry. Why did I start it in the first place? I proceed from the conviction that the Church is in crisis. This assumption is what compelled me to think seriously about the matter.

What do I mean when I say that the Church is in crisis? In my view, today's Church stands very far from the apostolic community. And it seems to me that the state of the Church as it was in the days of the first Apostles is the only truly normal one.

Accordingly, a question arises: In what exactly do we, today's Christians, differ from the first Christians? And a second question, far more important: How can we become like the first Christians? Such a formulation of the problem requires the development of an appropriate model—one that would allow us to compare that Church with the present one. Moreover, such a model should also help us to find a solution. That is, we need a model that will not only allow us to compare two, alas, different realities, but will also help us to describe a third—the desired, the ideal one.

Frankly, I do not even claim to be able to describe such a model. But I do believe I can at least attempt to formulate a language that would make it possible to describe such a model. That ambition gave birth to this treatise.

We began this study with an attempt to consider the Church in the same way one might consider any other kind of human activity. What will we see if we try to understand the Church as a particular form of ordinary human action?

If we wish to view the Church as a form of human activity, we must first understand: what is the goal of such an activity as the Church?

In order to define—or at least to attempt to define—such a goal, one usually identifies the resources and energies engaged in this “enterprise”. The purpose of such an inventory is to determine whether the “act of the Church,” the event of the Church, has in fact taken place or not.

Which resources and which energies, and in what proportion, must be employed so that we may say: in this particular case, the “act of the Church,” the event “Church”, has truly occurred; while in another case, it has not.

Here, almost of its own accord, a very interesting and significant term is born: “the act of the Church.”

If the Church is an ordinary activity—again, an activity—then it must consist of concrete actions, of Church-events, during which the Church actualizes itself as

Church. These concrete, that is, clearly bounded actions in time and space, can logically be called “acts of the Church,” or “events of Church”. For the sake of completeness, we can also speak of the opposite—of a “fiction of the Church,” an “imitation of the Church.”

Thus, we open the space of the Church directly to sociology—and to psychology as well. Of course, this would be a special sociology and a special psychology.

So then, what resources and energies, as we can see, are used in the Church? The primary resource—and at the same time the primary energy—is words.

Which aspect of words possesses energetic potential? It is the meaning of words that carries the capacity to mobilize, first of all, psychic energy, and then all other forms of energy available to human beings.

Of course, the use of words is accompanied by various decorations: music, singing, vestments, architecture, special furniture. Outside the ritual spaces, we can also observe forms of ecclesial presence or activity in almost every conceivable sphere of life.

We have already noted that it is meaning that gives power to words. This means that the Church is vitally interested in its believers—or, in the language of this study, its users—learning how to discern the true meaning of words.

Words have many meanings. Ordinary speech often involves the incorrect use of words, usage that does not correspond to their proper sense. In any case, true communication consists in the exchange of true information—that is, information that corresponds to reality.

There is also false communication, in which information that does not correspond to reality is disseminated. Such false communication can rightly be called manipulation, precisely in accordance with the dictionary meaning of that word.

Therefore, the very nature of the Church consists in protecting believers from all kinds of manipulation and in supplying them with true information, so that they may remain stable and discerning—and, if you will, competitive—in this changeable and often deceitful world.

Thus, we discover that one of the Church’s chief tasks is to teach her children to distinguish truth from fiction and to be able to defend themselves against manipulations built upon false information.

Already in the Old Testament, believers were given the commandment: “Thou shalt not bear false witness.”

Thus, our seemingly theoretical conclusion is confirmed by the millennia-long practice of the Church. Notice—it does not say “Do not lie”. It says, specifically, “Do not bear false witness.”

In other words, the believer bears responsibility for the quality of public information in the dissemination of which he takes part.

And I would underline one particular nuance: This commandment applies especially to normative information—that is, information that establishes what is taken as the norm. Since nearly all public information has this normative aspect, the believer must be especially careful with its dissemination.

For to establish a false norm is to create a toxic environment. And this is precisely the essence of that evil we call idolatry.

Before returning to idolatry, let us consider: what is the imitation of the Church?

The Church, as a process, has no independent nature of its own. The Church is the communication between the believer and God. The believer exists, and God exists. When they interact with one another, the Church arises.

How, then, can this interaction be imitated?

God is transcendent. From the standpoint of our current ontology, He is beyond nature. He is not limited by time or space. This is difficult to comprehend — and even more difficult to experience.

In the real Church, the believer places himself before the Absolute; he compares himself to absolute Perfection. The resulting picture, understandably, is not flattering — hence the endless repentances. It is difficult. It is easier to find reasons for self-satisfaction — and to seek and find material advantages offered by one’s status within the “sociological Church.”

A very ordinary, very human situation. But it leads to one small problem: God does not dwell in that small aquarium.

God is never “local”. God is never “our own”. Formally, everyone agrees with this, but in practice such a stance demands tremendous intellectual — yes, intellectual — effort. Therefore, one usually settles for a set of local emotional experiences and declares that to be the fullness of “Church.”

This raises, at least for me, a fundamental question: What distinguishes the ersatz Church from the event of the Church itself?

My conclusion is this: The imitation of the Church is characterized by self-satisfaction. We imagine that we have already “caught God by the beard,” that we

have trapped Him inside our Typikon. We have learned, for example, with God's help, not to eat mayonnaise on Wednesdays and Fridays. And if we can sing the troparia properly — then everything is magnificent: divine economy, the Incarnation, the whole salvific plan has reached its fulfillment.

Sociologically speaking, this is not just a common but a dominant situation. And, frankly, it is unclear what else is still missing.

We have already noted certain traits of this imitation of Church. Let me emphasize one crucial point: like every imitation, the imitation of the Church always begins with a lowering of the standard. If the true Church is communion with the transcendent God, then the imitation of that communion can be satisfied with something far less — a broad sociological experience. There are spectators, there is a crowd, and their emotional involvement is perceived as “the grace of God.”

I hope I am mistaken — and that we have not yet found the true reason for the loud “success” of the Orthodox Churches of Eastern Europe in recent decades.

Now, let us return to idolatry.

The following reference note was prepared by ChatGPT-5 (OpenAI) and Grok, created by xAI.

The Idea, the Form, and the Idol: Etymology and Philosophical Meaning

The Greek words ἰδέα (idéa), εἶδος (eîdos), and εἰδωλον (eídōlon) all stem from a common root — the verb εἶδω, meaning “I see,” which in turn derives from the Proto-Indo-European root weid- (“to see,” “to know”).

This root connects them to the Latin videre (“to see”) and the Slavic videt’ (“to see,” “vision”).

Despite their common origin, these words developed distinct meanings, especially in philosophy and theology.

Etymology and Meanings

εἶδος (eîdos) — “form,” “shape,” “appearance.”

Originally, the term referred to the external aspect or visible shape of a thing. In the philosophies of Plato and Aristotle, however, it came to signify the specific essence of a being — its inner structure or formal principle that determines what it truly is. For Plato, eîdos is often synonymous with idéa, but it emphasizes the concrete nature of each essence. For Aristotle, eîdos designates the formal cause of a thing's being, as opposed to its material cause. Example: the eîdos of man — his essential nature as a rational being.

ἰδέα (idéa) — “idea,” “mental image.” In Homeric and everyday Greek, the word also meant outward appearance or form. With Plato, however, it became a central philosophical concept: idéa denotes the eternal, immutable essence that exists in the intelligible world — the archetype or model of all things in the sensible realm. Example: the Idea of the Good in the Allegory of the Cave represents the highest reality. Plato’s doctrine of ideas profoundly shaped later thought, especially Neoplatonism and Christian theology. For instance, Augustine interpreted ideas as the divine archetypes or intentions within the mind of God.

εἶδωλον (eídōlon) — “phantom,” “shadow,” “idol”. A derivative of εἶδος (though not strictly a diminutive), it denotes an image or reflection devoid of true essence — an illusory likeness. In Plato’s philosophy, εἰδῶλα are deceptive images of the sensory world, mistaken for reality (for example, the shadows on the wall in the Allegory of the Cave). In a religious context, εἶδωλον came to mean idol — a false object of worship substituting for the true God. Example: in Christian tradition, εἰδωλολατρεία (idololatreía, idolatry) in 1 Corinthians 10:14 expresses precisely this substitution of illusion for truth.

Philosophical Context: Plato and the Allegory of the Cave

In The Republic (Book VII), Plato employs the Allegory of the Cave to describe the ascent of knowledge:

εἶδωλα — the shadows on the cave wall that prisoners mistake for reality; symbols of the sensory world and of false knowledge (δόξα, opinion).

ἰδέα — the true, intelligible essences accessible only to reason (ἐπιστήμη, knowledge), such as the Idea of the Good, symbolized by the sun.

εἶδος — an intermediate notion linking visible things with their ideal prototypes.

Plato thus opposes εἶδωλον (illusion) to ἰδέα (truth), emphasizing that the path to truth is the journey from shadows into light.

Christian Interpretation

Christianity inherited this Platonic terminology through the medium of Hellenistic philosophy. In the New Testament, εἶδωλον designates the idols of pagan cults (Acts 15:20), symbolizing falsehood and estrangement from God. Meanwhile, ἰδέα and εἶδος influenced Christian theology through the concepts of the Logos (John 1:1) and the image of God (εἰκών, closely related to εἶδος).

In the context of this treatise, idolatry thus represents the substitution of genuine communication — communion with God, the Logos — by false images.

This directly parallels the Platonic contrast between truth and illusion, between idea and idol.

Connection with Latin and Slavic Languages

Through Latin *forma*, *species*, and *imago*, and through the Slavic *videt'* ("to see") and *vid* ("vision"), this group of meanings continued to influence both Western and Eastern Christian traditions.

The Latin *videre* ("to see") and *idea* (transmitted through Cicero and Augustine) entered Western philosophy. The Slavic *vid*, *videnie* ("vision"), and *svet* ("light")—as in the Church Slavonic *Slovo* for *Logos*—derive from the same Indo-European root *weid-* ("to see," "to know").

Scheme: *weid-* → Greek *εἶδω* → *εἶδος* (form), *ιδέα* (idea), *εἰδωλον* (idol) → Latin *videre*, *idea* → Slavic "вид," "свет."

Conclusion: *εἶδος*, *ιδέα*, and *εἰδωλον* are cognate words that differ in meaning—from genuine form and idea to deceptive image. In the context of the Church, idolatry (*εἰδωλον*) can be understood as the substitution of true communication with God by false images or norms, which calls for a return to the *Logos*—the living source of truth and meaning.

What is the essence of this message?

The words *ιδέα* (idea), *εἶδος* (form), and *εἰδωλον* (idol) derive from the ancient Greek verb *εἶδω* ("I see") and the Indo-European root *weid-* ("to see," "to know"). *εἶδος* originally referred to external appearance, but in the philosophy of Plato and Aristotle it came to mean the form or specific essence underlying Aristotelian taxonomy. *ιδέα*, in Plato, took on the sense of the eternal intelligible essence—the archetype of things in the visible world. *εἰδωλον*, derived from *εἶδος*, means an illusory image, a shadow or idol—a false appearance that replaces reality, which in the Christian tradition is associated with idolatry.

So, having agreed on the terminology—what does the word "idol" actually mean? Continuing our earlier thought that the task of the Church is to lead believers to the truth, it follows that, from the Church's point of view, communication—especially public communication—is a sacred act. We have already seen that the communal sacrament of the Church is, or should be, the model of perfect communication. Its very name expresses this: "divine communication". In this central sacrament, we renew and actualize the highest norm—standing before God, before the living Truth, before the *Logos* of *logoi*.

The genius of Plato, as we have just recalled, already in the pre-Christian era distinguished between *idea*, *eidos*, and *eidolon*. Christians inherited this linguistic

framework as a given and today often assume that an idol is simply a monument of art belonging to a “foreign,” that is, false religion. This distortion of consciousness became possible because the Church’s greatest mystery—once a sacred act of divine communication—was transformed into a splendid quasi-imperial ceremony.

If we restore the original Platonic sense of the term, we may find plenty of idols even within the “churchly” enclosure. The very presence of idols indicates that such a “churchly” environment thus becomes a quasi- or, more precisely, pseudo-ecclesial environment. Yet sociologically speaking, it still refers to what is, in fact, the Church itself.

Thank God, in contemporary Serbian practice Logos once again replaces Slovo. Historically, however, in the Slavic tradition—apparently following the Latin translation—Logos became Slovo (“Word”). This is now the established practice in Russia, at least. That is why I cannot understand how reverence for the word, for speech itself, has not arisen within the Church! If the Word was God, then every word bears the image of God. Therefore, speech is a sacred function. In forming and uttering words, a human being becomes like God. To create and to give meaning to words is analogous to the creation of the universe. And what is speech, if not thought? Do we not become truly human only through communication? Hence, the misuse of words leads to the creation of idols. The devaluation of communication is idolatry.

It does not even matter with whom I am speaking — what matters is that I am speaking, provided I respect myself. It is difficult to rephrase the famous formula and declare, “I communicate, therefore I exist,” though there is much truth in such a statement. Yet I can certainly say: “I communicate, therefore I am human”. And “I am human,” of course, means: “I truly exist.”

The Church is the space of sacred communication, where the human being, through words and meanings, is united with and assimilated to the divine Logos. It is precisely in the act of true communication — with God, with fellow believers, with truth — that a person becomes aware of himself and experiences himself as homo, a bearer of the image of God.

This communication makes him human: *Communico, ergo homo*. And the awareness of oneself as a human being called to communion with God confirms one’s being in truth — one’s very existence: *Homo, ergo sum*.

Let us not forget: in the central sacrament or act of the Church, the believer — that is, the true human being — participates in the coming banquet of the Kingdom. The believer partakes in the triumph of the Logos, and in that triumph attains the fullness of his logocentric nature — becoming a complete, authentic human being.

In this sense, idolatry is the substitution of true communication by false idols, while the return to the authentic Church requires the restoration of consciousness of it as a space of such communion.

In summary:

Communico, ergo homo.

Homo, ergo sum.

With that, I hope the passage on idolatry can be considered complete.

In passing, I used the term “act of the Church”. Does it need clarification? Or is the opposition “act/event of the Church” vs. “imitation of the Church” technically self-explanatory? There are, in fact, many such questions, and I do not claim to have answers to them all.

I promised only to describe a language. I’m not sure about the language yet — but it seems a vocabulary has emerged; messianism, image and likeness, divine communication, act/event of the Church vs. imitation of the Church, the scale of personality, competitive vs. solidaristic ontology. It seems that something has indeed been accumulated; a certain analytical instrument has been described.

...

At the very least, it seems to me that modern Christians have lost the right understanding of the nature of the Church. The natural, living foundation has been buried beneath layers of artificiality — things alien to human nature itself. Antiquity had cultivated a taste for what is genuine and alive. It was precisely this taste that enabled the ancient world to recognize and receive Christ. Then the crisis began.

As it happened, in the Roman Empire — which many centuries after its fall would be called Byzantium — a “Dark Age” began around the seventh century. It lasted roughly until the ninth. But what was lost then was never recovered. Plato and Aristotle disappeared from the schools. The high standards of education and culture that defined the ancient world were gone. It was after this Dark Age that most of the “new” peoples of Europe embraced Christianity — but what they inherited was a Christianity already drowsy, ritualistic, alogos. They carried it through the centuries with the fervor of converts. Yet human nature demands its due: meaning and logic. Even neophytes need meaning and logic.

Life in truth is, by its very nature, life in the world of logoi. A Christian believer must be capable of contemplating the logoi of things. If he has not been trained to do this, if he has not learned to discern the deep order and meaning within the world, how can he possibly understand the teaching of the Church? By the example

— or the archetype — of the Church, the unnatural, the inhuman, has come to dominate every sphere of what was once the Christian world. Philosophy, which in antiquity was an ordinary and practical discipline of daily life, has turned into a sterile, impractical exercise — what the ancients rightly called sophistry, not philosophy. For the first Christians, Plato and Aristotle were part of their basic education. Today, not every university even expects its students to open a single volume of Plato or Aristotle. And we call that progress.

What's the point of all this? I am forced to repeat, again and again: Christianity is about thought — about thinking. Singing, alogos Christianity may know how to reproduce and multiply, but that is no longer Christianity — it is an ersatz Christianity. Yes, thinking is hard. It is no accident that the highest-paid professions in the modern world are those that require thinking. But the very essence of Christianity was precisely to equip its adherents with this — the greatest and most powerful of all weapons.

“When the Son of Man comes, will He find faith on the earth?” (Luke 18:8)

The Lord did not say, “When I return, there will be no temples, no priests.” He said: faith will be gone. What does this mean? It means that temples will stand, liturgies will be celebrated, priests will serve, even crowds will gather — but faith itself will have been replaced by something else. Should we Christians not take this warning seriously?

“Fear not, little flock, for it is your Father's good pleasure to give you the Kingdom.” (Luke 12:32)

Looking at the packed churches of Eastern Europe today, one cannot help but ask: Is this the “little flock” of which Christ spoke? And one more question — an uncomfortable one: Are we still waiting for the Kingdom of Heaven? Or has every Orthodox believer already found his own kingdom on the map — complete with borders, an army, and an anthem? And then, for the sake of these earthly kingdoms, Orthodox Christians rage in war against one another.

What am I getting at? I must repeat it again and again: Christianity is about thought, about thinking. A singing, alogos Christianity knows how to reproduce and multiply — but that is no longer Christianity; it is an ersatz Christianity. Yes, thinking is hard. It is no accident that the highest-paid professions in the modern world are those connected with thought. But the very essence of Christianity was to equip its followers with that supreme and most powerful weapon — the capacity to think.

“When the Son of Man comes, will He find faith on the earth?” (Luke 18:8)

The Lord did not say: “When I return, there will be no temples, no priests.” He said: “Faith will not be found”. What does that mean? It means the temples will stand, the liturgies will be held, priests will serve, crowds will gather — but faith will have been replaced by something else. Should we Christians not take this warning seriously?

“Fear not, little flock, for it is your Father’s good pleasure to give you the Kingdom.” (Luke 12:32). Looking at the overflowing churches of Eastern Europe, one cannot help but ask: Is this the “little flock” of which Christ spoke? And another, far more uncomfortable question: Are we truly still waiting for the Kingdom of Heaven? Or has every Orthodox believer already found his own kingdom on the map — complete with borders, an army, and an anthem? And then, for the sake of these kingdoms, Orthodox Christians wage furious wars against one another.

Perhaps this entire degradation was inevitable — once faith, that is, contemplation and logos, was replaced by chanting and asceticism. If the highest virtue is to “neither eat, nor drink, nor sleep,” perhaps we Orthodox should go and study under the yogis — they are much better at it than we are.

Let me repeat: I am not suggesting that the Church be turned into a Gnostic sect in which every believer must hold a professorship in linguistics or ontology. Nor am I suggesting that art be cast out from the Church’s enclosure. But all things must be in due measure.

Dogmatics must return to its rightful, central place among the theological disciplines. It was dogmatics that originally determined the role and hierarchy of all the other branches of theology, and the relations among them. At least that was how it was — in that age we call the Golden Age of the Church. In other words, in the normative age: the age in which the texts were written that we still proclaim as binding and inviolable for Orthodox faith and identity.

My dear reader may have noticed that I struggle with words. What do I mean by that? Of course, what is happening today within the Orthodox Church is, in a certain sense, quite “normal” and natural. Only, to be honest, the word Orthodox should probably be removed from the title of that institution as it now exists. All the other labels — “Georgian,” “Russian,” “Ukrainian,” and so on — would then remain honestly in place. (There is no “Abkhaz” Church, otherwise I would have to mention it as well.) But the definition ὀρθόδοξος — “right belief” — should honestly be withdrawn.

The Incarnation created a new reality. For a believing Christian, before the Nativity only the history of Israel could be sacred; but after the Resurrection and Pentecost, all of human history became sacred — and especially the history of the

Church. We cannot call ourselves Orthodox today if we do not take into account the experience of the Christians of the first millennium. What the Christians of the Church's Golden Age did and said determined the meaning and content of the word Orthodox.

The Fathers of that Golden Age convened the Ecumenical Councils. "Ecumenical" — yet another mistranslation. In the original Greek, these councils were called *oikoumenikoi synodoi* — councils of the Christian world of the Roman Empire, convened by the initiative of its ruling elite. The decrees of those councils are what we today call the dogmas and canons of the Orthodox Church.

This means that a practicing Christian of the twenty-first century who proclaims himself Orthodox is obliged to understand the logic of the debates that took place at those councils — and to agree with the conclusions reached by the Fathers.

In other words, "Orthodox" spiritual life, even now in the third millennium, must lead the practicing believer to the very questions and answers that were articulated by the Fathers of the Church fifteen centuries ago. All those questions and answers were, first and foremost, dogmatic in nature.

In the entire history of the Church, there was not a single "Ecumenical" Council convened primarily to discuss matters of liturgy or ascetic practice. When such topics were addressed, they always occupied a secondary place.

Therefore, even today, if a practicing Orthodox Christian — especially a clergyman — has not yet come to understand the realities of "essence", "energy", and "hypostasis", and has not seen in these dogmas the very guides for his spiritual life, let him not deceive himself: he is not Orthodox. He is Orthodox-like.

When we claim to be "Orthodox," we are claiming continuity with the Apostles. All the other Pauls, Apolloses, and Cephas's (1 Cor. 1:12) occupy, in this sense, a decidedly secondary position. After all, the use of a brand — in this case, Christianity — carries certain obligations. So it has been, so it is, and so it will be.

History is sacred. The Logos, through the Incarnation, sanctified it entirely — even if, before that, it had not been sanctified. I repeat the thought I expressed at the very beginning: the normative, authentic Church is the apostolic Church. The Golden Age occupies such a central place in our present life precisely because it was an attempt to develop and clarify the heritage of the apostolic era.

Here, allow me to share a personal intuition — one that is, as yet, without historical justification. A believing Orthodox Christian who has truly absorbed the logic of the debates of the Golden Age will even today be asking questions that arise

naturally from that logic. And there are many such questions. The very fact that these questions are no longer accumulating — that the Council of Crete did not become a turning point in the life of the modern Church, that the theologically insignificant “Ukrainian problem” has become the central issue of church politics — all this testifies to one thing only: the modern “Orthodox” Church has drifted far from the logic and the life of the Fathers of the Golden Age.

Small, empty ideas have flooded the Orthodox mind. Τὰ εἰδωλα have replaced τὰς ιδέας. Icons of Christ have replaced Christ Himself.

How did this happen? The icons of truth in the lives of the Orthodox-like have replaced Truth itself. Truth was not even crucified — it was simply exiled. (There is no need to recall the ending of the parable of the Wicked Tenants).

This, as I have said, is still only a personal intuition of mine — one not yet supported by historical or sociological analysis. Dogmatic questions simply do not arise among Orthodox Christians today. They just don’t arise — apparently because we have a Feast of Orthodoxy.

And yet, where is the solution? Where is the turning point we missed, and to which we must return?

The image and likeness of God. It seems to me that precisely the theology of image and likeness ought to have become the foundation of the Church’s practical theology. When these themes were pushed to the periphery of preaching and spiritual life, internal secularization began: the Church started to lose its transcendent foundation and gradually turned into an ordinary sociological phenomenon — “according to the elements of this world” (Col. 2:8).

It is necessary to return to the original practice: the restoration of the image and the perfection according to the likeness must once again become the core of the Church’s spiritual life.

By “ecclesial spiritual practice,” one should understand not only preaching and the written tradition, but the very heart of liturgical — and even more so, mystical — life. The Liturgy must be an exercise in this restoration and ascent according to the likeness.

It seems that modern Christians have “forgotten” that our present Liturgy is, above all, participation in the coming Banquet of the Kingdom of God, which is yet to take place (Luke 22:16–18), and not merely — or even primarily — a remembrance of what has already happened.

Unlike ritualism, which replaces μυστήριον with the contemplation of an unsolved puzzle, the Liturgy as an act of the Church is κοινωνία — divine

communication, in which the faithful, gathered for a sacred assembly, anticipate the eschatological banquet (Revelation 19:5–9). In this gathering, believers give thanks (εὐχαριστία) to the Logos for their adoption, purification, and participation in revelation.

In such communication, the believer, developing his logocentric nature, becomes a complete homo — and thereby affirms his complete being (sum). Even in the darkest hell, the believer freely and consciously chooses the Kingdom — and gives thanks for the very possibility of such a choice.

Therefore:

Communico, ergo homo.

Homo, ergo sum.

This communication is reciprocal. On the other side of the “line” stands the Christian God — the God who is meek and humble of heart (Matt. 11:29). Therefore, we can communicate with Him only in His own language — the language of humility. We must not forget this, even in circumstances that seem most comfortable to us.

It seems to me that the entire set of “instruments and mechanisms” of the Church’s spiritual life — fasting, prayer, worship, the study of Scripture and the Fathers — becomes fully intelligible and clear within this framework, even in the most practical, everyday sense. The cultivation of messianic identity, moreover, would also become entirely natural and traditional.

“So then, by their fruits you will know them” (Matt. 7:20). What fruits should the Church bear so that we may determine whether we have achieved the right result? If my reasoning is correct, what can we confidently expect from such a normative Church?

If the spiritual life of every individual Christian — and of the entire community as a whole — is directed toward meaning, toward the Logos of all logoi; if the Liturgy becomes an experience of “divine communication” within the “divine society,” then, “at the output,” as it were, we will have Christians whose words and deeds correspond to one another — whose words carry weight.

And not because such Christians will be more effective in politics or in public discourse. Words will, of course, be spoken less frequently — but their price will be different. This will not be the result of some special effort. A believing Christian who has sought and found himself, who knows his path in this universe, who has entered into a personal covenant with the Creator, will by nature filter his thoughts and, all the more so, his speech.

If a person knows that the meaning of his life in this world is the restoration of the image and the perfecting of the likeness of God — and of the Incarnate God — he will consciously and freely follow the path of keeping the commandments and of growing into the fullness of faith (Eph. 4:13–14).

Only in that case will there arise a real need for, and true meaning in, humility. To speak of humility makes sense only with a believer who has truly entered into a personal covenant with Jesus. What sense is there in speaking of humility to one who has never consciously experienced either the Trinity of God or the Incarnation? That poor soul already lives under the dominion of “the prince of this world” (John 12:31; 16:11). Such people perceive talk of humility as a call to depression — and God forbid when they begin to play at humility.

Human psychological humility and the humility of God — that is, the ontology of God — have about as much in common as the transcendent and the immanent realms. Of course, one can wax learned about analogia entis and apophatic theology, but such discussions are hardly soul-saving — at least not in this particular case.

In concluding this opus, I wish to say that I do not, of course, claim truth in any absolute instance. Yet it seems to me that these, my still ungrounded intuitions, describe problems that will confront the Church full-height tomorrow — if they have not already done so.

It is no surprise if my thoughts are largely shaped by my North Caucasian background. The North Caucasus, in both genetic and cultural terms, is its own continent — neither Europe nor Asia. Thus, representatives of other civilizations may find it difficult to follow the logic of a North Caucasian. But I hope that this “outside” perspective may help Christians of any origin.

Our Church, thank God, is already two thousand years old! There is nothing new we can learn about our faith. It is only — and entirely — about what we already know.

The issue is not merely historical. Both reformation and revolution signify changes of form. What we need is a deeper, essential rebirth. I would call it the reactualization — or simply actualization — of the Church.

And perhaps this is not the task of one generation alone. We must learn, again and again, to actualize the Church — to meet the challenges of the third and of all the coming millennia.

So may it be.

Christus nobiscum!

Toward an Ontology of the Logos

In the first part of this study, I tried to reconstruct the inner logic of all those actions performed by a believing Orthodox Christian within what is traditionally called “the enclosure of the Church,” that is, within the space of ritual. Now my Christian steps out of the temple. And what awaits him?

We all remember how the central question of philosophy sounds: What is being? But in fact, the very first question a human being poses to himself is: Who am I? I find it difficult to imagine an exception. Any further serious development of this discourse within our civilization inevitably leads to the central question of philosophy. And yet, it makes no sense to forget where everything begins.

The attempt at self-determination always begins with an examination of one’s environment and one’s inner world. This is followed by identifying a hierarchy of factors and their interdependencies. In this way, the need to establish priorities inevitably arises.

What gives life? What gives strength? How does one remain alive? Thinking has no meaning in and of itself. Thinking, like any meaningful process, must reach its intended goal. It is extremely important to define this goal clearly from the very beginning and, throughout all conceivable convolutions of syllogisms and paradoxes, to never lose sight of that goal.

What gives life? What gives strength? How does one remain alive?

This is the very first of all imaginable questions that arises before a thinking being already in early childhood. A child may not understand what “strength” or “life” is, but he always knows the difference between joy and the terror that lurks somewhere nearby—if it does lurk.

This dichotomy will follow a person throughout his entire life, even if the terms change: life – death, light – darkness, freedom – slavery, and so on.

Then comes adulthood. If it comes. And a thinking person begins to ponder his responsibility. He begins to see his responsibility for the world around him. Much later, he comes to realize his responsibility for the world that seethes within him. If he realizes it.

If, if — always an if. All life long there is a choice.

It becomes clear rather quickly that there is a correlation between the quality of thought and the quality of action—that is, of one’s impact on the surrounding world. The attempt to bring order into one’s own thinking reveals total chaos in that informational environment out of which this thinking must be constructed. In any

informational environment, at any point in space and time, there is always a complete mess. In any case, one must always filter the incoming streams of information oneself in order to form a stable identity.

Identity, by its very nature, implies stability. An unstable identity is not an identity by definition. Identity presupposes identifying oneself with something—something in the external world. And here the problems begin.

The modern person lives in a state of ontological exhaustion. All the “-isms” have been discredited. All the great narratives are dead — or at the very least, they were buried long ago. There is nothing left with which one could identify oneself.

But this condition has one advantage: it forces the modern person, in his search for himself, to come more quickly to the central question of philosophy.

What does being mean? The being is. Then what does “is” mean? What does to be mean?

Let us not forget: for us, this is a practical question. From the perspective of the question “Who am I?”, being primarily means identity. To be means to be identical, to be equal to oneself. To be means to be oneself.

And does a broken stone cease to be itself? Of course not. It remains a stone even if you shatter it into a thousand small stones.

Therefore, being oneself becomes a problem only for the thinking human being. It appears that the person who strives to remain himself is, in fact, the human being proper. For a human being is, by definition, not a stone — unless he is. Thus, the thinking person is the human person as such.

But can the non-thinking human being remain himself?

A non-thinking person does not control his thinking. His thinking, and therefore his behavior, resembles a paper boat that a child has thrown into the water running along the street. The fate of the boat is not in its own hands. Its fate depends on the weather and on the state of the city’s rainwater drainage system.

The same applies to the non-thinking human being. The ontological conformist turns out not to be quite human. Strictly speaking — not human at all. He is, rather, a stone.

Let us wish the conformists good luck in their difficult fate. We have just discovered that, strictly speaking, they do not even exist. And if they do exist, then only as part of inanimate nature.

We have just made an observation that greatly simplifies further analysis. It turns out that all being may be divided into two categories — only two: Logos-bearing, thinking beings, that is, thinking human beings, and the rest of nature, whether living or non-living. Put simply: people and nature.

And our analysis concerns human beings proper.

For nature does not care about preserving identity with itself. Nature is always beautiful. Even the most catastrophic natural cataclysms do not diminish the beauty of nature. The only problem is that nature cannot evaluate this beauty. Nature has left that task to us, to human beings. And we must preserve identity with ourselves.

What does it mean to “remain oneself”?

Oops! So simple — and so difficult.

Such a formulation assumes that we already know what it means “to be oneself.” But do we? Let us try to clarify.

I am.

At first glance, this statement expresses presence. If we accept our earlier assumption that being is identity, then such an affirmative requires the determination of an empty predicate: “I am what?” From this point, one would expect a list of the givens and preconditions with which we are born. But is a human being really defined by his place and time of birth and other such preconditions? If a person remains merely a product of his environment, does he break out of non-logos nature — or does he remain part of it? In the conceptual language of this work: Does a person become a person while remaining part of the very inertia that produced him?

A provocative formulation, but a fully legitimate one. First, a person must, of course, accept, preserve, and — if possible — develop what was given to him at birth. But second, a person must cease to be merely a product of his environment and become the author of his own project. The preconditions of one’s birth are merely a given, raw material that must be used to...

Enough. Let us avoid building overly long syllogisms so that we do not lose the central thread of our reasoning.

Thus, we have discovered that the statement “I am” is, first of all, an affirmative of presence and, secondly, must grow into a performative — otherwise it loses its meaning. The very structure of the proposition points to this.

Before I move to my next intuition, I want to remind the reader that I am a Christian and I am addressing Christians first and foremost.

Perhaps I am not sufficiently competent, but I have never encountered a verbalized expression of an observation that seems rather obvious to me.

We know that we, human beings, were created in the image and likeness of God. In the dialogue at the Burning Bush, God speaks about Himself for the first time. And what does He say? He says — as it is usually translated — “I am He Who Is.”

A terrible translation. In the Hebrew original of Exodus 3:14, at the very heart of the dialogue, there is no nominative at all. What appears is purely a predicative form: the operator of being (’Ehyeh) in the imperfect, which expresses an unfinished, unfolding, actualizing action. In any case, it speaks of dynamics, not of statics.

The Tetragrammaton — the “name” — appears later, in the next sentence. And even the Tetragrammaton is not, strictly speaking, a true nominative; it is only the substantivized form of a verb. This means that even the “name” of God remains an action temporarily “frozen” in the form of a noun.

For me, the crucial point is that at the Burning Bush God points to being as action. The Hebrew leaves no doubt about this. This means that we, who were created in His image and likeness, are called to repeat this action — that is, we are called to be. Our primary task is to be. The first virtue Christians must cultivate is being.

I have already written above that at the Burning Bush God gives an answer. Human thought will grow to formulate the question to that answer only a thousand years later, in Aristotle’s “What is being?” In his lectures on Aquinas, Heidegger recognized the place of the formula $\acute{\omicron} \acute{\omega}\nu$ in the history of Western thought. But even he did not wish to see in this event precisely an answer.

For us, however, this formula acquires relevance specifically as an answer — and more than that, as a commandment.

To be — as a commandment. To be — as a virtue.

The most remarkable thing is that if one says the same in different words — life as commandment, life as virtue — the statement becomes a truism in Christian circles.

Nevertheless, if being becomes doing, then it must become meaningful, rational action. “To be,” in its full form, means “to be someone” or “to be something.” And here the most interesting part begins.

Language itself suggests that the quality of being is defined by two parameters: the intensity, the saturation of being, and the quality of the predicate, that is, what

or who the subject is. In other words, the first parameter answers the question “to what degree be?”, and the second — “how be, in what manner be?”

The first case is quite obvious: it occurs when a seemingly logos-bearing being begins to impersonate something it is not. In its attempt to acquire ontic status, it puts on the mask of “the other” and ultimately loses its own subjecthood, its own authenticity.

But the second case is the one that truly interests us.

Suppose a person is sincere with himself and/or with his environment. Unfortunately, he is always located at one specific point in space and time. Therefore, he has only a limited set of raw material provided by nature in that place and at that time, and, likewise, a limited set of social roles offered by the maternal environment into which he was born.

What are the chances that, within this finite combination, he will accidentally discover a predicate that corresponds to his true being? Zero. Absolutely zero. Such is the structure of the current ontology.

Therefore, any person who wishes to preserve — or, even more importantly, to acquire — his identity will inevitably face the necessity of rewriting the roles offered to him and transforming the raw material. This is the condition of human existence in the world of our current logos-fugal ontology.

Within this work we do not examine the strategies of the conformists: we have already shown that the ontological conformist ceases to be a subject and becomes a mere function of his environment.

Thus, a person always faces the same choice: become himself or lose himself. There is no other path. To choose one’s own ontological position means to cease being an actor in someone else’s script and to become the author — the scriptwriter and director — of one’s own being. This is the minimal requirement for remaining human.

The next question: how does one make this choice?

We have already described the case of duplicity and left it aside. Now we are speaking of a subject who genuinely strives to be what he thinks himself to be. Genuinely. What does this “genuinely” mean?

In the language of logical syntax, this is called the operator of actualization / verification. Both actualization and verification are extremely interesting. Let us pause on verification.

Investigating the mechanism of actualization is a task far too grand; in truth, that is the task of this entire work. Here we are solving a concrete problem: we are examining the proposition “I am”, and specifically its true predicate.

Verification arises as a procedure only when there has been doubt. This doubt provokes an investigation. The investigation, in turn, consists of an inventory of possible options and the subsequent comparison of these options with a certain pre-established criterion. This criterion has already undergone verification and therefore can now serve as a clear indicator of truth.

Everything is clear. Except that nothing is clear.

It turns out that we need a criterion of criteria.

What is this called? Regress of criteria? Another “bad infinity,” which is certainly no reason to give up.

In any case, the very experience of verification — the experience of seeking truth — is already a profoundly positive achievement. And what is positive in it? The experience, and later the habit, of extracting essence. We have even named this experience earlier: one’s own ontological position.

Even if the result is not yet visible. A universe in which the search for truth is impractical makes no sense. If, in this universe, the search for truth yields no fruits, then this universe has no right to exist. Therefore, one may disregard the lack of immediate results. One may ignore it — because it is not true.

And the result does appear. But where does this result appear?

All this problematic arises from the tension between the expectations of the inner world and the “reaction” of external reality. But if we are logos-bearing beings — let us not fear this ancient term — then the answer must be sought in the world of logoi. We may never find the criterion of criteria, but the Logos of logoi is well known to all of us.

Every lamp, every source of light in this world is an image of the sun. Every machine is an image of a carriage or cart. This chain of analogies could be extended indefinitely. But there is only one question — and it is the most important one: Of what is every meaning an image?

Why are we certain that we are logos-bearing beings? What makes us human — truly human? To be precise: why is our thinking possible at all? Why is language possible? How is it that we can model what does not exist? Who gave us the right to draw being out of non-being? This, in fact, is the nature of all creativity. Where did we get this?

Who created all that exists out of what does not exist? Who is the Logos of logoi? Who entered history as the Meaning of meanings?

...

Ah, we have arrived at the answer too quickly! Let us make one more circle.

Let us look at the very same problem from another direction.

What is the source of all death?

What do we see in the world of nature? Everything that exists eventually perishes. An ordinary star of the type of our Sun lives about 10–20 billion years. Our Sun is about 4.5 billion years old. It has roughly 5.5 billion years left. Of course, this has nothing to do with the span of human life. And yet: nothing in this world is eternal. One only needs to stretch the scale of time.

But what is eternal?

Let us leave the stars aside. We will not be able to observe anything there in time. Let us look at the human being, at the social sphere. What is eternal among human beings?

What, in our everyday practice, must be maximally stable? The destruction of what leads to the destruction of society?

Meanings. That is what prevents human beings from returning to nature. As long as people speak a language, they remain human. But when words lose their meaning, when language disintegrates, human community disintegrates with it.

At least we have found the force that can preserve from decay at least one sphere of life.

Let us descend one level lower — from society to the individual. Can a person disintegrate? If so, what can prevent him from falling apart?

How does entropy act at the psychic level? Through fragmentation of the psyche, the loss of purpose and time, the chaos of emotions and thoughts, the disintegration of identity. If this is not stopped, it inevitably leads to death.

What can stop and prevent the disintegration of the person? First, a human being must assume a subjective ontological position in relation to being. Frankly, “to assume a position” already presupposes subjecthood — but let us specify this to avoid misunderstanding. Second, a human being must actualize this position.

And without this — nothing is possible. Without this, everything else is meaningless.

There — it slipped out by itself: meaningless, that is, without meaning and therefore without real existence.

Thus, a person must make the choice himself. And a choice, as we know, is faith. A choice cannot be determined by anything external. Either a person respects himself, or he does not.

If a person chooses reality — the actuality of his own existence — then there is something to speak about. If a person chooses to remain part of inertia, whether natural or social, he is, strictly speaking, choosing non-being. We have already spoken about this and will not return to it.

Once these two steps are fulfilled, everything else is a matter of time and technique. For to “assume a position” and to “realize it” means to come into being as a person. It means to survive; it means to triumph.

Everything seems self-evident — and yet, as always, there are nuances. Why do we choose to triumph? Why can we not simply dissolve back into nature? Physically it is inevitable. What criterion — yes, another criterion — requires survival?

A human being is the only creature to whom the experience of non-being is given.

...

Hm. We are discussing “I am,” and we have already reached the discussion of the predicate. But we have not noticed the “I”! What does “I” mean?

Who has the right to say “I”? What is being affirmed by the one who pronounces “I”?

First, we must establish the scope of this declaration. “I” is opposed to what? When a person asserts “I,” he thereby asserts that he is alive, in contrast to all that is non-living. This means that “I” is opposed to all non-living nature. Nature lives by inertia; nature cannot but follow the soulless mechanisms of physics and chemistry. “I” can. “I” declares its own personal projectuality, distinct from the natural, from the given.

“I” sets itself against non-living nature and simultaneously enters into dialogue with other “I”s. It seems to me that a defining characteristic of the “I” is reverence. Nature is soulless. Even living nature lives by instinct. “I” is “I” because it is conscious — and above all conscious of its responsibility. An “I” without responsibility is not an “I”; it is merely another specimen of living nature. Without reverence, without responsibility, this instinctive “I” will not even notice another “I.” For nature knows neither “I” nor, even less, the Other.

Again and again, we return to the discussion of logos-less existence. What can we do? Statistics cannot be canceled.

Thus, the “I” is a declaration of original projectuality and responsibility — and one is impossible without the other.

Perhaps this analysis of the “I” could be continued. But another thought has just come to mind.

Somewhere I have seen this before. Who was the first to propose His own original projectuality and to acknowledge His responsibility for the product? Of course: “In the beginning He created the heavens and the earth,” and then He looked and said: “Very good.”

Thus, every “I” begins its interaction with Being according to the image and likeness of the first “I.” Most importantly, we have discovered in whose image and likeness every “I” creates. Therefore, by comparing ourselves with the Archetype, we will better understand how any healthy “I” functions — and how it must function.

We have spoken about the predicate to “I.” We have spoken about the necessity of identity, and above all about the necessity of the identity of meanings. I am X. We have considered the “I,” we have considered the “am.” We have searched for the true X. I am a Christian, I am a theologian. I see the world accordingly. We have said that in order to survive, a logos-bearing human must assume a subjective ontological position. And both “logos-bearing” and “subjective” are terms with an explicitly theological — indeed, christocentric — character. At least for me.

We are now discussing the predicate to “I am.” What can a human being identify himself with in order to save himself from disintegration and dissolution back into nature?

Let us assume we have a messianic identity of a non-Christian type. It may be religious, or almost entirely secular. But in any case such an identity is forced to ascend to the highest level of abstraction. Unlike everyday or professional roles, a messianic identity attempts to become the ontological support of the person. This is why it must have a global scale: the totality of history, the destiny of humanity, the world proletariat, universal liberation, progress, the nation as a metaphysical subject, scientific salvation, cosmic evolution — all these are attempts to form a predicate at the level of the Absolute.

And if a person wants to build his identity seriously, rather than play a role in someone else’s script, the predicate must be high enough not to collapse under a serious encounter with history or with the psyche. This is why even for a communist, the predicates “universal happiness” and “the historical mission of the working

class” inevitably take a form suspiciously similar to God. The same applies to any strong secular project. They are compelled to take on the function of a revelation from God, because nothing less is capable of supporting the human “I” against disintegration.

A predicate of lesser scale cannot sustain identity. A predicate that is local, finite, historically conditioned — collapses faster than the person can fully rely on it. Therefore such projects demand constant energetic investments from their carriers. Thus, in every strong non-Christian messianism there inevitably arises a theology without God — an absolute without the Absolute, a logos-fugal imitation of the Logos, that is, an attempt to play the role of the foundation of being without possessing the fullness of being.

But we have already determined that only that which is not subject to decay can serve as a true predicate for “I am.” Therefore, the true predicate must be: metaphysical, supra-natural, and logos-bearing.

How fortunate we Christians are! We do have such a predicate — and it satisfies all necessary conditions.

“He,” the one we call ours, is Himself the Logos. He is not derivative; He is not a consequence of history. He is not a product of culture nor a function of social inertia. He does not depend on the change of epochs or contexts — He defines them. He is not bound to any form of human weakness. He does not exist because the world exists — the world exists because of Him. He Himself is the Meaning of meanings and the Ground of grounds. He not only sustains meaning — He generates it. He not only sustains identity — He gives it.

They will object — and quite convincingly: Where did you see this Meaning in the ritual practice of the Church?

And I will answer: the Church has many texts, and each person finds what he has grown enough to perceive. Whoever sought one thing found that; but the one who sought the Logos found the Logos.

One can find Him even in ritual — see Part One. This is not the Church’s problem. It is the problem of the eye that looks. Everything depends on the choice.

“I am a Christian” is not a political or cultural declaration. It is not a grammatical construction. It is an act of freedom, an act of faith, an act of identity. It is an ontological position — if one is serious.

A Christian chooses the predicate: Jesus Christ, who Himself is Being. Therefore he is confident in his identity with himself. Therefore he is confident in the eschatological scale of his personal project. Therefore he knows the metaphysics of

his “I.” Therefore he knows his mission in this universe; he knows his calling. A Christian in any situation chooses being, chooses identity, chooses light.

Only a Christian, even within the real Church, can find Christ. If he can accomplish this task, then what are all the others to him?

Let us move on. We have chosen our true predicate; we have identified ourselves with Christ the Logos. And what follows?

First, we thereby discover the ontological importance of thinking. Yes, I keep returning to the same point — forgive me, that is how it turns out.

The determination of truth, the discovery of truth, the identification with truth — these are very complex and energy-demanding activities that take place precisely on the level of the Logos. None of this is accidental. This presupposes a developed culture of thinking, a developed personal identity. Such things are not formed in a barrack or a kolkhoz. Of course, people of this kind may easily end up in a barrack or a kolkhoz, but they were certainly not formed there. A culture of thought is truly a culture; therefore it requires an appropriate environment and an appropriate tradition.

And then comes action.

Only a person — an actual person — is capable of action, as we know from experience. A developed, formed person.

A formed, stable, strong inner world externalizes itself. One’s personal inner reality becomes a fact of the social sphere — a constitutive fact, that is, a fact that establishes a new structure, a new form of the world. And often — without a single word.

Christian action is the maintenance of stability and identity throughout the universe. But this does not mean conservation or, God forbid, freezing. The Christian, as co-worker with the Creator, co-creates and builds.

Christianity is about life. And life, in order to remain life, must continually be born, must continually create. Therefore Christianity, too, must continually be born.

We forget that the Son–Logos is continually being born. The begetting of the Son is not a momentary act; it is an eternal process. And we are created in the image and likeness of the Son Himself, who is the Logos. Therefore we, too, are called to continual birth.

“He who believes in Me, as the Scripture has said, out of his belly shall flow rivers of living water.” “But this He spoke of the Spirit, whom those who believed in Him were to receive.” (John 7:38–39)

This passage from the Gospel of John is obviously not about H₂O — which the text itself immediately makes clear. If it is not about water, then what is it about? And what does this say to us, to Christians?

As the Son is born and gives birth, so the Christian, clothed in the Son, is born and gives birth. In the vocabulary of this work, this quality of the Christian is called “original projectuality.”

One must understand how Christian creativity differs from any other kind. A Christian does not create just anything. The rejection of idols implies the rejection of projects that do not contain Christian eschatology. If a project does not possess Christian eschatology, if it has no future in the Kingdom of God, then why waste time and strength — that is, life — on it? Hence the well-known Christian selectiveness, which naturally transitions into asceticism.

Asceticism is, first of all, the rejection of simulacra. A Christian cannot trade his life for simulacra, even if they provide access to resources and energy for a short time — for the duration of a single human life or even several human lives. What has no continuation in eternity has no value in history. Therefore a Christian, if he is indeed a Christian, will not create simulacra. Simulacra are the sure sign of idolatry, even when wrapped in churchly garments and masked as piety.

Now — here one must make a small but very important clarification, one that took me many years to grow into. Our life has a real, practical character. Not every action of ours needs to be justified ontologically. Not every visit to a shop or to a doctor must be viewed in an eschatological perspective. OK? We must walk on the earth with two feet.

A friend of mine in Moscow once told me a very interesting story from the Paterikon.

A peasant had lost his way in the desert and came upon hermits. He asked them: “How do I get to the city?” One of the hermits replied: “I do not know the way to the earthly city, but I know the way to the heavenly city and can show you that path.” The peasant answered: “If you do not know the road to the earthly city, how can you know the road to the heavenly city?” And the peasant went on his way.

Who is right in this story, and who is wrong? There may be many answers, and, one must admit, they are all equivalent. I believe that this is precisely what the Apostle Paul meant when he wrote about “solid food.”

Returning to ontology: What distinguishes a logos-bearing action from a “non-logos” action? How can one describe participation in the Logos? Most likely, one must speak about contemplation. It should be noted that contemplation may be of

two kinds: there is “ordinary” contemplation, and there is the supra-natural contemplation of the great mystics and prophets. There is no need to explain which one I mean — I refer to my own experience, that is, ordinary human contemplation. And what I want to say is that Christian action must grow out of contemplation. I am not certain about the temporal sequence — whether one follows the other or whether both occur simultaneously — but the fact remains that one is impossible without the other. Yes, this means that even the “everyday,” ordinary actions of a Christian must have a creative character. The Logos, once He has come, does not depart. I cannot speak of prophetic states that are inaccessible to me. But attentive consideration of the manifestations of the Holy Spirit — both in the lives and works of others, and in one’s own life — shows that He is present even in the creativity of people far from purity, when they are seeking truth. If a person seeks truth, if he attempts to articulate truth, then no matter how small a personality he may be, a prophetic voice will be heard in his creativity.

And yes, it seems to me personally that for the modern person the study of philosophy — sincere, real study — and then theology, opens a prophetic potential. For both philosophy and theology, as practices, are exercises in the search for truth. If they are not the practice of truth-seeking, then they are not philosophy and not theology. In that case, they usually become political prostitution. Please pretend you did not hear that — and invent a gentler way to say it!

A logos-bearing action is a deed, an ordinary human deed — only it must be performed with a more global perspective in mind. At least in my own life it was a real problem not to lose the details of a concrete fragment of life while trying to keep sight of the larger picture. I struggled with this. I literally had to learn this skill: to see not only the general picture of a given communication, but also to attend to the details — of myself, my interlocutor, and the context. Usually it is difficult to perceive the broad, abstract picture. But sometimes the opposite happens. I can testify to that.

Does this mean I am boasting? I am getting old. In any case, that is not why I wrote it. Life is a concrete thing, and this must never be forgotten. Who was it among the philosophers that fell into a well? The name of Thales has survived in history; the name of the servant girl who laughed at him has long been forgotten — but her joke has survived. We must admit that her joke contains much truth, which nevertheless does not place her alongside Thales.

In Holy Scripture it is often said about the righteous: “He walked before God.” As usual, let us not fall into excessive mysticism. I prefer to think that these were people just like us — and that this is precisely their greatness. So what does it mean, in simple human language, “He walked before God”? It means, among other things, that the righteous lived as if God were near — now and always. He lived in the

presence of God. Does this imply some kind of extraordinary state? Yes and no. If these people entered the text of Scripture, then in their lives this presence must have been especially intense. But even if not in such a degree, this *modus vivendi* ought to be the ordinary norm. There is nothing difficult in this. The only difficulty lies in letting God into one's inner world — in acknowledging that you are not alone in there. You have no "sovereign" space where no one hears or sees. There is One who hears and sees.

It truly puzzles me to see people in the church who believe that their secret thoughts are hidden from everyone. Perhaps not immediately — but sooner or later almost everything becomes clear to almost everyone. Does this mean that truth triumphs at once? Yes and no. Life in society, even in church society, does not free one from the mask. The mask is inevitable and unavoidable. "Do not give what is holy to dogs, and do not cast your pearls before swine, lest they trample them underfoot, and turn and tear you to pieces." (Matthew 7:6) What is this about, if not about life in society? And this, by the way, is a commandment — equal to all other commandments.

And now a note from ChatGPT

TABLE OF INFORMATION FILTRATION

(from reality to action)

LEVEL 1 — EXTERNAL REALITY (100%)

Contains all physical information: electromagnetic spectrum, sound, vibrations, chemical signals, pressure, radiation, magnetic fields, gravity, temperature, objects, events, processes. Assimilated: 0.0000000001–0.00000000001% (approximately 10^{-12} – 10^{-14})

LEVEL 2 — RECEPTOR REGISTRATION

Receptors respond only to an extremely narrow range of signals: retina → 380–740 nm, ears → 20–20,000 Hz, skin → pressure, temperature, pain, nose → some volatile molecules, tongue → 5 tastes. Assimilated: $\approx 0.0000001\%$ ($\approx 10^{-9}$ of physical reality).

LEVEL 3 — SENSORY NERVES (brain pre-filtering)

Incoming to the brain: vision → $\sim 10^6$ bits/sec, hearing → $\sim 10^5$ bits/sec, somatic input → $\sim 10^5$ bits/sec, total → ~ 11 million bits/sec. The brain discards: 99% of repetition, 99% of noise, everything that carries neither threat nor benefit, everything that does not match current expectations. Allowed into consciousness: $<0.001\%$ of input (40–60 bits/sec).

LEVEL 4 — CONSCIOUS PERCEPTION

Consciousness can simultaneously hold: 7 ± 2 units of information (Miller's classic rule), processing speed $\rightarrow$ 40–60 bits/sec, focus $\rightarrow$ 1 object $\rightarrow$ 3–5 seconds, almost everything is pushed out within 1–2 seconds. Assimilated: $\approx 0.0005\%$ of brain input, $\approx 5 \times 10^{-4}\%$ (one two-hundred-thousandth).

LEVEL 5 — MEMORY

Of what was consciously perceived: after an hour $\sim 50\%$ remains, after 24 hours $\sim 30\%$, after a month $\sim 10\%$, after a year $\rightarrow$ 1–5% (if it was meaningful). If there was no emotional tag, even less is retained. Stored long-term: $\sim 1\%$ of conscious experience $\approx 10^{-2}$.

LEVEL 6 — APPLICATION (action)

Of what memory has preserved: actually applied $\rightarrow$ 1–2%, becomes skill $\rightarrow$ $<1\%$, transforms behavior $\rightarrow$ $<0.1\%$. Thus: final action = $\sim 10^{-17}$ of the original information of reality.

ONE-LINE SUMMARY

Level	Information	Retained (%)	Coefficient
Reality	100%	—	—
Receptors	10^{-12}	0.00%	$\times 10^{-12}$
Brain (sensory input)	10^{-9}	0.00%	$\times 10^{-9}$
Consciousness	10^{-12}	0.0000005% of input	$\times 10^{-5}$
Memory	10^{-14}	1–5% of consciousness	$\times 10^{-2}$
Action	10^{-17}	1–2% of memory	$\times 10^{-2}$

Ultimately, a human being acts on the basis of roughly 10^{-17} of objective reality.

When the Church proclaimed the dogma of fallen human nature, it did not know any of this.

All this means that it can now be considered scientifically established that we humans do not react to objective reality, but to the myth we ourselves have constructed. Voluntarily — though not consciously. Therefore, Christian faith is a way of discovering what is actually happening around us, based on the instructions we have received from the Manufacturer. This instruction is usually called the Bible — the Old and New Testaments. And the Manufacturer is usually called the Creator.

We live in an illusion amounting to 10^{-17} of reality. And the only way out of this hell is to allow into this 10^{-17} part the One who is the entire reality. This is why “walking before God” is not a state of ecstasy. It is a state of sobriety. Our task and our ambition: to live in the world of 10^{-17} while remembering the 100%.

The conclusion is simple and obvious: we live in the world we ourselves have drawn. We live in the world we believe into being. No objective reality “as such” exists. Reality is only as objective as we believe its objectivity to be. And if we truly want to “reach” or “touch” reality, then we must understand how we compose our so-called objective reality — and compose it correctly, without illusions. This is precisely what Revelation helps us do. The task of Revelation is not to make us kinder, more humane, or more civilized. The task of Revelation is to enable us to use reality as effectively as possible. In the language of modern neuroscience: consciousness is a filter, not a window. We do not perceive the world — we construct it. So let us construct it properly.

The Kingdom of Heaven is the realm of reality — but of reality that is true, eternal, and non-illusory. The problem of a religion of Revelation is not ethical; the problem of a religion of Revelation is ontological.

How can this be overlooked? How can one spend 2,000 years circling around it?!

I believe that the main problem, the primary misfortune of Christianity, occurred already in the first generation. When the first Christians — the Jewish Christians — were massacred, Christianity lost its connection with the Jewish tradition and, strangely enough, with the ontology of Revelation itself. The Jews possessed no system of logic. There was no philosophy among the Jews. All the beautiful logical and philosophical frameworks were brought in by the “Christians from the Gentiles.” But even the most brilliant prophets among the Gentiles could not grasp the practicality of faith.

It must be noted — for the sake of historical fairness — that the Jewish Christians were not killed by Christians. This not only severed the continuity of tradition but also created a trauma that had such sorrowful consequences.

The Jews rejected their Messiah. The Gentiles accepted Him — but could not understand Him. In these two thousand years Christianity has achieved tremendous heights, yet today, for some reason, we are forced to begin almost from scratch, all over again.

And this is wonderful. Glory to God!

I am curious: what primitive things — obvious to our descendants a hundred or two hundred years from now — do we fail to see today? The world is contracting, and time as well. But Christian Revelation will remain relevant forever.

...

So — have we finally approached the answers to the questions with which everything began? The questions were traditional:

What gives life? What gives strength? How does one remain alive?

In other words, the question posed was: “Who am I?”

And what have we discovered?

We have discovered that we, strictly speaking, do not have access to reality. We react not to reality itself, but to the filters of our own consciousness. These filters depend not so much on energy and matter as on the structure of our own identity, on our own meanings. Therefore, by forming meanings, we form that which connects us to reality. Thus, by discovering — or more precisely, by forming — meaning in our perception, in our understanding of reality, we thereby form the very reality accessible to us.

Then we saw that meanings function according to the image of the primordial Meaning. We saw that the Λόγος is this primordial Meaning, the source of all meaning. Thus, by including the Logos in our filters, we gain access to reality. The only problem is that the Logos must not be the one we have invented, but the Logos as He has revealed Himself. By identifying ourselves with the Logos, we gain access to eternal reality — not fictitious, not illusory, but eternal, stable reality. Accordingly, we acquire our true identity, our true selfhood. We gain not a fictitious, illusory, momentary subjecthood, but a real, stable subjecthood that allows us to see the whole of reality. We break out of nature and step into a supra-natural, personal position.

From this position we can then return to the common social reality, which, as we see, is extremely unstable — ontologically unstable by definition. I do not even know what word to choose, within this framework, to describe standard social reality — the one seemingly available to everyone, the medium through which we

communicate with each other. But once we have gained stability in our individual reality, once we have seen reality there, achieved identity there, our interaction within social existence also acquires a different quality. And the social structures that arise in this way will function differently.

We must not forget one simple truth. When we include God in our filters, we thereby confess our ignorance, our incompetence — indeed, our ontological insufficiency. For God is a magnitude we cannot define, cannot explain. By including this magnitude in our narrative, we remove ourselves from the center of our own ontology. If we understand what we are doing — if our inner communication is conscious at all — we place at the center not ourselves, but God. We cease to be the axis of our reality and acknowledge the Source of meaning as the One who truly sustains our ontological being.

And what does this give us?

Nature knows no stability. Nature is, by definition, entropic. The only thing that differs from nature is meaning. But meaning is given only to the human being. Meaning is the form of human being. Nothing meaningless can exist for long. Meaning holds things together. Meaninglessness destroys. This applies to everything — from the human psyche to human civilization. As soon as meaning disappears, disintegration begins. Meaning is the ontological antithesis of entropy. Meaninglessness is the experience of non-being that a person undergoes already in this life.

Therefore, in the Christian tradition, hell is, in the main, not described as a “place of punishment.” Hell is the emptiness of meaning — a state in which identity has been completely destroyed and the gathering center no longer exists.

Meaning is usually perceived as an abstraction. But this is a mistake. Meaning is energy — and the only energy capable of stopping entropy. Only meaning creates order out of chaos. Only meaning sustains identity. Only meaning makes truly human action possible.

This is why any person who holds meaning — even a single individual — literally holds the world back from disintegration. To a Christian, this is given to do on an ontological level. This is precisely what distinguishes Christian action: it is universal and always directed against entropy. Meaning sustains identity. Identity sustains being. And being sustains the human being as human.

Access to meaning has been given to the human being. A person attains this access in the Logos.

Revelation — in the literal sense — is revelation. Revelation does not make us kinder, smarter, more civilized. Revelation opens us to reality and reality to us.

By placing God at the center of our own ontology, we raise our value to the maximum. God is the Other — the most radically Other. By recognizing this Other as the center of our ontology, we gain the ability to see everything. Nothing can be more different from us, more other, than God. Placing God at the center of our ontology allows the 99% of reality normally inaccessible to us to become accessible. The invisible, the unknown, the unreachable — which we usually interpreted as non-being — becomes our resource, becomes our habitat.

...

Who am I?

I speak, as always, from myself and about myself. I am a Christian; I belong to Christ.

Glory to the Father, and to the Son, and to the Holy Spirit, now and ever and unto ages of ages!

Amen!

Faith as Competence

I have already noted that this text has begun to live its own life. I am rather a witness to the birth of this text than its author. The reader may have noticed that I conclude each chapter with prayers and blessings. This is direct evidence that, at the time of writing, I regarded these chapters as independent articles. Later, they “merged” into a single whole.

The chapter “Toward an Ontology of the Logos” was also born with the assumption that it would be the last one. I no longer know what to think about the chapter that is now being born under my pen—or, more precisely, under the keys of my laptop.

Yes, originally there was no epigraph. Now it has appeared.

Once again, I proceed from the assumption that I am finishing the text. But now, based on experience—I cannot call it bitter—I no longer know what to think.

One of the most important people in my life, Metropolitan of Tyroloi Panteleimon (Rodopoulos), may he inherit the Kingdom of Heaven, taught us theology students who lived in the dormitory of his Vlatadon Monastery: “A theologian must be able to prove absolutely anything—and then must immediately be able to refute what he has just proved.” Your Eminence, I am fulfilling your testament.

In the “Toward an Ontology of the Logos” I analyzed the statement “I am.” At that time I lacked the honesty and courage to admit that the statement “I” speaks not only of original projectuality and otherness in relation to all inanimate nature. Not only that, and not even primarily that. On page 14 I explicitly state that “Man is simply God in his microcosm.” Of course, I wanted to say that man exists in his microcosm “like God,” almost like God. But not merely metaphysical, rather already strictly theological analysis of the statement “I am” forces us to take the next step.

We have already compared the space of this statement with the image of the Creator at the very beginning of the Book of Genesis—in order to understand how the “I” functions. Let us go further. As Christians, we know that our personality is a reflection of the mode of being of the Persons of the Holy Trinity. In order to understand how personality should function for us, as Christians, it is logical to consider the mode of being of the Persons of the Holy Trinity.

And what do we see?

What do we know about our own personality? How do we know it? Our “I” reveals our personality to us. In the Holy Trinity there are three Persons. This means

we could assume the presence of three “I’s” in the Trinity. And yet in the Trinity there is only one “I.” This is precisely why Christianity is a monotheistic religion.

How can this be? Our created personalities are made in the image of the Eternal Persons, yet the Eternal Persons do not have what their created images possess.

So what do we have that the original does not?

We have ontological autonomy and, correspondingly, ontological distance. The Trinity does not. This means that the original version did not provide for such an option. And this means that all our problems originate here. From here come logofugal ontology, gnostic will, and such a large number of zeros in the formula “10 to the minus 17th power.”

Let us be honest with ourselves, ladies and gentlemen, Christians. The statement “I am” in the current ontology does not mean confession, but functional appropriation of divine status, of origin: “I am god.” Communication—and even more so existence—built on the ontology of “I am” leaves no place for the Creator. Not because God does not respond, but because the autonomous subject ceases to be an address to which a response is possible.

We, created beings, possess ontological autonomy—even ontological distance. The original, the Persons of the Holy Trinity, possess none of this. On the level of words this appears as our advantage. In essence, however, it should be a problem for us. More than that, it may be one of our fundamental problems. On the ontological level, a mode has been activated that was not provided for by the “factory settings”: we occupy the position that the Creator left for Himself. Put more simply: we have switched off the mode of ontological receptivity, and the mode of ontological transmission has become stuck. And as a result, the surrounding reality is 10^{17} times larger than what we can access — and thus remains inaccessible to us.

So what is to be done?

We remember: this autonomy arose because it could arise. Freedom was given seriously—not as an illusion and not as decoration. The Creator created man not as an object of control, but as one capable of response. Autonomy and distance from the Source of life were not the norm of the design, but they became possible and were realized by freedom carried through to the end, thus revealing its own price. If we are going to allow these notorious “10 to the plus 17th power” into our reality, we must change the address. Not “I am,” but “God is,” and therefore “I am.”

We must cease to regard our “I” as the source of our being. As Christians, we must place the Trinity in the position of the source of our being.

It is difficult even to say this in human language. The most interesting thing is that Orthodox languages are incapable of expressing this thought. At least Greek, Russian, and Serbian. Not even my native Abkhaz, which is hard to classify at all. But Western languages allow this to be said.

Gott bin.

God am.

Le Dieu sui.

Not “Ich bin Gott,” not “Gott bin ich,” but precisely “Gott bin.”

As expected, German is best suited to convey this thought. In English and French, “Christ” and “Christian” are different words. In German, they are practically the same word.

Therefore, in German one phrase can say what the Apostle Paul said long ago:

“It is no longer I who live, but Christ lives in me. And the life I now live in the flesh I live by faith in the Son of God, who loved me and gave Himself for me.”
(Galatians 2:20)

Here it is necessary to stop and say with maximum precision what exactly the Apostle Paul says—and what he does not say. Paul does not assert: “I no longer exist.” He does not deny personality, does not dissolve the subject, and does not abolish human existence. In the Greek text he deliberately avoids the verb “to be” (εἶμι) and uses the verb “to live” (ζάω). This is not about the disappearance of the “I,” but about the loss of its status as the source of life. In other words, Paul does not say: “I ceased to be,” but: “I ceased to live from myself.” Life remains, personality remains, will remains—but the source of life is no longer located in the autonomous subject.

Life is realized in me, but not produced by me. And this is the Apostle Paul’s statement.

“Living from oneself” is yet another neologism; the context makes its meaning unambiguous.

In German everything is simpler and harsher: Christ bin.

And what changes?

Everything changes.

It is precisely this shift—from autonomous origin to life as response—that makes the further conversation possible and inevitable. Because from this moment

faith ceases to be the content of consciousness and becomes a question of the ability to live not from oneself. In this case we do not merely receive answers to the questions posed in the chapter “The Language of God.” New perspectives open before us.

Up to this day, when faith was discussed, three different phenomena were usually implied. First—faith as opinion. Second—faith as a psychological state. Third—faith as identity.

My own experience tells me that faith most often begins precisely with psychological experience. Certain special, unusual experiences bring a person into the community. This is a natural and understandable entry into faith.

Within the community, a person who already considers himself a believer gradually learns to be part of this society, this social environment—the Church. Here faith takes shape as identity: a person finds a language, a practice, a tradition, and enters the rhythm of church life.

As one “grows” in faith, the believer inevitably encounters questions that cannot be answered either by experience or by belonging. He discovers the significance of his personal relation to questions of faith, his own understanding and responsibility. Thus faith as opinion emerges—as conscious and personal acceptance.

In this sense one may assume that we are dealing with a kind of stages of “maturation in faith.” Their sequence may vary, and this is not essential. Only one thing is important: of these three stages, opinion is the highest, because only here does faith become the affair of the person.

Opinion can exist only in a person.

But the problem is that the same stages are passed—or may be passed—in any other religion or even ideology. Psychological experience, belonging to a community, and personal conviction by themselves do not yet make a person a Christian. They do not make him Christ.

So where does the boundary lie beyond which Christianity begins?

We all know this boundary. This boundary is the Cross.

What does the Cross mean? Why is it so important?

The Cross quite obviously means death. In Christianity, in real life, death verifies everything. Death cannot be a simulacrum. One cannot hide behind death. The capacity for the Cross, for death, radically removes the mature personality—properly speaking, the Person—from environment, from metabolism.

The Cross is important not because it is a symbol of suffering, and not because it evokes compassion or reverence. The Cross is important because it is an action performed wholly—without remainder and without insurance. This action may be without words, without explanations, and without witnesses. But precisely for this reason it is logos-like: it responds not to the world and not to itself, but to the Source of life.

Death can also be madness. That is why suicide is the gravest sin, the highest blasphemy against life, against reality. But precisely for this reason a person who, in the search for truth, comes to the Cross and stands before it—such a person performs the highest form of logos-action.

“Do not fear, little flock, for your Father has been pleased to give you the Kingdom.”

You have found reality, you have found life. Do not look around! Do not look at the dead who give birth to and bury their dead. They think they exist. But they lie, as they always do in everything—and first of all they lie to themselves.

But there is only one path to this reality.

As the poet said:¹

“Do you see, beyond the river, a cross rising? Come and hang on it for a while. And then come walk on the water.”

Poets are often prophets.

So where does the power of the Cross lie? Not all Christians, not all Christs, ended their lives literally on a cross. The Cross is not only and not so much literal crucifixion. But the Cross—the Christian Cross, the Cross in Christ—is always and necessarily self-emptying. Total emptying without remainder. Standing before the Cross means consciously and deliberately paying the full price for truth, for reality, for human dignity. A spoonful of tar, as we remember, spoils a barrel of honey. Our barrel of honey must be absolutely pure. Truth and humanity tolerate no compromise—first of all in relation to oneself. We remember the commandment: “Do not cast pearls before swine.” This is a commandment like all the others. It must likewise be fulfilled fully. Christ does not barter Himself on every occasion. Christ knows His worth. Truth knows its worth.

¹ “Walking on Water” (also known as “Apostle Andrew”) is the sixth track on the album “Foreign Land” by the Russian band Nautilus Pompilius.

How does the Cross differ from death for an “opinion”? Socrates also gave his life for his convictions, but he did not know and could not know Christ. Che Guevara could have accepted Christ, but he gave his life for convictions in which there was no place for Christ.

Both Socrates and Che Guevara remained with their “I.” Many worthy people lived bright, rich, highly moral lives. But they all died. For us the question is different: how can one live so that life does not end in death? How is a life possible that continues into the eschaton?

And here we again return to the Cross. The Cross is not death for a conviction and not sacrifice for an idea. The Cross is the renunciation of one’s ontological autonomy. I do not know how to say this differently or more simply. I tried to find other words—and did not find them.

It seems that the answer lies precisely here: on the Cross a person renounces being the source of his own life and receives into himself the Source of eternity. Only such a life is not confined by the limits of this world.

There is one nuance here that cannot be bypassed. At least on the lexical, verbal level, the project of renouncing ontological autonomy sounds suspicious. It clearly resembles totalitarianism. This must be clarified.

Every totalitarianism demands the renunciation of freedom, of opinion. Every totalitarianism seeks to destroy personality, to dissolve the “I.” Does renunciation of ontological autonomy not demand the same?

Accepting God as the source of life is always an individual, personal act. In this matter witnesses are hardly possible. Totalitarian submission always implies dissolution into the collective. Witnesses are mandatory there. Most importantly, totalitarianism removes responsibility. This is the price for renouncing personality, for renouncing the right to one’s own “I,” for submission to coercion and control. The Cross does not remove responsibility. On the contrary. Renunciation of ontological autonomy means renunciation of the right to arbitrariness—and nothing more. The Cross means the obligation of full and absolute submission to truth and humanity, and therefore to freedom. Acceptance of Jesus means the full unfolding of the potential of personality. A Christian—that is, another Christ—does not lose his name and does not become faceless. In Christ it is not personality and not the “I” that is abolished. Only the claim of the autonomous “I” to be the source of its own being is abolished. Life remains in me—but not from me. And only in such freedom is the Cross possible.

Let us return to Christ bin. It seems to me that we have said everything that could be said about the potential of faith. And words ended when we reached the most important thing—practice, the Cross.

...

Faith as competence, the practice of the Cross as competence. These words came on their own; they keep circling on the tongue. I myself do not yet clearly know what they mean.

Let us think about this together.

Before speaking about faith as competence, it is necessary to clearly define what should in general be understood by competence.

In everyday speech this word is often used to denote knowledge, experience, professional training, or authority — “competent authorities.” However, in the strict sense, competence is neither a sum of knowledge nor a set of skills.

Competence is a stable ability to act adequately in relation to reality under conditions of uncertainty, risk, and the absence of external instructions.

Competence manifests itself not where everything is known in advance and prescribed, but precisely where there is no ready-made algorithm, where it is impossible to fully rely on past experience, where a decision requires personal responsibility, and where the cost of error is real.

Therefore, competence is not identical with knowledge. A person may know — and yet be incompetent. He may be educated, erudite, convinced — and at the same time incapable of acting when supports disappear. In the same way, competence is not reducible to skill: a skill functions in repetitive conditions, competence — in unique ones.

Competence cannot be proven by words and cannot be appropriated declaratively. It is recognized only through action and only post factum. Before action, one cannot say with certainty whether a person possesses competence; after action, this becomes evident — regardless of whether the outcome was accompanied by success.

The most important characteristic of any competence is that it always presupposes an internal center of decision-making. A competent person does not shift the decision onto instructions, onto the collective, onto circumstances, or onto an emotional state. He acts from within a decision that has been made and assumes responsibility for the consequences. Precisely for this reason competence is always

connected with responsibility and incompatible with external control: where action is fully controlled, competence is not required.

From Abkhaz experience, from the experience of the Abkhaz war, I would add one more important aspect of real competence: competence rests on knowledge of the future, on the ability to relate oneself to the future. In essence, competence is reduced to the ability to influence the future. This sounds somewhat magical, not to say fairy-tale-like, but in fact everything is quite simple.

A certain crisis takes place. Something unknown occurs. The only thing that is known is the fact that defeat is worse than death. That is, there is no possibility of accepting the existing situation. And usually, out of nowhere, someone appears — previously unknown — who sees a solution, sees a way out of the crisis. And the crisis, in its acute form, is overcome.

Finally, competence is always connected with the question of the source of action. Incompetence almost always manifests itself as an attempt to act for the sake of preserving oneself, one's status, one's security. Competence, on the contrary, begins where a person is oriented toward reality rather than self-preservation; even in a collective sense, even if this requires abandoning habitual supports, habitual "competences."

For this reason competence is not a psychological state, not a conviction, and not an identity. It is the ability to act without making oneself the source of action. Reality itself becomes the source of action.

By and large, the question of the quality of competence reduces to the question of the criterion. We have already spoken above about the regression of criteria. Therefore, the switch to the mode of the ontological recipient resolves precisely this most difficult problem. If a person proves capable of orienting himself not toward himself, not toward his inner world as the source of reality, the dimensionality of his freedom increases by orders of magnitude; we remember the number of zeros in the formula "10 to the power of plus 17."

In fact, we have discovered that faith is the foundation of any competence. Faith in the technical sense, that is, the operation with the future. But what interests us is precisely Christian faith, that is, a religious practice based on an ontological claim.

On the basis of what has been described above, what can an attempt to consider Christian faith as competence give us?

If Christian faith is considered as competence, first of all the very angle of vision changes. The discussion is no longer about what a person believes in, which

statements he accepts, and which formulas he considers true. It is about how he lives, from which source he acts, and how he relates himself to the future.

First, such an approach removes the false alternative between faith and reality. Faith ceases to be an “addition” to life — a private conviction, a psychological support, or a cultural identity. It becomes a way of orienting oneself in reality, precisely there where reality ceases to be manageable and predictable. In this sense, Christian faith turns out not to be an escape from the world, but a form of the highest sobriety.

Second, faith as competence makes it possible to clearly distinguish genuine faith from its simulations. Where faith does not lead to responsibility, does not change the source of action, and does not affect the relationship to the future, it remains either a psychological phenomenon, or an ideology, or a form of collective identity. Considering faith as competence immediately reveals these substitutions without entering into polemics with them.

Third, such a view returns the Cross to the center of Christian practice. If faith is competence, then the Cross turns out to be not a symbol and not an object of veneration, but a key act of calibration. It is precisely on the Cross that the renunciation of an autonomous source of action and the transition to the mode of the ontological recipient take place. Without this transition, faith cannot become competence and remains merely the content of consciousness.

Fourth, understanding faith as competence explains its irreducible connection with the future. Christian faith is not knowledge of “how everything is arranged,” and not confidence in a favorable outcome. It is the ability to live and act proceeding from a future that has not yet been given, but already determines the present. In this sense, faith truly is a form of operating with the future — not as a forecast, but as a reality from which the direction of action is drawn.

Finally, such an approach allows freedom to be understood in a new way. Faith as competence does not restrict freedom, but radically expands it. By renouncing arbitrariness and self-preservation as the highest criterion, a person goes beyond closed autonomy and acquires the ability to act in a dimension inaccessible to the autonomous subject. That is why the growth of freedom here is not linear but exponential — let us not forget the zeros in “10 to the power of plus 17.”

Thus, considering Christian faith as competence makes it possible to see in it not a private religious phenomenon, but the foundation of the human ability to act in reality when habitual supports collapse, criteria regress, and the future demands an answer. And precisely in this capacity faith ceases to be a subject of dispute and becomes a subject of life — the main skill of life.

Now let us try to see how, in practice, faith becomes competence. How exactly does Christian faith become competence?

I said that faith ceases to be the content of consciousness and becomes a competence of being. This sounds beautiful — but only until the question is asked: where is this visible? Where and how is this recognized in living life, and not in a text?

Competence is always recognized not by words, but by load. It cannot be “possessed” in the form of a conviction. It can only be borne. Therefore, faith as competence begins to become discernible where supports disappear: where there is no longer clarity, no guarantees, no support, and no right to “later.”

And here it is immediately useful to say one simple thing: as long as faith works only “in good weather,” as long as it functions exclusively in a mode of comfort and intelligibility, it is not yet competence. It is a form of spiritual well-being. It may be sincere, it may be pious, it may even be many-years-old. But it becomes competence only where faith ceases to be “what I experience” and becomes how I act when I no longer have anything to hide behind.

I see seven signs of Christian faith as competence.

1) Competence begins where supports disappear

There are situations in which a person can be “believing” without any risk. He goes to church, he is in his own milieu, he knows the language, he knows the ritual, he is “on the right side”. His faith is supported by habit, environment, structure.

But there are situations where faith is deprived of all crutches: you are not understood and are not going to be understood; you cannot explain yourself, because explanation will turn into self-justification; the correct decision brings no benefit; justice loses; “your own people” remain silent or demand betrayal of truth for the sake of “ours”.

It is precisely here that it becomes visible whether faith is an address or a role. Whether it is “I speak about God” or “I live from God”. Whether it is “I have a conviction” or “I have a source”.

And that is why the competence of faith begins not in church and not in clarity, but at the point where clarity ends.

I will not comment on how relevant, in this sense, lavish church rituals are.

2) Fear is not an enemy, but a test of reality.

The first sign of living competence is uncertainty. Certainty is too often a counterfeit. It is easily produced by temperament, experience, character, even professional habit. Certainty can be simulated and worn like a mask.

Fear, however, is harder to simulate. Fear is an honest marker. It shows that the price is real. It says: “here you can lose”. And precisely for this reason fear is not an argument against faith, but the field in which faith becomes visible.

Incompetent faith does a simple thing: it tries to eliminate fear. It looks for anesthetic. It “calms itself down” instead of responding. It switches into a mode of self-preservation, calling this “humility”, “obedience”, “wisdom”.

Competent faith does not abolish fear. It does something else: it does not allow fear to become the criterion. Fear is a signal of price. Competence does not cancel the price; it makes payment possible. Where faith becomes competence, a person stops asking: “how can I not be afraid?” — and begins to ask: “what is the truth that I must not betray?”

This is extremely important: faith does not turn a person into a hero. Faith makes a person an addressee who is capable of acting even when afraid.

In any case, self-confidence is a sure and obligatory sign of the simulation of faith.

3) Decision — the choice of the source

As long as faith lives at the level of opinion, decision is a choice of position. “I believe that this is right.” “I adhere to such views.”

As long as faith lives as identity, decision is a choice of loyalty: “this is how we do it”, “this is how it is done among us”.

As long as faith lives as consolation, decision is postponed: “God will take care of it”, “somehow it will work out”.

But faith becomes competence in a different place: at the moment when decision ceases to serve self-preservation.

Here the main thing cannot be avoided. Decision in faith is not simply a “choice of the good”. It is a choice of the source. It is a refusal of the role “I am the beginning”. It is an internal shift of address: not “I am”, but “God is — and therefore I am”. Not “I decide”, but “I respond”.

That is why competent faith is characterized by two features that almost always look “strange” externally: fewer explanations and more inner definiteness; the decision is not demonstrated, because it is not for the public.

Competence always has a quiet formula: "I cannot do otherwise." But it is important that this "cannot" is not pride, not psycho-physiology of character, and not an aesthetic of heroism, but precision of address: I cannot do otherwise, because otherwise I will again become the source and again begin to live from myself.

4) Responsibility: the cancellation of alibis

Competence does not exist without responsibility. Therefore, faith as competence does the most painful thing for a human being: it destroys alibis.

A person lives in a mode of alibi. "They forced me." "This is how it is done." "Everyone does this." "Circumstances." "I could not do otherwise." One could list such excuses endlessly, or recall Heidegger's *das Man*; again, there is no getting around German.

All of this is an attempt to shift the fact onto the external. It is an attempt to cancel oneself as addressee. But faith as competence means: I remain the address. Not because I am a "hero", but because otherwise faith turns into simulation.

That is why wherever faith removes responsibility, it is not faith but a drug. Faith is not given to make things easier. It is given to make life possible — that is, to make action in reality possible without replacing reality with "explanations".

And here a frightening, but liberating thing appears: faith ceases to bargain. It ceases to demand conditions: "I will believe if...". Competence demands no conditions. Competence acts under any conditions.

5) Solitude: action without witnesses

Where competence begins, the possibility of a "collective decision" ends. Not because the collective is bad, but because it is always a concrete addressee who decides. And no one can become the addressee instead of you. Therefore, the competence of faith is recognized by the ability to act without witnesses.

This is directly connected with what I already said about totalitarianism. Totalitarianism does not merely control — it destroys the solitude of the addressee. It makes the collective the final instance. It replaces responsibility with submission. It replaces decision with consent.

But faith as competence begins precisely where a person is capable of taking a step even if: no one will see; no one will evaluate; "one's own people" will not support it; and "outsiders" will not understand.

The Cross is always accomplished in solitude, even if there is a crowd around. This is not romanticism. This is the structure of reality: decision and responsibility are always solitary.

And here the most important test appears: if a person needs witnesses for his “faith”, if he needs confirmation from “his own”, if he performs an act so that it will be noticed, this means that faith has not yet become competence; it is still serving identity.

6) The future: being from non-being, living from what does not yet exist

The most precise sign of competent faith is its relation to the future.

Incompetence lives from the past (memory, tradition as a museum) or from the present (comfort, safety). Competence lives from the future. But not as people dream. And not as they plan.

Faith as competence is the ability to live as if the future is already acting in the present. Not “to believe that everything will be fine”, but to live from the future Kingdom. This means: I act not because I see the result, but because the truth of the future has already made a demand on me now.

Therefore, competent faith knows how to maintain direction without results. It does not sell truth for “quick improvement”. It does not replace the criterion with the outcome.

The competence of faith is action from the future, not waiting for the future.

7) Stability of the mode: return to the Source

And finally, the most incomprehensible thing for modern consciousness: competence is not a one-time heroism. Heroism can be a flash. Competence is a mode.

Therefore, the decisive sign of faith as competence is, first, the ability to recognize the Other as one’s source, and second, the ability to return to the Source after falls.

This is the true meaning of repentance. Repentance is not emotion and not self-flagellation. Repentance is the restoration of address. Not “I am bad”, but “I have again placed myself in the position of source”. Not “I am worth nothing”, but “I have again begun to live from myself”.

And here faith becomes practice: it ceases to be a drama of wounded pride and becomes a sober return to reality. Like breathing. Like a return to the foundation that holds a person in reality, even when there is nothing else inside that holds.

Substitutions: what faith without competence looks like

Now things can be called by their proper names. Simulation is when the word “faith” remains, but competence does not. That is, there is no Cross, no freedom, no responsibility, no future. Forms remain.

And there is a very simple criterion: genuine faith increases freedom and responsibility; simulation reduces them.

Here are four signs of simulation.

1) Faith without the Cross

Faith without the Cross is religion within the limits of the world. It may be high morality, culture, idealism, even self-sacrifice. But the source remains “I”. The price has not been paid. Autonomy has not been surrendered. The person remains the master of his life and asks God to be his amplifier.

Such faith does not lead where Christ leads. It leads to an improved biography. It does not bring one out of death as the final argument.

2) Faith under control

If faith can be controlled, it is no longer possible to believe in it. Control kills competence just as control kills love. Where there is control, there is no addressee. There is a function.

Faith under control always replaces responsibility with submission. It cultivates the fear of “being not like that” and makes the collective the criterion of truth. It is very convenient for the institution — and deadly for life.

3) Faith as identity

Identity says: “we”. Faith says: “here is the truth — and I answer”.

When faith becomes identity, a person defends “ours”, not the truth. He lives in the logic of the password, not of the Cross. He shifts the center from the future to the past: to symbolism, to cultural code, to belonging. And then the Cross is replaced by signs of the Cross.

4) Faith as consolation

Consolation can be a gift — but when it becomes the main meaning of “faith”, God turns into a function of psychotherapy. Prayer becomes a technique of self-soothing. Truth becomes “so that I feel better”.

This is a direct path to the loss of reality.

Faith is not given so that it becomes easier. It is given so that it becomes possible to live.

The final test

If faith makes you less free and less responsible — it is simulation. If faith makes you more free and more responsible — it is competence.

Directly to eschatology

Here it becomes clear why without eschatology everything falls apart. Eschatology is not a section “about the end of the world”. It is the ontology of the future that is already acting now.

The criterion of truth is not born within history. It comes to history.

The autonomous “I” can have plans. But it cannot have eternity. It lives by what it can hold: status, safety, memory, control. It cannot live from what does not yet exist.

That is why the Cross is not morality and not a symbol, but a transition: refusal to be the source → acceptance of the Source. On the Cross a person ceases to belong to death as the final argument.

And then the harshest formula emerges, the one the modern mind hates: faith does not guarantee an outcome. It guarantees that the outcome is no longer the criterion.

Freedom is not arbitrariness of choice. Freedom is the ability to act from the Kingdom, and not from fear. And if the Church is not a museum of apostolicity but an access to the future, then it becomes clear why faith is not waiting for the Kingdom, but living from it. Freedom means: already now, in the midst of this world, to live from the Kingdom.

It seems that everything has already been said, yet some simple things still remain that must be spoken aloud.

Action becomes action proper only under conditions of crisis. A crisis implies the presence of a threat. The choice of a strategy for exiting a crisis directly depends on how the subject is understood. If the subject is the “I” — whether an individual “I” or a collective one — then God, that is, the highest reality, remains in the background. As long as the “I” is in play, it is impossible to see the eschaton. Short-term, medium-term, and long-term forecasts and plans are possible; any strategic analyst can demonstrate this, as they say, “on one’s fingers.” But eschatology will remain inaccessible.

Any communication on the side of the recipient requires silence. If the recipient fills the air with noise, what can they hear? Nothing. Yet this is a universal rule. If we want to know what is happening with the “10 to the power of plus seventeen” of our reality, we must at the very least listen to it. Reality can be seen only from the position of the recipient, not of the transmitter. This is simple and obvious.

If we translate this observation into the language of faith, we must make one more paradoxical statement. Faith is optimism, as we have already discovered. But real faith is incompatible with self-satisfaction.

And in general, I would like to point out clearly and directly who our main enemy is. We know the standard icon of Satan: horns, a tail, goat’s legs, disproportionately obscene genitalia. But the main enemy is not hidden behind this honest icon. The main enemy is fiction. The real enemy has long mastered “our” design. He has long learned to look like “one of us,” to speak like “one of us.” Why is no one surprised that the serpent entered Eden? Because he passed face control. He already knew how to do that back then.

I have the impression that when the Lord spoke of the “little flock,” He did not have global sociology in mind. He had ecclesial sociology in mind. In this sense, nothing has changed since the time of the prophet Elijah, and it is unlikely that anything will change.

If we retell “simply, in human terms” everything I have described above, the following picture emerges. Christianity, faith in Christ, the Cross as practice — this is the acceptance of full responsibility; it is an absolute renunciation of one’s right to arbitrariness.

Church as the Infrastructure for the Formation of Personal Eschatology

1. Definition of the Church

The Church may be understood as the infrastructure for the formation of personal eschatology.

Personal eschatology does not mean merely an idea about the future, nor only the dogmatic teaching about the end of history. Personal eschatology signifies an attempt to form personal subjecthood within the Eschaton.

The question at stake is more radical: how can the human person preserve their subjecthood in the ultimate reality of being? In this sense, a human being seeks to think of themselves not only as a subject within historical time, but also as a subject capable of existing in the Eschaton.

Historical life is therefore neither devalued nor pushed into the background. On the contrary, it acquires a maximally intensified character. If the subject thinks of themselves within the horizon of the Eschaton, their existence in history begins to be perceived as the space for the realization of this subjectivity. The Aeon becomes the place where eschatological subjecthood is tested, formed, and manifested in concrete actions.

In this sense, the Church represents the space in which the subject receives the possibility of forming such eschatological subjecthood and actualizing it within history. The practices of the Church—liturgy, prayer, ascetic discipline, catechesis, and work with texts—may be understood as a form of ontological therapy: a gradual process of freeing the subject from false foundations of existence and restoring its orientation toward the Logos.

The result of this process is the formation of the eschatological subject—a human being capable of living from the horizon of the Eschaton within historical time.

Below a model of such ontological therapy is proposed.

2. Structure of Ontological Therapy

0. Ontological Stop

(ontological interruption)

The ontological stop denotes the moment at which the subject interrupts the automatic flow of life and for the first time becomes aware that their existence is

directed by a certain horizon of the future which they have neither chosen nor reflected upon.

This is not a psychological crisis but an ontological rupture, in which the hidden teleology of existence becomes an object of consciousness.

From this moment a fundamental question arises before the human being: from which future does one live, and who determines the direction of one's life?

1. Choice of the Subject Position

(logos coherence)

After the ontological stop, the person finds themselves before the possibility of taking a subject position.

The subject position means refusing to exist in the mode of mere adaptation to circumstances and recognizing one's own responsibility for the direction of one's life. The person ceases to see themselves merely as the result of external forces and begins to perceive themselves as an instance of decision.

The subject position presupposes logos coherence—a readiness to be honest with oneself and not to conceal contradictions between one's own convictions, actions, and reality.

Without this coherence the subject position is impossible. The subject arises only where a person is ready not to lie to themselves about their own existence.

2. Self-Determination of the Subject

(the search for authenticity and identity with oneself)

At this stage the subject discovers the instance of the "I" and begins the search for their own authenticity.

Self-determination does not merely mean fixing a personal opinion; it means seeking identity with oneself—an attempt to discover one's own nature and to form an inner coherence of existence.

Self-determination and the search for authenticity are inseparable: the subject arises only where a person strives to become themselves.

3. Decolonization of Personality

The search for authenticity requires liberation from those structures of meaning and value that were implanted from outside and that in fact determined the direction of the subject's life.

Such structures include cultural expectations, ideological constructions, social roles, collective identities, and psychological patterns of behavior.

The exposure of these structures destroys the habitual foundations of existence and brings the subject to a state of ontological vacuum. This state is experienced as existential destabilization: former orientations lose their force, while new ones have not yet been formed.

Yet it is precisely this instability that makes the formation of a truly independent position possible.

4. Formation of Ontological Autonomy

(capacity for projectuality)

After decolonization, the subject seeks to form a stable autonomy.

Ontological autonomy means the capacity to maintain one's own position and preserve identity with oneself regardless of the pressure of circumstances. At this stage, not yet the project of life itself is formed, but rather the capacity for a project—the instruments for designing, modeling the future, and maintaining a life trajectory.

The subject learns to think of their life as an open field of possible directions.

However, diagnosis is necessary here. Not every autonomy is authentic. Many forms of life produce only its mirage: dependence on success, recognition, power, ideology, or psychological comfort may be experienced as independence, although in reality the subject remains governed by external structures.

Authentic autonomy manifests itself not in the ability to realize desires, but in the ability to maintain one's own position in the face of the pressure of circumstances and not to lose identity with oneself.

5. Formation of the Project of the Future

The foundation of autonomy becomes a personal project of the future, for the sake of which a person makes decisions and structures their own life. Existence acquires a projective character: a person begins to form an image of the future capable of giving their life coherence.

By its nature, the subject strives to expand the ontological scale of its own existence. This expansion is expressed in the increase of the volume of reality that the subject is able to hold within its thinking and action.

A healthy personality—a subject with a high quality of ontology—strives to expand as much as possible the zone of its ontological claims. However, such expansion is possible only if logos coherence is preserved. As the subject includes an ever broader scale of reality within the field of its attention, the zone of its responsibility inevitably expands as well.

Thus, the expansion of the subject's ontological scale leads to the formation of an ever larger project of the future.

In its ultimate form, this process leads to the necessity of forming a messianic identity.

Messianic identity is understood as a form of existence in which the subject assumes responsibility for the world and regards its own life as participation in the overcoming of the entropy of being.

In this sense one may also speak of the messianic function of the subject. This does not refer to an external role or a special historical privilege, but to the ultimate form of the development of healthy subjectivity.

6. Crisis of Autonomy

(the limit of self-foundation)

Further development leads to the discovery of the limit of autonomy.

The attempt to construct the ultimate foundation of one's mission solely by one's own powers proves internally contradictory. Biological finitude, the temporality of existence, and dependence on many conditions make the complete self-foundation of the subject impossible.

Autonomy thus appears as a necessary stage in the formation of personality, yet it is incapable of becoming the ultimate foundation of meaning.

7. Discovery of the Necessity of Eschatology

The crisis of autonomy opens the question of the ultimate foundation of existence.

The subject begins to understand that the project of the future requires a final horizon that surpasses its own capacities. There arises the necessity of eschatology—an ultimate perspective in which human subjecthood may receive its final foundation.

8. Personal Eschatology

Personal eschatology signifies the attempt to form a subjecthood capable of existing in the Eschaton.

A human being strives to think of themselves not only as a subject within historical time, but as a subject capable of preserving their identity within the ultimate reality of being.

Historical life thereby acquires an eschatological and messianic character. The Aeon becomes the space in which eschatological subjecthood is tested and manifested in concrete actions.

In other words, the human being seeks to form their subjecthood within the horizon of the Eschaton and to live historical existence as its messianic actualization.

9. Recognition of the Logos

The search for the foundation of eschatological subjecthood leads to the recognition of the Logos as the source of meaning and being.

Christianity appears here not as a moral system nor as a cultural tradition, but as an ontological affirmation: the Logos, who is the source of meaning, has become accessible to the human being.

10. Identity through Participation

The recognition of the Logos remains abstract until the subject enters into a relation of participation.

Identity is stabilized through participation in the Logos. The subject exists not as the source of its own mission, but as the one who receives and bears it.

Only here does the subject gain the possibility of preserving identity in the ultimate sense—not merely as inner psychological coherence, but as participation in the source of being and meaning.

11. The Practice of the Cross

(ontological re-addressing)

Participation in the Logos must be confirmed in real existential acts.

The practice of the Cross denotes those situations in which the subject renounces empirical guarantees for the sake of preserving the truth of its ultimate horizon.

Each such act represents an ontological re-addressing of existence to its source.

12. Textual and Ontological Verification

Any personal experience requires verification. Without such verification there is a risk of replacing the Logos with one's own projections.

Therefore, verification is carried out primarily through texts that contain concentrated ontological experience: Sacred Scripture, the texts of the apostolic era, the patristic tradition, and philosophical works that have reached ontological depth.

13. The Ontological Mode of Life

When the mission passes verification, it ceases to be a separate decision and becomes a stable mode of existence.

The subject begins to live not from fictitious foundations but from truth. Its actions are determined not by the fear of the present nor by the pressure of circumstances, but by the horizon of the coming reality.

Thus an ontological mode of life is formed in which the person preserves identity within change and acts from an orientation toward the Eschaton.

In this sense, the goal of ecclesial practice is the formation of a human being whose existence takes the form of mission.

It is precisely this form of existence that the Christian tradition designates by the word apostleship.

Interpretive Condition

In all points where human choice or the ability of the subject to assume a certain position is discussed, it is presupposed that there exists a capacity which in the theological tradition is designated by the concept of grace, understood as the condition of possibility for this choice.

Metaphysics of the CTM Project

(Christians of the Third Millennium)

PART 0. METHODOLOGICAL KEY

0.1. Distinction of Registers

This commentary deliberately places itself within the field of tension between classical metaphysics and post-metaphysical critique. We proceed from Jürgen Habermas's observation about the historical end of metaphysics at the present stage, yet we challenge the conclusion that normativity can be reduced to a purely discursive function.

The text does not claim to construct a new dogmatic system. Its task is rather to identify the structure of the subject's orientation under conditions of ontological instability.

We employ a number of terms ("logocentrism," "autonomy," "participation") that possess a dense history in twentieth-century philosophy. In order to avoid accusations of academic deafness, we immediately clarify our points of divergence from the tradition:

Term	Tradition	Here (CTM)
Logocentricity	J. diagnosis of the metaphysical illusion of a center	Derrida: of the illusion of a principle of coherence, thinking is impossible
Ontological Autonomy	I. Kant: autonomy of the will as a good	Description of an ontological rupture: the created "I" claims the status of the source of being
Decolonization	Postcolonial theory: liberation from political domination	Ontological liberation from false centers of self-determination

This commentary should be read as an attempt to construct a metaphysics of post-metaphysics: while acknowledging the end of classical systems, we nevertheless affirm the inevitability of a normative level of being.

The text operates within the boundaries of three registers:

Register	Status	For whom
Philosophical	Logos as an ontological necessity	For external dialogue (philosophers, academia)
Theological	Logos as the incarnate God-Christ	For internal use (the Church, believers)
Operational	Method as an instrument of distinction	For practitioners: principle of coherence of thought

0.2. The Author's Position

The author writes from the periphery — from a space where the disintegration of society has been experienced as a personal reality, not merely as a theoretical problem. This does not grant the author any privilege of truth, but it may offer a different perspective. From the periphery it may be easier to see what remains hidden from the center: the fragility of institutions, the simulacral nature of norms, and the entropy of communication.

This position is neither an advantage nor a disadvantage — it is simply different. The author is aware of the possible distortions associated with traumatic experience and does not claim objectivity in the classical sense.

PART I. FUNDAMENTAL ONTOLOGY

1.1. The Initial Situation

The contemporary state of thought is characterized by a post-metaphysical orientation. Christianity no longer forms the ontology of culture — and thanks be to God. In philosophical discourse this is referred to as the “end of metaphysics.” The

subject has lost its status as an ontological center. Truth is reduced to a discursive function. Freedom is problematized empirically.

Yet for the author, such a formulation — treating the end of classical metaphysics as the end of thinking itself with all its consequences — is unacceptable.

The post-metaphysical tradition — from Nietzsche to Heidegger and Derrida — does not assert the thesis “there is no truth,” but something more complex: truth is an event; it is always inscribed within the contexts of language, power, and history; being conceals itself. This is a serious position that cannot be refuted by a simple appeal to performative contradiction.

However, the practical structure of thinking preserves normativity: the distinction between truth and fiction, between the correct and the incorrect, between responsibility and arbitrariness. The question is not how to “refute” post-metaphysics, but how to live once the epoch has accepted its arguments and rejected metaphysics.

Consequently, the post-metaphysical condition does not eliminate the normative level but merely problematizes it. The task is not to invent normativity but to identify its ontological status after critique.

1.2. Stratified Ontology

Reality must be described as stratified. At a minimum, five levels can be distinguished:

Level	Content	Risk of Reduction
Biological	Instinct, neurophysiology, body	“The human being is only a body”
Psychological	Emotions, the unconscious, trauma	“Everything is determined by the psyche”
Social	Language, discourse, norms, power	“Everything is a social construct”

Level	Content	Risk of Reduction
Normative	Truth, meaning, coherence	"Norms are an illusion"
Ultimate	Logos, the horizon of being	"This is metaphysics, not reality"

Theological concepts of ontology (the universe, the world of angels, God) are not included here in order to simplify thinking and communication.

The central thesis is this: no level explains the others. Reductionism is an ontological error. The transition between levels requires an ontological leap, not merely the accumulation of data.

"Reality is not flat. It is given to the human being as a multi-layered structure. The reduction of any level to another is a form of ontological violence."

Stratification describes levels of being. Ontological regimes (Aeon and Eschaton) are considered separately, since they describe a mode of existence, not the depth of reality.

Stratification and the category of normativity are used here operationally—as instruments of distinction rather than as metaphysical dogmas. The author does not conceal that his real ontological picture is Christian, but in this text it is placed in brackets in order to make dialogue possible.

1.3. Logos

Definition: The Logos is the principle of the coherence of being. It is the foundation for distinguishing truth from fiction and the horizon of orientation for the subject.

The question arises: why is a hypostasized Logos necessary, rather than, for example, Kant's "I think" or Heidegger's Dasein? The answer can be given in two registers.

In the philosophical register: Kant's transcendental unity of apperception describes the structure of the subject but does not provide a criterion for distinguishing the truth of contents. It is formal. The Logos, by contrast, presupposes

that the coherence of being precedes the subject and makes it possible. This is a hypothesis, not a proof.

In the theological register: The Logos is not an abstract principle but the incarnate God who passed through the Crucifixion. This distinguishes it from ideological phantoms, which always demand service without self-sacrifice. The Logos of Christianity is the Logos of the Cross. But this already goes beyond the limits of the philosophical register.

Function	Description	Example
Coherence	Ensures the minimal unity of reality	Without the Logos, experience disintegrates into fragments
Critique	Makes possible the critique of particular levels	Without the Logos, critique loses its criterion
Prevention of absolutization	Prevents a derived level from becoming ultimate	Without the Logos, biology/society become idols

“The Logos is not what we know. The Logos is that by which knowledge becomes possible.”

1.4. The Subject

Definition: The subject is the capacity for ontological re-addressing of the foundation. The subject does not eliminate biology, psyche, or society. But it can change the hierarchy—what is considered the ultimate foundation for decisions.

The subject is a vector, not a point.

Tradition	Definition of the Subject	Problem
Descartes	Thinking substance (res cogitans)	The subject is closed in upon itself
Kant	Transcendental condition	The subject is

Tradition	Definition of the Subject	Problem
	of experience	formal
Postmodernism	Effect of discourse	The subject is eliminated
CTM	Capacity for re-addressing the foundation	The subject = function, not a thing

“The subject is not what is. The subject is what does. Not a thing, but a function. Not a point, but a vector.”

What the subject can do: change the hierarchy of foundations; orient itself toward the Logos or toward a derived level; re-address the source of being. What the subject cannot do: create being out of itself; eliminate biology, psyche, or society; become the source of its own life.

1.5. Freedom

Definition: Freedom is the capacity to change the ontological center of gravity.

A human being is not free from conditions (biology, history, society). But one is free in choosing what to recognize as the ultimate foundation.

Freedom is re-addressing, not arbitrariness.

Sartre	CTM
Freedom as an existential project	Freedom as a structural choice of the source
Man is condemned to freedom	Man is free in the choice of the foundation

Sartre	CTM
Freedom = arbitrariness	Freedom = re-addressing

Two types of freedom: freedom from (negative) — “I am not obliged to obey,” which leads to liberation but also to emptiness; freedom for (positive) — “I choose what to serve,” which leads to orientation and rootedness.

“Freedom is not the possibility to do anything. Freedom is the possibility to choose what to live from.”

PART II. ONTOLOGICAL TYPOLOGY

2.1. Two Types of Ontological Orientation

A critical clarification: the terms “logocentric/logofugal” and “solidaric/competitive” ontologies originally refer to the distinction between Aeon and Eschaton. Their later use has been extended.

It is important to note that pure types do not exist. Most people exist in intermediate, mixed states. Orientation is not a binary choice but a dynamic field of tension. A person may be logocentric in one area of life and logofugal in another.

Thus, the typology is an instrument of distinction, not a classification of people.

Type	Formula	Consequence
Logocentric	“Logos is the foundation, I am the recipient”	Stability, coherence, identity
Logofugal	“I / fear / society are the foundation”	Entropy, fragmentation, disintegration

This is not a moral evaluation but an ontological description. Logofugality leads to disintegration not because it is “bad,” but because derived levels cannot sustain identity in the face of death.

“Orientation is not what you believe in. Orientation is what you live from.”

2.2. Aeon and Eschaton

Parameter	Aeon	Eschaton
Ontology	Competitive / logofugal	Solidaric / logocentric
Truth	Relative, dependent on position	Absolute, falsehood impossible
Subject	Autonomous, fragmented	Rooted in the Logos, whole
Freedom	Freedom from (negative)	Freedom for (positive)

The intermediate space is a zone within the Aeon where salvation in Christ has already been accomplished, but the fullness of the Kingdom (the Eschaton) has not yet arrived. It is the space of human responsibility, where ontological choice is still possible and has consequences.

“To live from the Eschaton within the Aeon means to strive, already within history, to align oneself with the ultimate horizon.”

2.3. Entropy

Communication is subject to entropy. Language is devalued. Normativity becomes blurred. Foundations become derivative. Consequently, the orientation of the subject becomes unstable.

Human beings act while relying on an infinitesimally small portion of objective reality — an image from the main CTM text refers to a “ 10^{-17} filter.” This is not a scientific statement but a metaphor expressing the structural limitation of human perception. The rest is a construction of consciousness.

The task of ontological work is to include within this filter a source not subject to entropy (the Logos) in order to increase access to reality.

2.4. Ontological Tension

Definition: Ontological tension is a state of individual or collective being that arises under conditions of existential threat, in which habitual simulational regimes collapse, ontological noise is sharply reduced, and the subject is forced not to interpret reality but to relate to it directly; the cost of error becomes equal to the loss of being itself.

“Ontological tension is a regime in which reality ceases to be a background and becomes the stake.”

Not	Is
Psychological stress	Ontological regime
Emotional uplift	Sobriety of perception
Ideological mobilization	Rejection of simulation
Collective affect	Individual responsibility
Patriotic pathos	Ontological precision

Why this is possible in war: war abolishes the possibility of simulation. It makes being binary: to be / not to be.

“In war there is no place for lies. Lies kill. That is why in war people become sober. Not because they are better, but because simulation kills.”

It is important to note: ontological tension is an emergency regime, not a project for the future. It cannot be sustained for long. One must be prepared for war.

PART III. PRACTICAL PROJECTION

3.1. Ontological Axiom

The fullness of reality is not exhausted by the empirical. The Logos is the condition of the coherence of being and thinking. The subject is not a substance but

a function of re-addressing the foundation. Freedom is the choice of the source of foundation. History is a space of unstable orientation.

From this, practice follows.

3.2. Zero Phase: Diagnosis of Orientation

The question is: from which foundation does the subject live? This is not a moral test but an ontological diagnosis.

Possible regimes:

Regime	Type of Foundation
Autonomous	Self-foundation
Colonized	Derived foundation (ideology, trauma, role)
Logocentric	Re-addressed foundation

Without this diagnosis, no practice is possible.

3.3. Functions of Practice

Ontological practice performs six functions:

Unmasking of imitation — distinguishing real re-addressing from rhetorical cover.

Ontological tension — creating the conditions for a rupture with the previous foundation.

Re-addressing — the act of changing the foundation to the Logos without destroying the subject.

Stabilization — consolidation through form: practice, rhythm, dogmatic framework, community.

Integration of the limit — translating tension into ontological memory.

Social projection — transformation of the type of power, responsibility, and institution.

Before speaking about re-addressing, one important point must be considered: in order to relinquish autonomy, one must first possess it. Not everyone does. Therefore, the first phase of the work may consist in the formation of ontological autonomy, and only afterwards in its re-addressing. (Developed in the “Functional Structure” of the main CTM text.)

3.4. Social Ontologies

Type	Foundation
Competitive	Self-assertion
Solidaric	Common foundation
Logocentric	Coherence
Logofugal	Fragmentation

3.5. Ontological Therapy

Definition: Ontological therapy is the restoration of the correct foundation of the subject through the structured readdressing of its ground and its stabilization within the historical body.

Phases of Ontological Therapy

Phase 0: Diagnosis of orientation.

Determining the current orientation: autonomous, colonized, or logocentric regime.

Phase 1: Critical.

Unmasking imitation and ontological tension form a cycle: tension exposes imitation, and exposure deepens tension. This is not a linear sequence but a spiral.

Phase 2: Re-addressing.

The act of changing the foundation to the Logos without destroying the subject. This is structural freedom.

Phase 3: Stabilization.

Consolidation through form (practice, rhythm, dogmatic framework, communal

verification) and the integration of the limit (the translation of tension into ontological memory). Here the Church appears as the ontological infrastructure for the formation of personal eschatology.

Phase 4: Social projection.

If re-addressing becomes stable, the type of power changes, the type of responsibility changes, and the type of institution changes.

PART IV. FINAL ARCHITECTURE

4.1. Summary of Key Theses

The Logos is ontologically necessary.

The subject is the capacity for re-addressing the foundation.

Freedom is the change of the center of attraction.

Orientation is unstable (entropy).

Historical form is necessary for stabilization.

The Church is an event manifested in a body.

The body is subject to entropy.

Re-actualization is inevitable.

4.2. The Formula of the Subject after CTM

If this architecture withstands argumentation, it represents not spiritual journalism but a metaphysics of logocentric orientation. Its task is not to create a new system but to reveal the structure of the subject's orientation.

For a practicing Christian, the formula of the subject changes from "I am" (autonomy) to "Christ lives in me" (the ontological recipient).

This is a condensed expression of what occurs in the act of re-addressing.

Now the construction exists.

From this point onward, the proof begins through life.

APPENDIX. Key Categories of the Project

Below follows an explanation of the key concepts used in the commentary, indicating their place in the history of thought and the specific way in which the author employs them.

1. Logocentricity (Logocentricity)

Tradition: Introduced by L. Klages (1920s) and popularized by J. Derrida (1960s) as a critical term. It denotes the “metaphysical illusion” of the presence of a center (Truth, God) that can be deconstructed.

Here: The term is used in an inverted sense. We do not assert a naïve belief in a present center, but rather state the ontological impossibility of thinking without a principle of coherence.

Defense:

“Unlike Derridean deconstruction, I understand logocentricity not as dogmatic certainty but as a transcendental condition for the possibility of distinguishing truth from fiction.”

2. Logofugality (Logofugality)

Tradition: A neologism, analogous to terms such as “theocentric / theofugal.”

Here: Describes the ontological dynamic of flight from the foundation. This is not a moral sin but a structural displacement of the center of gravity toward derived levels (biology, society).

Defense:

“The term is introduced to describe a process that in theology is called the Fall, and in philosophy the forgetting of Being (Heidegger), but without the mystical burden.”

3. Ontological Autonomy (Ontological Autonomy)

Tradition: I. Kant (autonomy of the will as a good); M. Heidegger, J.-L. Marion, J. Zizioulas (critique of the autonomous subject as forgetfulness of Being/the Other).

Here: Used in a critical sense (closer to Zizioulas and Marion). Autonomy is the claim of the created “I” to be the source of its own being (Ich bin Gott), which is ontologically impossible and leads to disintegration.

Defense:

“The issue is not moral independence (Kant), but the ontological source. The subject is free but is not the source of life (Christ bin).”

4. Participatory Identity (Participatory Identity)

Tradition: Plato (μέθεξις — participation); Radical Orthodoxy (J. Milbank, C. Pickstock); Orthodox theology (theosis, θέωσις).

Here: The mechanism of personal stability. Identity is not produced by the subject but is constituted through participation in the Logos.

Defense:

“The concept approaches Radical Orthodoxy, but the emphasis is shifted from social theory to the ontology of the subject: participation as the condition for the preservation of identity.”

5. Decolonization of Personality (Decolonization of Personality)

Tradition: Postcolonial theory (F. Fanon, E. Said, W. Mignolo) — liberation from political and cultural domination.

Here: Ontological liberation from false centers of self-definition (ideologies, traumas, social roles).

Defense:

“The term is used metaphorically in relation to postcolonialism. The issue here is not politics, but the restoration of the subject’s right to ontological addressability.”

6. Subject as Re-addressing (Subject as Re-addressing)

Tradition: J. Lacan (the subject as rupture); A. Badiou (the subject as fidelity to an event); post-structuralism (the subject as function).

Here: The subject is not a thing but a vector. It is the capacity to change the hierarchy of foundations.

Defense:

“This definition accepts the critique of the substantial subject but restores its agency through the function of choosing the foundation rather than through substantiality.”

7. Church as Event and Form (Church as Event and Form)

Tradition: Eucharistic ecclesiology (Fr. N. Afanasiev); ontology of communion (Metropolitan J. Zizioulas); phenomenology of the event (M. Heidegger, A. Badiou).

Here: A balance between charismatic event and institutional form. The Church is understood as the ontological infrastructure for the formation of personal eschatology—the environment in which the subject constructs its relation to the ultimate horizon and stabilizes its orientation in time. Form is needed not for power but for the stabilization of the event in time.

Defense:

“Unlike purely event-based ecclesiology, this approach emphasizes the necessity of a historical body for the verification and transmission of experience, which brings the understanding closer to Heidegger’s notion of the holding of truth.”

8. Ontological Realism (Ontological Realism)

Tradition: Scientific realism vs. constructivism.

Here: A mode of life in which a person acts from the horizon of the coming reality (the Kingdom) rather than from fear of the present. It involves taking into account the fullness of reality (including the divine aspect), not merely its fragment.

Defense:

“This is not naïve realism but eschatological realism: reality includes the future as an active force.”

9. Ontological Tension

A mode of being in which reality ceases to be background and becomes the stake. It arises under conditions of existential threat, when simulation becomes deadly dangerous. It differs from psychological stress in that it affects not a state but the structure of being.

10. Faith as Competence

Faith is understood not as a psychological state or moral quality but as a functional capacity—the ability to distinguish ontological levels and correctly address the foundation.

Competentia fidei — the capacity to act from the Logos.

11. Christ bin

The formula of subjectivity: “Christ lives in me” (Gal. 2:20). The opposite of Ich bin Gott—the claim of the autonomous subject. Christ bin means that the subject does not produce being but participates in it. The subject is a recipient, not a source.

12. Ontological Dissonance

A state of structural mismatch between the addressing of the foundation and the real structure of being. It arises when a derived level is chosen as ultimate. It differs from psychological dissonance in that it affects not cognitive schemes but the very mode of existence.

13. The 10^{-17} Filter

A metaphor from the main CTM text expressing the structural limitation of human perception. Human beings perceive only an infinitesimal fraction of reality. This is not a scientific claim but an image. The task of ontological work is to include within this filter a source not subject to entropy (the Logos) in order to expand access to reality.

14. Limit of Complexity

The threshold beyond which increasing the complexity of a system leads to its disintegration. This applies both to individual psychology and to social systems. Exceeding this limit is one of the causes of logofugality.

15. Ontological Memory

A structure that preserves the experience of re-addressing after the intensity of the event has diminished. It differs from psychological memory in that it does not store information but possibility—the potential for a repeated act.

16. Ontological Shift

A structural change in the hierarchy of foundations. A synonym for re-addressing, but with an emphasis on irreversibility: after such a shift, returning to the previous configuration becomes impossible without disintegration.

17. Quality of Ontology

The quality of a subject's ontology is determined by the degree to which it retains the infinite horizon and by its capacity not to reduce reality to a finite scale. The removal of this horizon is a form of ontological degradation.

A subject with a high quality of ontology: preserves the maximal scale; expands the dimensionality of freedom; sustains the tension of being; models its own trajectory; does not reduce its readiness for action; seeks real ontological deification.

This commentary does not require the reader's agreement with theological dogmas in order to accept the ontological architecture it proposes. Instead, it invites the reader to test it in practice: does the re-addressing of the foundation toward the Logos increase the stability of the person, the capacity for love, and the sobriety of perception of reality?

If the answer is yes, the construction works independently of confessional affiliation.

If not, it should be discarded.

SUBJECT

The subject is a form of being structurally oriented toward expansion and foundation. Its distinction from other forms of life lies in the fact that it forms its behavior not on the basis of instincts or pre-given algorithms, but on the basis of reflection upon a complex configuration of the world accessible to it within the space of thought.

The expansion of the subject is not merely spatial or biological. It has cognitive and ontological dimensions. The subject expands not only its sphere of action but its horizon of understanding. It strives to include within its inner space the maximal possible scale of reality.

The scale of the subject is the volume of reality that it is capable of holding in consciousness and taking into account in its action. The greater the scale, the greater the complexity of decisions and the degree of responsibility. The expansion of the subject’s scale automatically expands the zone of its relatedness to reality. The subject is responsible not because it must be, but because it holds. The greater the volume of reality included in its horizon, the greater its degree of ontological responsibility.

Responsibility is not externally added to subjectivity; it is its structural consequence. A refusal of responsibility signifies a reduction of scale. A reduction of scale signifies a decline in the quality of the subject’s ontology.

The action of the subject is mediated by reflection. Between stimulus and response there exists a space of freedom.

Freedom is the capacity to decide on the basis of a reflected horizon rather than external pressure or internal automatism.

LIMIT AND RADICALIZATION OF EXPANSION

The subject is originally oriented toward maximal expansion. However, it encounters a limit: the finitude of empirical existence does not allow for the realization of an orientation toward infinite expansion.

Yet the limit does not abolish the vector.
It radicalizes it.

In its ultimate logic, the expansion of the subject is not confined to enlargement of scale. It assumes the form of a striving toward foundation.

It is not enough for the subject to understand the world. It is not enough to act within the world. It is not enough to be autonomous. The subject strives to be foundation—not only of itself but of the reality it holds within the horizon of its being. It seeks to become a principle of order, a source of meaning, and a criterion of truth. This tendency constitutes a structural orientation toward self-deification.

By self-deification is meant not a religious metaphor, but the ultimate logic of subjecthood itself: the striving for absolute self-sufficiency and universal foundation. This striving is not a moral error, but the internal logic of subjecthood as such.

CRISIS OF AUTONOMOUS TOTALITY

Having encountered the limit—finitude, mortality, the impossibility of producing being and guaranteeing truth—a subject with a high quality of ontology confronts the impossibility of autonomous self-deification.

It does not create being. It does not control time. It does not hold back death. It does not produce truth. The attempt to preserve a universal claim under conditions of finitude generates a regime of fiction. The ontology of fiction is a mode of being in which foundation is simulated through the reduction of the horizon and through the displacement or imitation of foundation.

Fictive self-deification is a form of defense against the limit.

NORM AND PATHOLOGY OF SUBJECTIVITY

A subject with a high quality of ontology does not renounce the striving toward infinity.

If the subject becomes satisfied with the finite and neutralizes the tension of the ultimate vector, a reduction of subjecthood occurs. A subject that abandons the striving for deification enters a derivative mode of being and loses its non-derivative point of foundation. In this sense, the quality of the subject's ontology is determined by the degree to which it sustains the infinite horizon and by its capacity not to reduce reality to a finite scale. The removal of this horizon constitutes a form of ontological degradation.

PARTICIPATORY ONTOLOGY AS RESOLUTION OF THE LIMIT

The recognition of the impossibility of autonomous universal foundation does not abolish the striving for deification. It makes it real.

If the subject cannot become the source of being from itself, the possibility remains of participation in a being that exceeds it. This constitutes the transition to participatory ontology.

Ontological re-addressing means the transfer of the function of foundation from the autonomous “I” to the transcendent Logos.

In this mode, the subject neither dissolves nor loses itself. It attains the ultimate realization of its nature through participation in the real foundation of being.

Self-deification is transformed into deification through participation.

STRATEGY OF RESPONSE TO THE LIMIT

The response to the discovery of the limit shapes the subject’s further existential strategy.

It either:

— closes itself within fiction and reduction,

or

— performs ontological re-addressing and preserves scale.

A subject with a high quality of ontology preserves maximal scale, expands the dimensionality of freedom, maintains the tension of being, models its own future trajectory, does not reduce its ontological mobilization toward action, and seeks real ontological deification.

II. ONTOLOGICAL POSITION

Ontological position is the structural mode of the subject’s being in reality. It determines the distribution of the center of foundation and the character of the subject’s participation in being. It is neither a psychological attitude nor a worldview, but a regime of relatedness to reality that determines the trajectory of existence.

Ontological position defines not only the character of the subject’s internal mobilization, but also the degree to which it sustains reality as a whole. The greater

the subject's scale, the wider the zone of its relatedness to reality, and the higher the degree of its ontological responsibility.

Responsibility here is neither externally added nor moral in character; it is a structural consequence of sustaining scale. A refusal of responsibility signifies the exclusion of a portion of reality from the horizon of holding and inevitably leads to a contraction of the scale of subjectivity.

Two basic modes of such a position are possible: the subject-position and the inertial position.

1. SUBJECT-POSITION

The subject-position presupposes: preservation of scale, expansion of freedom, acceptance of responsibility for one's own trajectory, maintenance of ontological tension, and the formation of one's own future project.

In this position, the subject sustains the substructures responsible for modeling its own future. Its informational and energetic metabolism is oriented toward the generation of its own project.

This position gives rise to the ontology of the act—a mode of being in which the subject sustains reality through ontological mobilization without neutralizing the ultimate horizon and without delegating foundation.

2. INERTIAL POSITION

The inertial position is characterized by: reduction of scale, simplification of the world-picture, transition to algorithmic patterns, lowering of ontological tension, and adaptation to an external project.

Here, the substructures responsible for modeling one's own future atrophy. Sovereignty is transferred to an external center.

The inertial position gives rise to the ontology of fiction—a mode in which stability is achieved through simplification and reduction of reality.

The lowering of tension creates the illusion of energetic economy. In reality, what occurs is not economy but redistribution: the energy required to sustain truth is replaced by the energy required to maintain a construct that protects against encounter with the limit.

Inertia does not eliminate tension; it masks it.

III. COLONIZATION AND DECOLONIZATION

The transition from the subject-position to the inertial position signifies colonization: the transfer of sovereignty to an external project.

Colonization is the transition to a derivative mode of ontology and the loss of the non-derivative point of foundation.

Formal decolonization remains a fiction if one's own infrastructure for modeling one's future has not been formed.

The key obstacle is the fear of responsibility. The stable restoration of subjecthood requires: the formation of a language of responsibility, the existence of one's own practice of modeling one's own future,

the capacity to create a metaphysical instrumentarium that enables these competencies.

Why some subjects or communities are capable of forming such an infrastructure while others are not remains an open question.

IV. AEON AND ESCHATON

Christian ontology of time distinguishes four periods:

From the creation of the world to the Fall.

From the Fall to the Incarnation.

The middle aeon — between the First and the Second Coming.

The Eschaton.

For the CTM project, the following is fundamental:

At the Fall, not only human nature was corrupted; the entire universe was subjected to decay. In the Resurrection — the culminating act of the Incarnation — human nature was healed, yet entropy continues to reign in the material world.

The subject has been granted access to reality, but this access is not automatic. It requires ontological mobilization and readiness for the redistribution of foundation.

Having discovered the limit of its expansion, a subject with a high quality of ontology seeks a predicate—a relation that secures the maximum of its development.

In the text of CTM, this messianic technology is called ontological re-addressing. It implies a change in the ultimate foundation of the subject's being. In the context of this investigation, this means that the subject recognizes the incarnate God-Logos as the ultimate foundation of its being.

Thus, the middle aeon—our aeon—is the space of subject-responsibility. The entropy of the world does not abolish the possibility of the ontological act; it underscores it.

Operationally, we observe two poles of tension.

The middle aeon is the space of tension.
The Eschaton is the space of fixation.

In the aeon, re-addressing is possible.
In the Eschaton, only stabilization of the chosen direction is possible.

The present aeon is characterized by a logos-avoiding, competitive ontology. The Eschaton presupposes a logos-centric, solidaric ontology. The Incarnation reveals the Logos as the principle of the ordering of being. It opens new perspectives for the subject. Relation to the Logos—rootedness in the Logos—grants subjectivity: stable orientation, inner integration, the capacity to sustain scale without disintegration, expansion of freedom without arbitrariness.

FOUNDATION

In CTM, foundation denotes the active structural grounding of the subject's being. It does not refer merely to a static basis, origin, or presupposition. Rather, it signifies the dynamic configuration through which the center of grounding is established, sustained, or redistributed. Foundation determines the regime of being in which the subject exists. Changes in foundation imply changes in ontological position. The loss, simulation, delegation, or redistribution of foundation correspond to different ontological modes (e.g., ontology of the act or ontology of fiction).

Thus, foundation in CTM is a structural and operative category, not a metaphorical or purely epistemic one.

ONTOLOGICAL ACT

An ontological act is an action that changes or sustains the regime of the subject's being at the level of its foundation, and not merely its empirical state.

An act is ontological when it touches the center of foundation and redistributes or sustains it without reduction.

ONTOLOGY OF THE ACT

The ontology of the act is a regime of being in which the subject sustains reality through ontological mobilization without neutralizing the ultimate horizon and without delegating foundation.

In this regime, participation in being is real rather than simulated. The subject preserves its non-derivative point of foundation and assumes the burden of foundation.

ONTOLOGY OF FICTION

The ontology of fiction is a regime of being in which stability is achieved through reduction of the horizon and simulation of participation in foundation.

Here, foundation is either declared autonomous without possessing ontological power, or transferred to an external center without a personal ontological act.

Fiction does not eliminate the question of foundation; it merely masks it.

QUALITY OF ONTOLOGY

The quality of ontology is the degree of correspondence between the subject's regime of being and the fullness of reality.

The quality of ontology serves as the criterion for distinguishing the ontology of the act from the ontology of fiction.

It is determined by:

the capacity to sustain the infinite horizon,

refusal to reduce foundation,

preservation of the non-derivative point of foundation,

readiness for ontological mobilization.

A decline in the quality of ontology manifests as a transition to a lowered regime of being — toward reduction, derivativity, and fiction.

KEY TERMS OF THE PROJECT “CHRISTIANS OF THE THIRD MILLENNIUM”

Logocentric ontology
Logofugal ontology
Competitive ontology
Solidaric ontology
Ontological stop
Ontological re-addressing
Decolonization of personality
Faith as competence
Personal eschatology
Re-actualization of the Church
Liturgy as an ontological process
Quality of ontology
Ontology of the subject

Afterword

The reader could not have failed to notice the heterogeneity of the texts in this collection.

This difference is not accidental and is not due solely to the history of their composition. Any attempt to homogenize the language of the corpus would entail the loss of the very object of which it speaks.

The abrupt transition from analytical language to almost homiletic language — and back again — may be perceived as a stylistic rupture. However, this rupture does not belong to the text alone. To a significant extent, it reflects the very reality within which ecclesial existence is carried out.

For this reason, the heterogeneity of the corpus is a condition of its adequacy.

The reader will not be mistaken in assuming that what they hold in their hands are texts differing in form. However, it would be more precise to say that what is at stake is not different texts, but different states of one and the same process. If this difference is perceived as a rupture that obscures internal unity, then the process in question has not yet become evident.

If, however, it begins to be read as coherent despite its external irreducibility, then the distinction for the sake of which this corpus was written has, to some degree, taken place.